The Truth of Life

Understanding Life · The Truth of Life

Views on Life · The Six Realms of Rebirth · Karma & Causation · Planning One’s Life

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Chapter One: Understanding Life

What is life? Where do we go after death? Why should we believe in cause and effect? This chapter begins by contrasting four different views of life, then peels back layer by layer the truth of the cycle of rebirth through the six realms (samsara), and finally corroborates it through both official history and research outside the Buddhist tradition.

I. The Life-View of Contemporary Chinese (the One-Life View)

Let us first explain what is meant by the one-life view and the two-life view. As the name suggests, the one-life view holds that our life spans only a single lifetime. That is to say, what we call life is just the stretch from birth to death; before birth there is absolutely no 'me,' and death means the complete end of 'me' as a mode of existence. Complete, meaning the end of both the material and the mental. Those who hold the one-life view believe life is this one life alone. Today, nearly the great majority of ordinary Chinese people hold the one-life view. What are the characteristics of such people?

According to estimates from several authoritative bodies in 2026, the world population was about 8.2 billion that year, and China about 1.4 billion; yet industry statistics show Chinese consumers accounted for nearly half of global luxury spending.

Therefore he cannot understand why, during the few decades he is alive, he should do things that benefit others at no benefit to himself, or why he should not do things that benefit himself at others' expense; he finds no theoretical basis for it. Why can't I make gutter oil? Why can't I use the shortest time and any means necessary to seize the greatest profit? Thus one can understand that if the proportion of people in a country, or even a nation, who believe the one-life view is too high, that society's morality is bound to suffer.

So from the perspective of the one-life view, those who emulate Lei Feng are thoroughly the losers. Believers in the one-life view think that when a person dies it is like a lamp going out; however much good or evil one has done, at death it all resets to zero, and so they strive for the greatest gain within their limited time.

II. The Christian View of Life (the Two-Life View)

Next we discuss the two-life view. Western Christianity believes in the two-life view; Christianity holds that death is not the end of life. Death is the death of the body, but the soul does not die. What happens if it does not die? Christianity says you must not be impatient; you must wait, and wait, and wait! The soul must wait until the end of the world. Christians believe that all who have ever come into the world will be reborn on the day of the world's end. After rebirth they must face judgment by the supreme being, God, who may sentence you to heaven or to hell.

Does God have any basis when he judges us? A great portion of Christian scripture is devoted to discussing the basis of judgment; distilled to its essence, the most important points are four:

(1) During the few decades of the life you live, do you believe or not believe in the existence of God. If during those decades you simply do not believe God exists, then according to Christian doctrine, at the world's end God will surely show you no mercy and sentence you to hell. Within Christianity this is called 'believe in the Lord and be saved.' Without believing in the Lord one cannot enter heaven; this is an iron law that cannot be changed. This is the first point.

(2) Not only must you believe in God's existence, you must also believe that God once sent his son Jesus into our world to suffer on behalf of all beings, to atone for our sins, the one who was nailed to the cross. He is the son of God, not God himself. Christianity holds that you must believe not only in God but also in this son of his. Some believe only in God and not in Jesus; that is Judaism, believed by the Israelites. One of the greatest differences between Judaism and Christianity is precisely whether one believes in Jesus. Christianity holds that one must believe in both God and Jesus.

(3) Christianity holds that all of us come into this world carrying sin; every person bears original sin. Therefore Christians must constantly and unceasingly repent of their sins, so repentance is an important duty for Christians. Not only must they repent of past sins, they must also refrain from committing new ones. Hence Christian precepts are very strict. They constrain not only behavior but also thought. For instance, even if you have not in action killed a person, but a thought arises that you want to kill him, though there is no action and only this thought, it is still sin. So Christian precepts are extremely strict. To sum up:

1 Believe in God

2 Believe in Jesus

3 Repent constantly

4 Live according to the precepts.

If one does what is forbidden, then later there is no possibility of entering heaven. For example, one who makes gutter oil cannot enter heaven.

As for Christianity, the early Bible also mentions rebirth. According to the Bible, the prophet Elijah would come again; in the New Testament Jesus also said that John the Baptist was the Elijah who was to come. Because the Bible's records concerning rebirth touch on the matter of cause and effect, there is later tradition of excision. Buddhist writings often mention that an empress of the Eastern Roman Empire, unwilling to accept the doctrine of karmic retribution, advocated removing the relevant scriptures. This is a story circulating within the tradition; scholars hold different views.

III. The Life-View of the Ancient Chinese (the Two-Life View)

Chinese culture speaks of yin and yang. How did the ancient Chinese, profoundly shaped by yin-yang culture, understand life? The ancients divided the states of life into yin and yang, calling the world we live in the 'yang world' and the world after death the 'yin world.' So when a person dies it is like moving house, from the yang world to the yin world; this notion already has a flavor of the two-life view. But it differs somewhat from Christianity: Christianity requires facing judgment, whereas the ancient Chinese thought that upon death one simply moves house. Thus the ancient Chinese believed that grandfathers and grandmothers, once dead, are in the yin world, and if we die we go to meet our grandparents. For example, one who believes this view, while alive, to whom is his conduct accountable in this life? It is accountable to the ancestors. Our ancient Chinese often said, 'Ah, in what you do you must be worthy of your ancestors,' and why? Because according to this view, if you do evil in the yang world, then in the yin world you cannot answer to your forebears; grandfather will say, you did so much evil in the yang world, bringing disgrace upon this clan and this bloodline, and grandfather will be angry. Grandfather's anger is a small matter, but if in the yang world you are utterly wicked beyond pardon, then in the yin world it is not a matter of grandfather's anger; grandfather will cast you out of the family, the clan will have no place for you, and what are you then in the yin world?

A lonely ghost wandering the streets of the yin world is quite miserable. So according to this ancient Chinese view of life, our present conduct is accountable to the ancestors. Therefore, in order to face the line of ancestors well, people will conduct themselves properly in the world. Another expression of belief in the two-life view is lavish burial, because they believe the grave is the house in the yin world; thus the Chinese bury the things they liked in the earth for lavish burial, meaning you can keep using them in the yin world. For instance, people and objects were buried as companions. Burning paper money for the ancestors at the Qingming tomb-sweeping is also an expression of the Chinese belief in the two-life view.

IV. The Buddhist View of Life (the Three-Life View)

The three-life view is a Buddhist theory. Buddhism holds that death is not the complete end of life; death is merely the discarding of the physical body, while the mental factor does not die. When Indian culture reached China we translated this as the 'spirit-consciousness' (also called the soul or hun-po). This spirit-consciousness does not die; what happens if it does not die? It must through rebirth transform into the next living being and return to this world. After returning, your lifespan is still limited; you live a while and must die again; after death the spirit-consciousness discards this body and through rebirth transforms into a new living being and returns again. After returning, the lifespan is still limited; life is die-and-return, die-and-return, die-and-return, without end, without limit. This is Buddhism's unique understanding of life. Judging from this form, Buddhism holds that life is endless; we call this many-lives view the three-life view.

The so-called three-life view refers to the past, present, and future, that is, previous life, this life, and the next life. Buddhism holds that there is this present lifetime, a future lifetime, and beyond that yet another future lifetime. We revolve around these three lives, which is the so-called 'three-life view,' circulating without cease.

The three-life view determines the character of Buddhism. Buddhism not only has the three-life view; it also holds that life is suffering, whether you are rich or poor. Many of us Chinese have also come to believe the three-life view. For instance, one who believes the two-life view will say that if you do no good you will be unable to face your ancestors. But one who believes the three-life view will say that if you do no good you will become a dog in your next life. In saying this, he has already assented to the three-life view of life. For among the three great categories of life-view, only the three-life view can connect a person after death with a dog. You see, in our ancient Chinese literary works there are often such descriptions: a man on the execution ground about to be beheaded, yet upright and unafraid of death, says that in eighteen years he will be a good man again. The one who says such things has in fact assented to the three-life view.

For only with the three-life view can a person after death be connected with being a 'good man.' Of course this person feels quite certain, thinking his next life will surely be human, and surely male. But from the Buddhist perspective, after we die the certainty of our next-life form is not so great. Believers in the three-life view believe that a person's death is not an end, that life circulates infinitely in samsara; this is the life-view generally accepted by Buddhist disciples. Having said all this, we have respectively the one-, two-, and three-life views. Surely there is only one truth; which one should we believe is the sole truth? Please keep your curiosity and continue reading.

V. The Truth of Samsara (the Suffering of Samsara)

The two most fundamental premises of Buddhism are the cycle of rebirth through the six realms and the law of cause and effect (karma). The so-called suffering of samsara means that beings revolve in birth and death within the three realms and six paths; no matter in which realm or path, it is all the fruit of suffering.

(1) Where Do We Go After Death

What is samsara? We are human in this life; who am I? Where did I come from? Where will I go after death? This is a question every religion must answer. Ordinary people merely pursue comfort and enjoyment in life and may not value this question. Yet as they grow older, many may reflect on what life is really about, and some thereby make a choice and turn to the religious path. Then is religion after all superstition? Religion has its superstitious parts and its non-superstitious parts; so too does science: many believe in science, yet science has its superstitious parts and its non-superstitious parts. Because scientists' theories are often overturned by later generations, what you absolutely believe is not necessarily right! Why say this? Because when many things in this world are beyond your ability to discern, you can only listen first, and you must harbor doubt, a question mark.

Then use your own ability and wisdom to judge whether it is correct. If you have no ability to judge, you can only rely wholly on belief. Some of the questions of life that religion often discusses usually transcend the capacity of ordinary people, and this involves the matter of faith. Buddhism speaks of the six realms of samsara hoping to let us know and understand for ourselves. A person cannot be convinced by a few words. One must, according to what the Buddha taught, observe and verify from many angles to find the correct answer. As long as we patiently seek verification, the Dharma can be proven.

The meaning of samsara is this: your present life is neither a beginning nor an end. Beings flowing and turning within birth and death is precisely the phenomenon of cyclic rebirth; you have had many past lives, born and dying, dying and born, until this life. Then, when you die in this life, birth and death will continue. In modern language, beings' repeated births and deaths are samsara within the six realms. If birth and death were only ever being human, that would not yet count as samsara. The samsara expounded by Buddhism has 'six realms'; your next life may not again be reborn as a human; because of past good and evil causes and effects, you may become another kind of life. Buddhism divides the life after returning into six categories, also called the six realms (sometimes called the five destinies); which six? We will mention later.

When did the concept of samsara begin? Since ancient times some Chinese have believed in the six realms of samsara. Some mythic tales describe devas (heavens) coming to the human world, and spirits and demons also coming to make trouble in the human world; in fact this is a kind of exposition of samsara.



Figure 1. The Wheel of Samsara (Thangka painting)

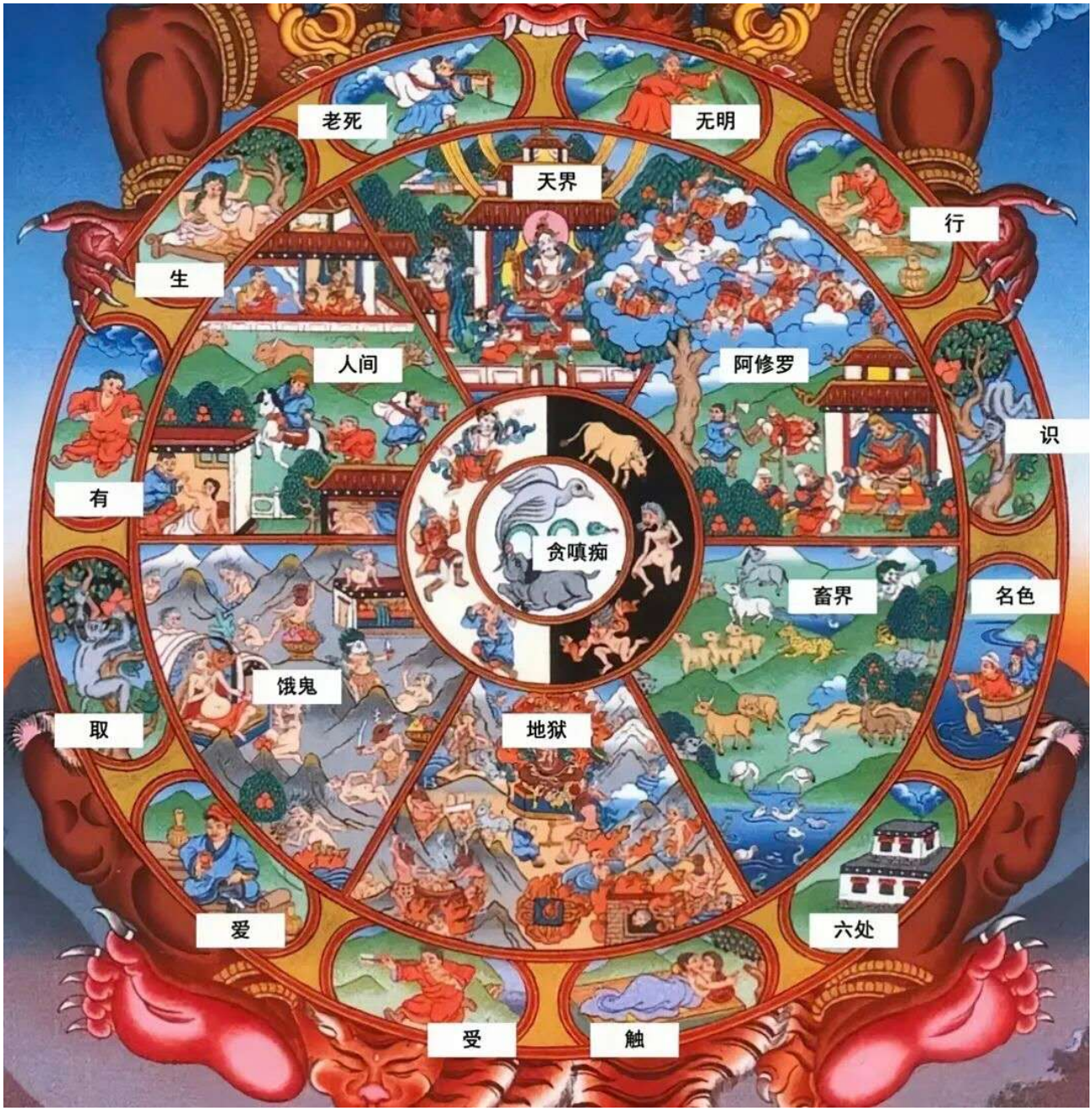


Figure 2. The Wheel of Samsara (mural in a Tibetan monastery)

(2) An Illustrated Explanation of the Six Realms of Samsara

This diagram is a teaching aid for explaining birth-death and cause-effect, commonly seen in Tibetan monastery murals and thangkas. It is not merely a depiction of the world after death, but a complete illustration of the principles of life. The whole picture can be divided into three great parts: the outer ring of the Lord of Death, the four-layered wheel, and the liberation teaching outside the wheel, to be read layer by layer from inside out.

I. The Outermost Layer: Yama (the Lord of Death) Embracing the Whole Wheel

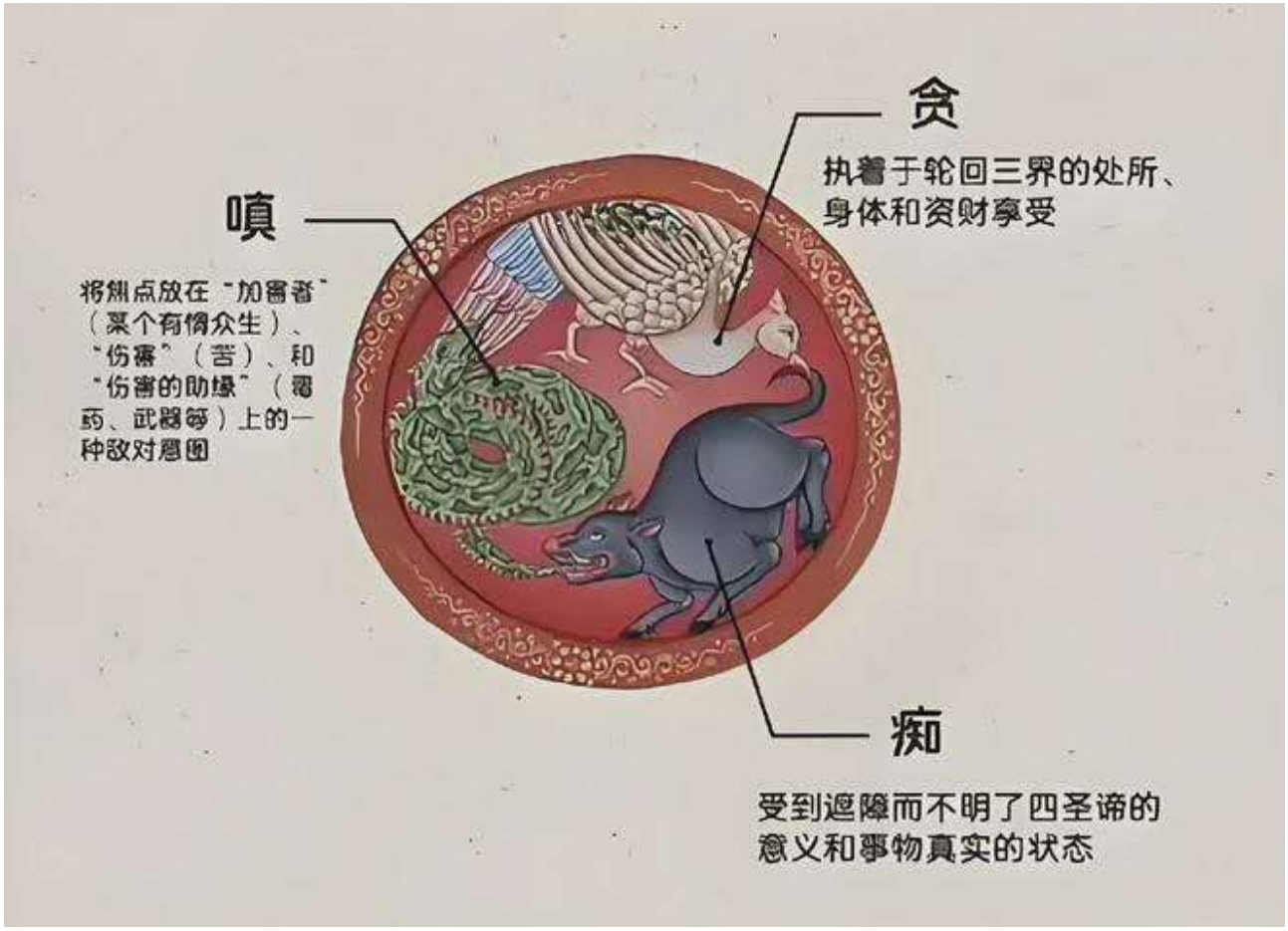
The blue-faced, fanged Yama clasps with both hands and bites the whole circular wheel with his mouth.

Meaning: He is not a great judging deity, but symbolizes impermanence, death, and the law of karma. No matter how great one's blessings, as long as one remains in samsara, one cannot escape aging and death; all beings are bound by afflictions and karma within the cycle of birth and death, unable to free themselves.

Key point: Yama himself is also within samsara, not a god who governs fate; fate is determined by the karma one oneself has created.

II. The First Layer of the Wheel (the very center): the Three Poisons (greed, hatred, delusion), the engine of samsara

In the central circle are drawn three animals, head to tail, biting in a cycle:



1. Dove (or rooster) = greed: clinging to wealth, love, and enjoyment, never satisfied.

2. Snake = hatred: anger, resentment, the mind to harm; upon adversity immediately arises enmity, harming others and self.

3. Pig = delusion (ignorance): fundamental stupidity, unable to see the truth of the world, unable to distinguish good from evil or suffering from joy; greed and hatred both arise from delusion. In the picture the dove and snake emerge from the pig's mouth, which is this meaning.

III. The Second Ring: Black and White Halves, the Rise and Fall of Karma

The second circle outward from the center is divided into a white half and a black half.

- White half-ring: the heads of beings face upward. It represents wholesome karma such as doing good, giving, and upholding precepts; life tends toward ease and rebirth in the three good realms.

- Black half-ring: the heads of beings face downward. It represents unwholesome karma such as killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, and false speech; one falls downward, reborn in the three evil realms.

Meaning: there is no heaven arbitrarily arranging fortune or misfortune; every thought and action is karma, determining the direction of the next life, so beings' suffering and joy are all self-created and self-experienced.

IV. The Third Ring (the main body of the picture): the Six Realms, six forms of living existence

Six spokes divide this ring into six regions, the three good realms and the three evil realms. In each realm is painted a Buddha. The meaning is that even in an evil realm, the Buddha-nature is not lost, and there is always the chance to be taught and awaken.

The three good realms (great blessings, but still in samsara, suffering not yet exhausted)

1. The Deva Realm

Greatest blessings, long life, enjoyment, beautiful surroundings. The greatest danger: indulging in pleasure and neglecting practice; once blessings are exhausted, one immediately falls, and joy ends in sorrow.

2. The Asura Realm: blessings almost equal to the devas, with ample power and wealth; but the mind of jealousy and bellicosity is extremely heavy, with endless strife and never any inner peace.

3. The Human Realm

Mixed suffering and joy, with the sufferings of aging, illness, and separation, yet also the opportunity to reflect, practice, and cut off afflictions. The Dharma holds that a human body is most rare, the realm most suited to practice and liberation.

The three evil realms (profound suffering)

1. The Animal Realm: dullness, enslavement, devouring one another, confused mind.

2. The Hungry Ghost Realm: forever hungry and thirsty, never obtaining what is sought, inwardly lacking and tormented.

3. The Hell Realm: the most intense suffering, the place of painful retribution summoned by extremely heavy unwholesome karma.

Key reminder: The six realms do not refer only to rebirth after death; in real life, a person's state of mind is at every moment in the condition of the six realms. Raging anger is like hell; unceasing greed is the hungry ghost; foolish blind following is like the animal.

V. The Fourth Layer (the outermost inner ring): the Twelve Links of Dependent Origination, explaining the complete chain of samsara

The outermost circle is divided into 12 small cells, each a small picture, representing the twelve links of dependent origination:

Ignorance to formations to consciousness to name-and-form to the six sense-doors to contact to feeling to craving to grasping to becoming to birth to old age and death.

Complete demonstration: starting from a single deluded thought, step by step arise mental impulses and karma-creation, then come birth, aging, and death, and after death delusion arises again, cycling without end.

It answers a core question: exactly how are beings trapped step by step within birth and death.

VI. Outside the Wheel: the Path of Liberation (the most important finishing touch of the whole picture)

Outside the great circular wheel is painted a Buddha, extending a hand pointing to a bright moon.

- Within the great wheel of samsara, all is flowing and suffering; outside the wheel is the state where one can leap out of samsara (nirvana).

- The moon represents the pure, affliction-free state of liberation; the Buddha as guide shows that samsara is not an inescapable cage.

Beside it is a common verse: Diligently cultivate precepts, concentration, and wisdom; extinguish greed, hatred, and delusion.

The way out is not to escape reality, but to purify one's own mind, extinguish the three poison afflictions of greed, hatred, and delusion, cut the chain of the twelve links, and transcend the six realms of samsara.

Summary of the Popular Essentials

1. Samsara is not some deity judging you; the root is the greed, hatred, and delusion in your own mind; all circumstances are the result of your own karma.

2. The devas' enjoyment and the hells' suffering are neither permanent; once blessings are spent or retribution exhausted, one still continues to be reborn in turn. Even ascending to heaven does not count as liberation.

3. The human body, with balanced suffering and joy, has the greatest chance to practice and leave samsara; the Pure Land tradition's teaching of rebirth in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss is precisely to depart from this six-realm cycle.

4. The true purpose of this picture is not to frighten the world, but to let people see clearly the afflictions and cause-effect, and thereby cultivate the mind, cut off delusion, and seek liberation.

(3) Signs of Samsara

Samsara concerns our previous and future lives, which we in this life cannot know. But is it possible to know? According to the Dharma, some people are able to know their previous lives. First let us understand some signs of samsara. The classification of life, that is, the classification of beings.

1 The supernatural phenomena of ghosts and spirits.

What ordinary people can see are the two categories of beings, humans and animals. We think humans are the spirit of all things, the highest animal. According to Buddhist theory, life is not only these; there are also beings invisible to humans; if you cannot see them, you cannot say they do not exist. For not seeing does not mean not existing. For instance, whether there are ghosts or not, you cannot say there are none just because you cannot see them. Air, electricity, radio waves, and so on are all invisible. You can learn from some who have encountered ghosts what they say. Of course, the ghosts spoken of in the Dharma differ from those spoken of by ordinary people.

So-called ghosts are a form of life among the six realms. For instance, some folk beliefs, such as spirit-medium possession, from the Buddhist perspective those so-called spirits are mostly ghosts (some ghosts with blessings), which attach to the medium's body to communicate with humans. These ghost-realm beings, by attaching to the medium, give the medium some precognitive ability, able to point the puzzled to clarity and at the same time assist people in handling matters, so many believe. Some people's homes show strange phenomena, and then they invite a cultivator to communicate with the ghost, and perhaps learn of an unfulfilled vow, and so on. Then the family, following the cultivator's instructions, settle some matters, and those strange phenomena never appear again. All this can be heard from those who have encountered supernatural phenomena, listening to their inconceivable experiences.

2 The strange behavior of animals.

Ancient China also has many tales about animals. Below are a few examples from ancient and modern times.

Selling the Pig, Selling the Son (Records of Hidden Retribution)

Original text: In the eighth year of the Daye reign of Sui, Huangfu Qian of Yizhou once stole sixty cash from his mother; the mother could not find the money and the whole family was flogged. The next year Qian died and was conceived in the belly of a pig in his own household; the pig grew and was sold to the family of a village head far away for six hundred cash. That night his wife had just fallen asleep when she dreamed the pig said, 'I am your husband; for taking sixty cash from mother I brought the whole family flogging, and was punished as a pig; unexpectedly I have been sold by you, so quickly redeem me, for if you are late I will be slaughtered.' The wife awoke, still not quite believing, soon fell asleep again and dreamed the same, the plea more urgent. She rose and knocked at her mother-in-law's door; the mother-in-law had long since risen, and each told her dream and they matched. It was already midnight, and the village head was thirty li away. The mother, fearing he would not allow redemption, took twelve hundred cash and sent the eldest son together with Qian's son. The village head, because the communal sacrifice was imminent, firmly refused. Relying on numbers and force by night they forcibly redeemed the pig, and the village head then released it. Passing through open country, the brother said to the pig, 'If truly my brother, go on ahead.' The pig went on ahead and reached home. Later the neighbors all mocked, and the children were ashamed, and privately said, 'Our father has become thus, bringing shame on us children; father was always close with Xu, why not send him to the Xu household, and we will bring food.' Hearing this the pig wept, wagged its tail and went to the Xu home, forty li away. In the eleventh year of Daye the pig died there.

Comment: Having changed head and face, the whole family fails to recognize him; thus the six kin are after all empty.

Vernacular paraphrase: In the eighth year of the Daye reign of Sui, Huangfu Qian of Yizhou stole sixty cash from his mother; the mother could not find the money and flogged the whole family. The next year Huangfu Qian died and was reborn as a pig in his own home; the pig grew and was sold to a faraway village head's family, who got six hundred cash. That night Huangfu Qian's wife had just lain down when she dreamed the sold pig said to her, 'I am your husband; because I stole sixty cash from mother I brought the whole family flogging, and for this unwholesome karma I was reborn as a pig after death; I never expected to be sold by you again. Please quickly redeem me and take me home, for if you are even a little late I will be slaughtered!' The wife awoke still not quite believing, and slept again, only to dream her husband's plea once more, more urgent than before. Huangfu Qian's wife rose and knocked at her mother-in-law's door; the mother-in-law had already been up for a long while, and each told her dream and they were exactly the same.

By then it was midnight, and the village head's home was thirty li away. Fearing the village head would refuse to redeem the pig, Huangfu Qian's mother took twelve hundred cash and sent the eldest son together with Huangfu Qian's son. Because the communal sacrifice was about to occur, the village head firmly refused to allow redemption. Taking advantage of night and relying on their numbers and influence, uncle and nephew prepared to force the redemption; seeing the situation unfavorable, the village head agreed to let them take the pig back. On the way home, passing through open country, Huangfu Qian's elder brother said to the pig, 'If you are truly my brother, you may go on ahead.' The pig, heeding his brother, walked ahead and arrived home early. When the neighbors learned of it they all mocked the family; the children, ashamed, privately said, 'Our father has become a pig and shamed us children before others; father was always on close terms with Xu, so why not send the pig to the Xu home, and we will bring it food on schedule.'

Hearing their words the pig was deeply grieved, wept, wagged its tail and went by itself to the Xu home forty li away. In the eleventh year of Daye the pig died at that place.

Comment: Once Huangfu Qian changed head and face and was reborn in a pig's body, the whole family failed to recognize him; thus the six kin, in the ultimate sense, are all illusory and unreal. (Transmitted from the Extended Meaning of Wenchang Emperor's Treatise on the Hidden Rules, in the Complete Works of Master Anshi)

Saving the Sheep, Saving the Daughter (Forest of Dharma Jewels)

Original text: The custom of Chang'an in the Tang dynasty was, each New Year's day, to feast in turn. A brush merchant Zhao Da was next to host. On the day guests arrived and saw on his mortar a girl of thirteen or fourteen bound with the well-rope, wearing a blue skirt and white shirt, weeping she told the guests, 'I am the host's daughter; in past years I stole a hundred cash from my parents, wishing to buy powder, and died before I could; the money is now in the northwest wall-hole of the kitchen, and I am now punished as a sheep.' Having spoken, the guests looked closely and saw a blue sheep with a white head; startled they told the host. The host asked her appearance, which matched his dead daughter, dead two years. Hastily they searched the kitchen and the money was still there. Thereupon they sent the sheep to a monk's dwelling, and the whole household observed vegetarian precepts.

Comment: The money was still there, yet the painful retribution already borne, is that not suffering punishment in vain? Of all things one cannot take along, only karma follows the self. How true.

Vernacular paraphrase: In the Tang dynasty, the custom of Chang'an (present-day Xi'an) was for households to feast and congratulate one another starting from New Year's day. It happened to be the brush merchant Zhao Da's turn to host. On the day of the feast, when guests arrived they saw on the mortar a girl of thirteen or fourteen bound with the well-drawing rope, wearing a blue skirt and white shirt, weeping as she told the guests, 'I am Zhao Da's daughter; in the past I stole a hundred cash from my parents, wishing to buy rouge and powder, and died before I could buy them; the money is still in the northwest corner wall-crevice of the kitchen, and for this unwholesome karma I am punished by rebirth as a sheep.' No sooner had she spoken than the guests looked closely and saw it was a blue sheep with a white head. Seeing this, they told Zhao Da in alarm. Zhao Da asked about the girl's appearance, and the description matched his deceased daughter exactly; she had been dead two years. They hurried to the kitchen to look for the money, and sure enough it was still there. Thereupon they sent the blue sheep to the monks to be released, and Zhao Da's whole family from then on observed vegetarian precepts and practiced Buddhism. (Transmitted from the Extended Meaning of Wenchang Emperor's Treatise on the Hidden Rules, in the Complete Works of Master Anshi)

Whipping the Horse, Whipping the Kin (Supplement to Records of Hidden Retribution)

Original text: In the Tang, Li Xin of Wenshui county in Bingzhou, a guard of the Longzheng government. In a winter of the Xianqing years, riding a red steed and leading a colt, he went by regulation to Shuozhou on frontier duty. The weather was severely cold; after traveling more than ten li the horse could not advance. Xin whipped it scores of times, and the horse spoke in a human voice, saying to Xin, 'I am your mother; in life I concealed from your father over a bushel of rice given to the youngest daughter, and thus now receive this retribution. This colt is your sister, also here to repay a debt.' Hearing this Xin wept bitterly, personally bore the saddle and bridle, and said to it, 'Since you are my mother, go home by yourself.' The horse went ahead and reached home. Xin's brothers made a separate stable to feed it, serving it as mother, often inviting monks for its sake and confessing, the whole household diligently cultivating. At that time the vice-minister of works Wen Wuyin and the judicial officer of Qizhou Zhang Jinting, both at home in mourning for parents, heard and were

amazed, came to inquire, and saw the horse was still there.

Comment: Of those with whom wealth may be shared, none are closer than spouse and children, yet still there is not the slightest borrowing thus. Then in the world, those parents with partial love and private favoritism, are truly chilling.

Vernacular paraphrase: In the Tang dynasty, Li Xin of Wenshui county in Bingzhou served as a guard of the Longzheng government. In a winter of the Xianqing years, Li Xin rode a red steed and led a colt, going by regulation to Shuozhou on garrison duty. The weather was severely cold; after traveling more than ten li the horse could not go on. Li Xin whipped the red steed scores of times, and the horse then spoke in a human voice to Li Xin, saying, 'I am your mother; because in life I concealed from your father over a bushel of rice given to the youngest daughter, I have thus received this retribution. This colt is your sister, also reborn as a horse to repay a debt.' Hearing this Li Xin was deeply grieved; he bore the saddle and bridle and said to the horse, 'If you are truly my mother, please find your own way home!' The horse truly went ahead by itself and returned home. Li Xin's brothers built a new stable to feed and care for the horse, serving it as their own mother, often inviting monks on its behalf to confess and transfer merit, and the whole family resolved to study Buddhism and cultivate diligently. At that time the vice-minister of works Wen Wuyin and the judicial officer of Qizhou Zhang Jinting were both at home mourning their parents; hearing of this they were greatly amazed and came to Li Xin's home to see, and found the horse was still there.

Comment: Of those with whom wealth may be shared, none are closer than husband and wife and children, yet still there can be no slightest misuse. Then those parents in the world who have partial aversion or partial love and privately favor one over another are truly chilling to the heart! (Transmitted from the Extended Meaning of Wenchang Emperor's Treatise on the Hidden Rules, in the Complete Works of Master Anshi)

(4) On Xiao Po Hainan Street in Singapore there was a gold shop, opposite which was a coffee shop. The coffee shop owner kept a dog, but every night this dog would run across to guard the door for the gold shop owner. Customers teased the coffee shop owner for keeping a dog that ate from one home and served another. The more the customers talked, the angrier the owner grew, and he scolded the dog for being ungrateful and forgetful of kindness. That night the dog appeared in the owner's dream and said, 'In my previous life I was so-and-so, a clerk at the gold shop; because I stole a little money from the shop, I fell in this life and became a dog. To repay the debt, every night I go over to help guard the door.' In the dream the owner asked how much the dog owed; the dog said only a few dollars. The next morning the coffee shop owner took some money and gave it to the dog to carry and return to the gold shop. From then on the dog no longer went to guard the door. Stories like this can be heard in many places; they illustrate the various signs of rebirth.

3 Some inborn abilities come from previous lives.

Furthermore, some people after birth need not study with great effort; once taught they easily learn. From the Buddhist perspective, this is because they learned it in a previous life and still remember in this life. Some people, upon meeting, feel the other is familiar, as if they had met somewhere before. Or one may like some people for no reason, or dislike some people for no reason. From the Buddhist perspective, that is a karmic connection between you and him in a past life. Moreover, some animals at birth have the instinct to survive, knowing without teaching how they should live. For example, a small sea turtle at birth knows to crawl toward the sea, swim into it, and flee for survival. This shows the sea turtle carries some memory of how to survive; this is what the Dharma calls the karmic habit (the similar-flow habit) brought along in the stream of transmigration. If one says human memory is stored in DNA, yet the inheritance of parents' DNA yields children with different karmic habits; and why would the children of non-genius parents have the DNA of a

genius? Thus each person, through their own karmic causes and the condition of parents, brings about the relevant DNA.

4 Past-life regression under hypnosis.

There are also reports that some people under hypnosis often speak of their previous lives' experiences and states. Some have investigated based on these previous-life data, and the results confirm it truly happened; this too is proof of the cycle of life and death.

5 Supernormal recollection.

Some people through cultivation gain spiritual powers (abhijna) able to know matters of past and future lives. These people will tell you that in a past life you were so-and-so, or they have the ability to know that a certain person of a past life was reborn as who in this life. If one learns more about reports of rebirth cases, there are very, very many such stories of samsara. One cannot deny it simply because one lacks the ability to prove it.

6 The authoritative testimony (agama) says there is samsara (what the Buddha said is called authoritative testimony).

The Dharma says our sources of knowledge about the world are three:

A: Direct perception (pratyaksa), knowledge gained from one's own practical intuition and sensation;

B: Inference (anumana), knowledge gained from hearing;

C: Authoritative testimony (agama), knowledge expounded for us by sages; in religion it refers to the revelation of religious sages, and in the secular sphere it refers to principles unattainable by human intellect that can be obtained from religious scriptures. Among these, the classics of Indian Brahmanism, Buddhism, Daoism, and even Christianity all speak of rebirth. We often think knowledge gained from the sense organs is the most direct and intimate, but that is not necessarily true. In this world many things seen with the eyes or heard with the ears are not necessarily right. What our eyes can see is only the visible light of 380nm to 760nm, just 4 percent of the spectrum family. What we can hear is only sound waves in the frequency range of 20 to 20,000 hertz. To do otherwise would be extremely irresponsible toward one's own life.

7 The mystery of the intermediate existence (the forgetting between lives).

From the perspective of the Dharma, we have flowed from past lives many times to this life. Someone will surely ask: if so, why do I know nothing of my previous lives?

We beings are bewildered by the immediate sphere, by which is meant the sphere seen and heard by our eyes and ears. When with a bewildered mind we observe the immediate sphere through eyes and ears, because of bewilderment we forget our inherent wisdom, and so believe the illusions aroused by the six sense-roots such as eyes and ears, while remaining ignorant of the truth beyond the immediate sphere. Therefore we think that this life is thus, and that what is seen and heard is real. For instance, when watching a movie, the whole body and mind throw themselves into the plot and forget that one is watching a play, and temporarily forget that beyond the play there is the existence of the world. According to the Dharma, in the course of this flowing, once we are conceived in the mother's womb, we forget the memory of previous lives; this is the so-called mystery of the intermediate existence. We cannot even remember our childhood memories, let alone past lives. Only a few who cultivated relatively well in past lives will remember some.

8. Character, appearance, and intelligence have former causes.

Furthermore, each person's character and appearance differ from those of the parents. Why? Because character and appearance are not absolutely determined by parental inheritance; it is evident they are influenced by other

conditions, and these conditions are related to your own past life. Since they are conditions related to you, this shows that before you were even born some conditions already influenced you. That you receive such a result in this life shows that indeed some conditions influenced you, so there is rebirth, there is a previous life. Some say it is genetic inheritance, but children born of the same father and mother, twins and so on, differ in wisdom, health, and character, showing that besides the parents there are also the individual's own former causes. The karma of past lives creates the due retribution of this life; within that retribution are such a family and such parents, and the due appearance and intelligence of this life, and so the body has such genes.

9. The affinities of this life were formed in past lives.

According to the Dharma, everyone and everything we meet in our life are phenomena brought by the cause and effect of past flowing. This rebirth phenomenon occurs not only when a person is reborn, but also in the daily life of this life; for instance, sometimes a person will dislike someone for no reason, or will also like someone very much. On a first meeting, of course, there is no influence of any factor from this life; it is only the memory of your past life at work. If a person has never encountered these phenomena, it is hard to persuade him to believe in rebirth by a few words alone, so one must contact and learn about the relevant reports oneself. In fact there are quite many scientists at home and abroad doing research on these matters. Ian Stevenson of the University of Virginia collected over 3,000 complete and verifiable cases. Raymond Moody's Life After Life is a wise book exploring death and near-death experience. Mary Roach's Spook: Science Tackles the Afterlife asks whether death is a permanent end or the beginning of another life; does immortality exist? This is a puzzle that has long troubled humanity. In this book the author records humanity's historical exploration of the soul, and personally conducted a year-long exploration, from villages in India to British medium schools, from the Cambridge University library to Duke University medical school, from the consciousness research lab at Laurentian University to rural Carolina, and on to the operating rooms of the University of Virginia.

(Appendix) Synopsis of Raymond Moody's Life After Life:

Life After Life is a wise book exploring death and near-death experience. The author Raymond Moody heard a psychiatrist tell of the strange events he experienced when he 'died' and came back, and while teaching a university course on Plato's 'immortality of the soul' heard many students tell similar stories, and was greatly shocked, whereupon he devoted himself to the study of the phenomenon. In Life After Life, the author interviewed, directly or indirectly, 150 people with such experiences, summarized 15 common elements, and for the first time proposed the concept of near-death experience (NDE). In addition, the author compares it with important philosophical discussions of the afterlife in human history, and lists psychological and natural-scientific explanations of the phenomenon; the logic is clear and the exposition detailed, greatly adding to the book's scientific and philosophical depth, provoking deep thought.

Upon its release the book caused a sensation and initiated a worldwide research upsurge among scientists on near-death experience. Although at first many in the medical world sneered at it, now science has come over to Dr. Moody's side. More than thirty years later, the book is still continually reprinted, translated into many languages, and sold tens of millions of copies worldwide; it is truly a classic work in the field. The whole book is vivid, beautiful, and philosophical; after reading, it not only lets everyone reconsider death, but also cherish the present life more.

Highlights:

Separation from the body

Most of the time we equate the self with our body, which seems self-evident. We of course also acknowledge a 'mind,' but for most people, compared with the body, our mind seems even more fleeting and perishable. Because the mind may be merely the electrochemical reaction of the brain, it belongs to a part of the body. Many people find it hard to imagine, if the mind is not in the body, where it could be.

The people I interviewed, before undergoing the death experience, were no different in attitude from ordinary people, which is why passing through a dark tunnel often astonishes the dying. At that time he may watch his own body from somewhere outside it, like a 'spectator' or a 'third party in the room,' or like watching the roles and plot 'on a stage' or 'in a movie.' Let us see how they describe the weird scene of leaving the body.

When I was seventeen, I worked at an amusement park with my brother. One afternoon we decided to go swimming, and many young friends went with us. Someone said, 'Let's swim to the other side of the lake.' I had swum across several times, but that day somehow I got submerged past my head in the middle of the lake. As I floated and sank in the water, suddenly I felt myself separate from my body, leaving everyone, alone in a space. I stayed calmly in one place, watching my body drift in the water a meter away. I saw my body lying sideways in the water. Although I had left my body, I still felt I had the shape of a body. At the time there was an indescribable light, floating feeling; I felt like a feather.

A woman recalled: About a year ago I was sent to the hospital for heart disease. The next morning, lying in bed, I felt a sharp pain in my chest, pressed the button by my bed to call the nurse, and they came in and began to resuscitate me. I was very uncomfortable lying in bed, so I turned over, but immediately stopped breathing and my heart stopped. Then I heard the nurse shout, 'Code Pink! Code Pink!' As they shouted, I felt myself leave my original body, drifting down between the mattress and the bed frame. I seemed to pass through the bed frame and float to the floor. Then I slowly rose. As I floated up, I saw more nurses rush into the room, about a dozen. My doctor happened to be making rounds; they called him and soon he arrived at the ward too. I thought, 'What can he do here?' I floated up past the lamp and clearly saw its side, then stopped, floating and looking down from the ceiling. I felt like a piece of paper blown to the ceiling.

From above I saw them doing CPR on me! My body lay stiff on the bed, and they surrounded it. I heard a nurse say, 'Oh my God! She's gone!' Another nurse leaned over to give me artificial respiration. As she resuscitated me, I saw the back of her head. I will never forget the look of her hair, a short style. I saw them wheel in a machine and shock my chest, I saw my body bounce off the bed, and heard every bone inside the body crackle.

That was the most terrifying thing! I saw them down there pounding my chest, kneading my arms and legs, and I thought, 'What on earth are they doing? I am fine.' A young respondent said: About two years ago, I had just turned nineteen. I was driving a friend home, passed a downtown intersection, stopped to look both ways, but did not notice something speeding toward me. I accelerated through the intersection, and my friend's scream came to my ear.

Then I saw a dazzling light, the headlight of an oncoming car.

I heard a terrible sound; the side of the car was heavily hit. In that instant, I seemed to pass through a dark, enclosed space in the blink of an eye. Then I floated above the street, about one or two meters from the car. The crash sound gradually faded; I saw people run over and surround the car. I saw my friend climb out of the car, clearly frightened. I saw my body lying in the wreckage, and people trying to pull it out.

My legs were twisted and deformed, blood everywhere.

Perhaps someone will think, people in such danger will inevitably have some strange thoughts and feelings.

Many people cannot imagine what it means to leave the body; even if they experienced it themselves, conceptually it is still a mess, and it takes a long time to connect it with death. They wonder what happened to them, why suddenly they are watching themselves from afar like a spectator.

People's emotional reactions to this strange state vary. Most say that at first they were anxious to return to their body but did not know how; some recall they were very afraid. But some also responded to their predicament more positively, as in the following account:

I was very ill, and the doctor arranged for me to be hospitalized. That morning, a thick fog arose around, and I left my body. When I felt separated from my shell, there was a floating feeling. I looked back and saw myself lying on the hospital bed below; my heart was not alarmed or afraid, but felt calm and peaceful. I was not at all depressed or fearful. It was a quiet feeling; I need not worry or fear. I knew I might die; if I could not return to my body, I would die.

Different people's attitudes toward the body they left behind also differ greatly. It is normal to show worry about one's own body. There was a young girl who, when she experienced the death event, was still a nursing student, so her fear is understandable.

I know it is a bit ridiculous, but in nursing school they instilled in us that we should donate our bodies to scientific research. But when I saw them trying to make me breathe, I kept thinking, 'I do not want them to dissect my body.' I have heard two others say they had the same worry when leaving the body. And interestingly, they were both in medical work, one a doctor and one a nurse.

In another case, this worry turned into regret. A person severely injured by a fall, leading to cardiac arrest, recalled: For a while, I knew I was lying on the hospital bed, but could not really see the bed and the doctor caring for me. Somehow, I saw my body lying on the bed, saw its bloody and mangled appearance, and my whole heart clenched.

In addition, scholars such as Professor Zhu Qingshi of the University of Science and Technology of China and Professor Poon Chung-kwong, former president of the Hong Kong Polytechnic University, have also discussed the issues of life and consciousness from the perspective of dialogue between science and Buddhism.

(4) Which are the six realms of the six realms

The so-called 'six realms' are the deva realm, the human realm, the asura realm, the animal realm, the hungry ghost realm, and the hell realm.

First, the deva realm, the deva beings, or simply devas. Obviously the devas' blessings are very great. The deva realm has the formless, form, and desire-sphere heavens; the formless and form-sphere heavens require cultivation to the four dhyanas and eight concentrations to be born there, while the desire sphere requires desire-sphere concentration and cultivation of the ten wholesome deeds (no killing, no stealing, no sexual misconduct, no false speech, no frivolous speech, no divisive speech, no harsh speech, no greed, no hatred, no delusion) to be born there. Devas can be divided into three kinds:

The first kind, desire-sphere devas, like humans enjoy sexual desire and sensory pleasure, called desire-sphere beings. The dwellings of desire-sphere devas are not all floating in the clouds; they can be divided into two kinds: earth-dwelling devas and space-dwelling devas. Buddhist scriptures record that the devas who interact more with us humans are the 'Four Heavenly Kings' and the 'Trayastrimsa' (the thirty-three heavens). Beings reborn in the first desire-sphere heaven, the Four Heavenly Kings, have a lifespan of five hundred years, one day and night of which is fifty years of the human world. Beings who cultivate better are reborn in the second

heaven, Trayastrimsa, with a lifespan of one thousand years, one day and night of which is one hundred years of the human world. These two kinds of devas have the ability to see us, but we cannot see them. Above them are successively the Yama heaven, the Tusita heaven, the Nirmanarati heaven, and the Para-nirmitavasavartin heaven; higher heavens can see lower heavens, but lower heavens cannot see higher heavens.

The third heaven is called the Yama heaven, lifespan two thousand years, one day and night of which is two hundred years of the human world. The fourth heaven is called the Tusita heaven, lifespan four thousand years, one day and night of which is four hundred years of the human world. The fifth heaven is called the Nirmanarati heaven, lifespan eight thousand years, one day and night of which is eight hundred years of the human world. The sixth heaven is called the Para-nirmitavasavartin heaven, lifespan sixteen thousand years, one day and night of which is sixteen hundred years of the human world. The higher the heaven, the longer the lifespan and the more the enjoyment, and this is the fruit of the heavens. The last life of a bodhisattva before attaining Buddhahood dwells in the inner court of the Tusita heaven, and when conditions mature descends from Tusita to the human world to become a Buddha. The devas of the Four Heavenly Kings and Trayastrimsa are closest to the human world, therefore they govern the human-realm and ghost-realm beings of the human world. Other devas do not care about human affairs and do not interact with humans.

The second kind, form-sphere devas, do not crave the pleasures of the desire sphere, regarding them as suffering; they are in meditation, taking the joy of meditation as food, experiencing the mind's happiness within concentration, which is very happy. The pleasure felt through the sense organs comes from contact with external objects. For instance, when you touch smooth skin with the tactile sense and feel comfortable, that comfort is felt from the external object. But the happiness in meditation is completely unrelated to external objects, purely the happiness of one's own inner mind. If such a being's body still exists, it enters deep concentration, with a very happy mind; this kind is called form-sphere being.

The third kind, formless-sphere devas, have no body, only the existence of the spirit-consciousness and inner feeling; this kind is called formless-sphere being. The concentration power of formless-sphere beings is stronger than that of form-sphere beings.

Second, the human realm, that is, we humans, ranked fairly high. To be born in the human realm one must uphold the five precepts (no killing, no stealing, no sexual misconduct, no false speech, no intoxicants) in order to be born human. The human realm has both suffering and joy, mixed. (The sufferings of the human realm include the eight sufferings and the three sufferings, etc.; the eight sufferings are birth, old age, sickness, death, not getting what one seeks, separation from what one loves, meeting with what one hates, and the burning of the five aggregates, etc.; the three sufferings are the suffering of suffering, the suffering of change, and the suffering of conditioning, etc.)

Third, the asura realm (non-deva); in fact asuras are also a kind of deva, only they differ somewhat in character from devas, so they are separated into a category. Asuras are distributed among the other five destinies. Male asuras are all ugly, female asuras all beautiful. Asuras are fierce beings with heavy hatred and a love of strife. Except for the hell realm, the deva, human, animal, and hungry ghost realms all have asuras. Some asuras live among humans, some are human, some are devas, some hungry ghosts, some animals. The lowest Four Heavenly Kings and Trayastrimsa also have asuras. Beings who have done much good but with heavy hatred will become asuras after death.

Fourth, the animal realm (hatred, delusion), animals are the various creatures known to humans, pigs, sheep, cattle, horses and such; the animal realm involves being slaughtered and eaten by humans. But some animals may not be visible among humans, such as dragons and the great garuda bird. Dragons can be with the devas,

able to contact the devas of the Four Heavenly Kings. So some animals move among humans, some among the Four Heavenly Kings and Trayastrimsa.

Fifth, the hungry ghost realm (greed); note that this 'hungry' is hunger, not the 'evil' of good and evil. There are many ghosts in hell, and many ghosts among humans, living together with humans. Besides, many ghosts live together with the devas of the Four Heavenly Kings and Trayastrimsa, such as the spirits among the eight classes of gods and dragons; this differs from the general religious teaching that ghosts are all in hell. The Dharma calls ghosts hungry ghosts; why the added word 'hungry'? Because beings in past lives did not cultivate goodness, were greedy and stingy in giving, and as a result fell after death, often hungry and unable to swallow food, hence called hungry ghosts.

Hungry ghosts are divided into three kinds: the rich-fed ghosts, the poor-fed ghosts, and the no-fed ghosts. The rich-fed ghosts have three types: the ghost fed by offerings, the ghost fed by discards, and the ghost of great power; because they enjoy wealth and pleasure they are also called ghosts of blessing, and some of the orthodox gods believed by folk today are in fact ghosts of blessing; the ghost of great power enjoys wealth and pleasure equal to the heavens, including yaksas, the man-eating raksasas, and the pisacas who eat human essence. Rich-fed ghosts have good blessings and people worship and offer them food. Poor-fed ghosts can only eat pus, blood, and other impure things, even their own pus and blood, and have three types: the needle-hair ghost, the stinking-hair ghost, and the goiter ghost. No-fed ghosts have the torch-mouth ghost, the needle-mouth ghost, and the stinking-mouth ghost; their retribution cannot enjoy food and drink, the food obtained turns to flame and cannot be swallowed, clearly a life-form that cannot eat its fill; their bellies are drum-large and their throats needle-thin; the water we see, they see as fire, and food they see as burning charcoal, so of course hungry ghosts are not yet the most suffering.

Sixth, the hell-realm beings, who are the most suffering. Hell is not in the human world, but beneath the earth. According to the Abhidharmakosa, there are the eight hot hells, the eight cold hells, and the solitary hell.

1. The Eight Hot Hells (the eight great hells)

1 The Reviving Hell: beings in this hell kill one another, die and revive, live and die again; lifespan five hundred years, with one day and night equal to five hundred years of the Four Heavenly Kings. (Fifty years of the human world is one day-night of the Four Heavenly Kings; converted, one day-night of this hell is about nine million-plus years of the human world)

2 The Black-Rope Hell: beings in this hell are bound with ropes, their bodies sawn apart; lifespan one thousand years, with one day and night equal to one thousand years of Trayastrimsa. (One hundred years of the human world is one day-night of Trayastrimsa; converted, one day-night of this hell is about thirty-six million-plus years of the human world)

3 The Crushing Hell: beings in this hell are crushed as mountains close from all sides, their bodies broken to dust; lifespan two thousand years, with one day and night equal to two thousand years of the Yama heaven. From here the time becomes incalculable.

4 The Wailing Hell: beings in this hell are boiled in scalding soup, crying and wailing; lifespan four thousand years, with one day and night equal to four thousand years of the Tusita heaven.

5 The Great-Wailing Hell: beings in this hell are tormented in cauldrons of hot iron, crying in pain; lifespan eight thousand years, with one day and night equal to eight thousand years of the Nirmanarati heaven.

6 The Heating Hell: beings in this hell are scorched and rotten by fierce fire; lifespan sixteen thousand years, with one day and night equal to sixteen thousand years of the Para-nirmitavasavartin heaven.

7 The Great-Heating Hell: beings in this hell are burned both inside and outside the body; lifespan half a middle aeon. (A small aeon is about 16.8 million years, a middle aeon about 336 million years, a great aeon about 1.344 billion years)

8 The Avici Hell, also called the Uninterrupted Hell; beings in this hell suffer without interval, that is, they receive this retribution repeatedly without interval, suffer all pains in that hell without interval, the time of suffering without interval, the lifespan of one middle aeon without interval, and after dying in pain are reborn to suffer again without interval.

2. The Eight Cold Hells

1 The Arbuda Hell: cold and suffering touch the body, like a blister.

2 The Nirarbuda Hell: pressed by cold and suffering, the blister splits.

3 The Atata Hell: cold and suffering intensify extremely, the tongue makes this sound.

4 The Ahaha Hell: cold and suffering intensify extremely, the lips make this sound.

5 The Hahava Hell: cold and suffering intensify extremely, the throat makes this sound.

6 The Utpala (blue lotus) Hell: cold forces skin and flesh to split open like this flower.

7 The Padma (red lotus) Hell: cold forces flesh-color to split greatly like this flower.

8 The Mahapadma (white lotus) Hell: cold forces skin and flesh to fall off, the bone-color like this flower.

The Solitary Hell

Also called the Single Hell or the Marginal Hell. It may be near rivers, scattered in mountains, wilderness, underground, empty space, and so on.

A person dies and returns, may still be human, may not be human. But whatever it is, one must still die, and after death cycle again. After death one chooses among these six life-forms. Therefore this life-form is called the three-life six-realm samsara view, abbreviated as the six-realm samsara. Then in the samsara process of these six realms, whether the next life turns to the deva beings enjoying blessings or turns to the hell beings suffering torment depends on the good or evil of our present, actual conduct.

(5) The Suffering of Samsara

Beings repeatedly go back and forth in birth and death among the six realms, which is the so-called six-realm samsara: a being dies in one realm and is born in another, born and dying again; after death goes to another realm to take birth. In the process of flowing through birth and death, sometimes good conditions appear and one is reborn in a good realm; evil conditions appear and one turns to an evil realm; this is called the three realms and six paths. Among the six realms, the good three good realms are: devas, humans, asuras; the evil three evil realms (three lower paths) are: animals, hungry ghosts, hells. Beings cycle again and again within good and evil conditions. The arising of samsara: samsara is the activity of beings' body, speech, and mind, which the Dharma calls the fruit of karma. At death, the mind clings to a sphere and follows it to take rebirth, thus life after life. Whenever a being dies, not believing it has died, because of attachment to the world it goes to pursue the feeling within the sphere, follows it to take rebirth, comes again to be born in the world, and continues flowing. Yet, whether the enjoyment of devas, the mixed joy and suffering of humans, or the suffering of animals and hell beings, in essence all is suffering.

Many experiences in samsara are not what we want, yet they appear precisely, happening again and again. The Buddhist scriptures record: 'Humans die and become sheep, sheep die and become human, revolving in mutual repayment.' The meaning is, if you are a butcher who kills sheep and slaughters many sheep, in cause and effect you owe countless sheep lives. Because your affinity with sheep is deep, when you die you will follow the sheep's sphere, even wanting to catch a few more sheep to kill. That is, when you die, the sphere of sheep appears in your mind and you chase after it, with the result of being reborn as a sheep. When you are a sheep you must repay with your life and be killed by your enemy (the sheep you killed in the past), you will be a sheep for many lives and be killed, until the retribution for killing sheep in past lives is fully repaid; when the sheep retribution is exhausted you return to be human, but because of your past habit of killing sheep you will kill sheep again, and those who killed you in past lives now reborn as sheep to repay you by letting you kill, thus revolving in mutual repayment.

1 The absolute suffering retribution of the hell realm.

Beings who commit unwholesome karma such as killing or harming other beings and sexual misconduct easily fall into hell after death, enduring all kinds of suffering. Hell beings suffer extremes of cold and heat, and unbearable torment. For instance, being boiled in oil cauldrons, pierced by sword-mountains, having the tongue plowed by a plow, and so on. When beings finish the hell's retribution they can still be reborn human, and in the future have the chance to be born in heaven; this is the phenomenon of samsara. The sufferings of hell beings include the great cold, great heat, oil cauldrons, sword-mountains, tongue-plowing, and so on, all pure suffering.

2 The hunger retribution of the hungry ghost realm.

If beings fall into the hungry ghost realm, however hard they try they cannot obtain food; they must have someone give to them before they can eat. Otherwise they can only eat very filthy things. Why? Because in the sphere of hungry ghost beings, clean things are not seen; all good things they see as filthy and cannot eat, but being hungry they have no choice but to eat. So the Dharma says, the same river, humans see as clear water, drinkable; hungry ghost beings see as pus and blood, undrinkable; devas see as crystal and lapis, very beautiful. Because everyone's sense organs differ, the experiences differ.

3 The delusion retribution of the animal realm.

Beings, according to the wholesome or unwholesome karma they have accumulated, will repeatedly be reborn in good or evil realms. Buddhist scriptures record: a being reborn as an ant has a short lifespan, but after death will again be an ant, for many lives an ant. According to the Dharma, a human body is hard to obtain; one must cultivate wholesome karma to have the chance to be reborn human again, but the chance of being human is less than the chance of an ant being reborn as an ant after death. So after death one easily falls; a human body is hard to obtain, which is this meaning. If you are asked whether you are willing to be like pigs, ants, or maggots in dung heaps, of course you say no. Because you are human, with higher wisdom, you can clearly see the suffering of animal-realm beings. Likewise, the Buddha also said that devas looking at human life will disdain such a life. That is, devas enjoy themselves in heaven, comfortable and free. In the eyes of devas, our human material enjoyments cannot compare at all with heaven, not worth living a human life. From the human perspective, looking at maggots in a dung heap, one thinks their life is very bitter; likewise, from the deva perspective looking at human life, they also think we are as miserable as maggots in a dung heap. This means beings with higher wisdom and blessings will regard the lives of lower beings as very bitter.

4 The locus of human-realm suffering.

Why is the human realm a suffering retribution? The Buddha said this is because everything in the world is impermanent. History proves there is nothing eternal in the world; everything is changing. The nation cannot be eternal, the family even less permanent; not only is there constant change, there is also strife. Why is this so? Because the six-realm beings have the affliction of greed; to satisfy greed they will try every means to possess more wealth; when one person or one nation wants to possess more, others must lose, and thus strife and plunder arise, so the Buddha said there are several kinds of calamities among humans.

(1) The calamity of weapons

wars between nations arising from plunder. No matter how society progresses, humans often must resort to war to solve some problems. Therefore, although humans are very unwilling to see war break out, they still continue to launch wars, plunging the people into misery.

(2) The calamity of plague

there are many kinds of disease in this world; no matter how medicine advances, viruses keep mutating, such as SARS and COVID-19, which will harm the health of all humanity. According to the Dharma, we created some unwholesome karma in past lives and receive the fruit of disease, an invisible common-karma factor. In the human world, these diseases cause many deaths; when some infectious disease comes, it takes thousands upon thousands of lives!

(3) The calamity of famine

in the world, at certain intervals crops fail or there is no harvest; unequal distribution of wealth causes financial crisis, economic difficulty, and illiquidity, and when the famine comes, many are starved to death.

(4) Natural disasters

at intervals, some places in the human world are flooded; at intervals the weather grows hotter, crops and plants wither and cannot grow, hot weather causes wild fires in forests, causing loss of life and property. (Wind disasters, fire disasters, earthquakes, and so on)

Some of us live comfortable lives, but in some places people have nothing to eat and are starved to death; in some places people not only have nothing to eat but no water to drink; this is the so-called famine they suffer. In the human world there are such unsatisfactory miseries, so the Buddha said beings flowing in the human world suffer. As humans we must also bear some painful things, such as those with little blessing who often feel financially strapped, living on debt, pressed by banks for repayment. They must do hard work to support themselves. Devas do not need to work; with good blessings, merely a thought brings something for them to use; this is their retribution.

So within the three realms and six paths, below the human realm, that is, animals, hungry ghosts, and hells, there are many painful and unfree things. Being human is still fairly good, except that humans have the calamities of weapons, famine, flood and fire, earthquakes, and disease. Worse, to occupy a certain territory and maintain a certain space to move, to survive, humans must toil and rush about to make a living. Living thus our whole life, have we ever thought for whom we toil and busy ourselves? Have we ever thought what the meaning of life is? Generally, many people think of this question after living past fifty. In youth and strength, not knowing old age, sickness, and death, they recklessly exhaust body and mind; this is very suffering behavior.

5 The suffering of the deva realm

Perhaps some think, do not devas enjoy happiness? Desire-sphere devas have the pursuit of greedy desire, but they have blessings and can be satisfied, enjoying desire-sphere pleasures. Lower desire-sphere devas, when

about to die, show the 'five decay signs.'

(1) The light on the body disappears: devas' bodies emit light; the higher the deva the brighter the light; the lowest Four Heavenly Kings and Trayastrimsa devas' light is still less than sunlight, while the third, fourth, and fifth heaven devas' light is brighter than sunlight; there is no sun there, the devas' body light illuminates the whole world. But at death the light disappears, and thus they suffer and fear.

(2) The flower crown on the head withers: devas have a precious crown on the head, naturally arisen; when about to die, the crown on the head withers.

(3) Where the deva sits is very comfortable, but when about to die, sitting there feels uneasy.

(4) The body emits foul odor: a human who does not bathe for two or three days smells foul; devas are different, they need not bathe, but when about to die, the body emits a foul odor.

(5) The deva body does not attract dust, but when about to die, dirty things stick to the body.

Devas in their lifetime have no sickness, only enjoyment, but once the five decay signs appear, they know they are about to die, and know to which realm they will be reborn, so they are very fearful. After devas finish the deva retribution, they fall after death to be human, or animal, or hell. Because while they were devas they only enjoyed and did not cultivate, these blessings reverse, so deva happiness is not eternal either. Form-sphere and formless-sphere devas can enter concentration for a long time, but when their concentration power wanes they will still be reborn into the desire sphere lacking concentration, continuing to suffer. Therefore, form-sphere and formless-sphere devas only temporarily avoid the suffering retribution; once the time comes and concentration fades, they too will fall and continue to suffer. This is the suffering of flowing.

VI. Proof of Cause-Effect and Samsara

Birth and death are great matters; with birth there is death, which no one can avoid. Therefore, since ancient times humanity has been exploring: where do we come from in birth, where do we go in death? What exactly is birth and death? Can one transcend the cycle of birth and death? Humanity has explored these questions for thousands of years, and sages of East and West have all discussed them deeply and minutely. More than three thousand years ago, Sakyamuni Buddha already deeply and minutely explored the truth of birth-death and samsara, giving a supremely perfect answer. The ancient Chinese sage Confucius also said, 'If you do not yet understand life, how can you understand death,' 'If you do not yet know how to serve humans, how can you know how to serve spirits,' 'Respect spirits and ghosts but keep them at a distance.' He spoke much about the principles of conduct and dealing with the world, but little about the principles of death and spirits, because Confucianism is worldly (speaking of worldly Dharma). But he also acknowledged spirits and samsara; in his commentary on the Book of Changes Confucius mentioned, 'Refined energy becomes things, wandering soul becomes change,' where the so-called 'wandering soul' refers to the state before rebirth after death (commonly called the soul, the Dharma calls the spirit-consciousness), and 'refined energy' refers to the union of parents' blood and energy, the state after rebirth.

Thus we can see that Master Kong also knew a person is not annihilated after death, but will go to be reborn and reincarnated. The Western sage Plato, in his work the Republic, also repeatedly mentioned that humans have a soul and the phenomenon of the soul leaving the body. Not only have sages of East and West described, admonished, and taught about reincarnation and karmic retribution, but in Chinese and foreign history there are also very rich writings on reincarnation.

Here for everyone I pick a few simple cases from China's official history, to see one spot and know the whole leopard. Let us not speak of China's unofficial histories or folk legends, but only of the official histories acknowledged by ancient and modern emperors and the state, which contain very rich records of samsara. For instance, the Song Shi (History of Song), ten fascicles three volumes four hundred forty-fourth juan, records that the Tang dynasty's poetry immortal Li Bai was reborn into the Song dynasty, named Guo Xiangzheng. The Nan Shi Liang Ji (Southern History, Liang Annals), one fascicle three volumes eight juan, records that in the Northern and Southern dynasties, the Liang Yuan Emperor's previous life was a monk called the One-Eyed Monk. There are also devas reborn, such as the Tang Shu (History of Tang), three fascicles two volumes twenty-seventh juan, which records that the Tang Daizong was born of a divine descent. There are also those reborn as animals; like a record in the Dong Zhou Lie Guo Zhi (Stories of the Warring States), that in the Spring and Autumn and Warring States period, Qin and Zhao fought; Zhao's great general Zhao Kuo, who did not understand the art of war and only talked of it on paper, was defeated by Qin's great general Bai Qi. Bai Qi actually buried alive four hundred thousand Zhao surrendered soldiers, creating very heavy karma, so Bai Qi was reborn as an animal and later fell into hell. According to the Dong Zhou Lie Guo Zhi, on a certain day in the late Tang dynasty, a sudden bolt from the blue struck and killed an ox, and on the ox's belly were the two characters 'Bai Qi.' Historical commentators held that Bai Qi created major killing karma, so life after life he cycles through evil realms suffering, repeatedly struck dead by heavenly thunder as retribution. These are official history records, real persons. China's historical records are rich in such cases.

It is precisely because of the teachings of ancient sages and the rich historical records that the ancients firmly believed in birth-death, samsara, and karmic retribution, treating them as common sense; but modern people, thinking they have scientific knowledge, do not believe in cause-effect and samsara, considering them superstition, anti-science, not in keeping with the scientific spirit. This may be because there is a history of grievance between science and religion. In seventeenth-century Europe, when science was just rising, many astronomers through scientific observation proposed astronomical theories conflicting with the religion of the time, for example the Italian astronomer Galileo proposed that the earth is not the center of the universe, a theory regarded by the religious circles of the time as heresy, and even imprisoned him for life. Bruno was also burned alive for insisting on the same theory. The people of the time were superstitious about religion, using religion to oppose science; and now people are superstitious about science, using science to oppose religion; truly one retribution answers another, which is the obvious karmic retribution!

After Prince Siddhartha became a Buddha, the Buddha's homeland was attacked by King Virudhaka with troops; the Sakya people, following Sakyamuni Buddha in cultivation, many did not want to fight. The Buddha, knowing this, thought King Virudhaka would create great unwholesome karma, because many Sakya people cultivated and realized the fruits, and if King Virudhaka killed them his retribution would be heavy and he would fall for a long time.

Therefore the Buddha waited where King Virudhaka led his troops through, to dissuade him from war; King Virudhaka respected the Buddha and heeded his advice and withdrew twice. When King Virudhaka marched the third time, although the Buddha dissuaded him, he still insisted on attacking the Sakya clan. It turns out that when King Virudhaka was young, his father was defeated and sent him as a hostage to the Sakya clan, to live with the other Sakya princes. Because he was a hostage, he was often bullied by the Sakya princes, so from childhood he wanted revenge. After he inherited his father's throne and became king, he led troops to attack the Sakya clan. On the surface this was the reason, but in fact it was not so. Later someone asked Sakyamuni Buddha, 'Buddha, King Virudhaka respects you so; you have dissuaded him three times, why does he still attack the Sakya clan?' The Buddha then told the whole former cause and later effect: long ago in a past life, the Sakya

people were villagers of one village, all making a living by catching fish in the river; the fish they caught were the army attacking the Sakya clan. At that time a child in the village (a previous life of Sakyamuni Buddha), one day the villagers caught a big fish, the fish king (the previous life of King Virudhaka); the child, for fun, knocked the fish's head three times, and as a result when Sakyamuni Buddha met King Virudhaka about to attack the Sakya clan, he had a headache for three days, which was the retribution for the karma created in that past life. These captured and killed fish and the village fishermen thus had very evil cause and effect. When the fishermen were reborn as the Sakya clan, King Virudhaka and that school of fish were also born at the same time, and everyone fought again. So on the surface it was because of the hatred between King Virudhaka and the Sakya prince, but in fact it was not so; rather it was mutual cause and effect between the entire army and the entire Sakya people, their enmity evolving into retaliatory action. So in this world, many wars are caused by enmities from distant past lives.

Rebirth of a 9/11 victim, past-life memory vivid

Many people do not believe in things like reincarnation, but an American boy may change your view. An American boy has past-life memories and often claims to be a 9/11 victim. The reality TV show Ghost Inside My Child records children with past-life memories and their families; the little boy said he was a victim in the 2001 U.S. 9/11 terrorist attack.

Experts believe this child's recollection of past lives often occurs in dreams. Such is the case with Molly Curnutte's son Cade; Curnutte said, 'Cade was a very normal, good baby when small, able to sleep calmly for long periods and play on his own. Until age three, he suddenly woke up and screamed, 'Fell from the office, can see the Statue of Liberty, and how the leg broke when falling,' etc.' Curnutte guessed her son might be a victim who died in 9/11; she said, 'Cade talked about lightning, two buildings, a person falling. At this point, I began to suspect he was describing the 9/11 events.' At the same time she was also worried whether her son, at such a young age, being so concerned with death and experience, would affect his future. Cade also told Curnutte, 'We will not die.' Cade also told Curnutte, 'I am older than you.' In the program, ten-year-old Cade also met a past-life friend and recalled some circumstances of the 9/11 event. He said a plane hit a tall building and got stuck there, then he fell from the tall building but had not yet died, later buried by some rubble. But at the time he had no feeling, because he was dead. After investigation, Cade learned he had worked in the World Trade Center and was among those who died in 9/11, only he lacked the courage to contact the victims' families.

And this matter is not just an isolated case; among children with past-life memories like him, there is also Carson, daughter of America's Culpepper, whose mother believes her daughter died in the 1995 Oklahoma City bombing in a previous life. The Oklahoma City bombing occurred on April 19, 1995, a domestic terrorist bombing against the Alfred P. Murrah Federal Building in downtown Oklahoma City, USA. This terrorist act was the most terrifying before 9/11; at the time 168 people died and more than 680 were injured, not only that, 324 buildings within a sixteen-block radius were damaged, with very heavy casualties, at least 652 million dollars in losses.

Wang Yangming, the Reincarnation of a Senior Monk

The old monk, knowing the past and future, long knew that fifty years later he would be reborn in samsara, named Wang Yangming, and said he would return after fifty years, 'The one who opens the door is still the one who closed it'; the one who closed the door fifty years before is the one who opens the door fifty years later, so the old monk's verse proves 'the spirit leaves and returns again'; after the soul leaves the body it will still come back in the future. The old monk's attainment was truly remarkable; with good cultivation, his flesh did not decay, and fifty years later he returned to see his previous life's flesh body. It is a pity he did not leap out of

samsara, but was reborn as Wang Yangming; because of the result of previous-life cultivation, his learning and virtue were both excellent, but in this life he had forgotten his previous cultivation and that cultivation was interrupted, so this life's attainment was inferior to the previous. If the old monk had recited the Buddha's name and vowed to be reborn in the Western Pure Land, with his attainment he could have accomplished in that very life, certainly attaining the highest grade of the highest birth, leaping out of samsara and swiftly becoming a Buddha, and would not again cycle as Wang Yangming. I hope this historical story brings everyone a little warning.

Chan Master Zhenru Zhe

Chan Master Zhenru Zhe resided at the Zhenru Chan Monastery in Tanzhou (present-day Changsha, Hunan), hence called Master Zhenru Zhe. He died without illness, spoke a verse in farewell, and at cremation relics were obtained; eyes, teeth, and nails did not decay, showing extremely high cultivation. He lived over ninety years, diligently practicing the Way. It is said that at his cremation even the paper jacket he wore on his body burned out relics; such a great Chan elder. Master Yinguang said: Zhenru Zhe's later body was born into great wealth and nobility, suffering much worry and bitterness throughout life. Could it be Emperor Qinzong of Song? Reborn as Zhao Huan, Emperor Qinzong of Song.

Chan Master Qingcaotang was reborn into a family he had formerly received offerings from, a certain Mrs. Zeng, called Zeng Gongliang (Zeng Lugong), who rose to prime minister. Chan Master Haiyin Xin was reborn as the daughter of Zhu Fangyu. Chan Master Wuzu Jie was reborn as Su Dongpo. The Yandang monk (previous life) was reborn as Qin Hui. Cao Cao (previous life) was reborn as a pig (a Suzhou person killed a pig, and inside was pig liver with the two characters Cao Cao).

Here is another true historical story, the historical fact of Fang Xiaoru of the Ming dynasty being executed with ten clans. Fang Xiaoru (1357-1402) was a great Confucian of the early Ming, learned and virtuous; his loyal and righteous deed is praised in history. At the time the Ming founder Zhu Yuanzhang greatly valued him. Later Fang Xiaoru also assisted the Ming founder's grandson, the Ming Hui Emperor, in governing. Before Fang Xiaoru was born, his father bought a geomantically auspicious plot to build an ancestral grave; the night before digging the grave, he had a dream in which an old man in red came to plead with him, saying I have eight hundred descendants living below the grave site you are to dig; I know you are building an ancestral grave, which is understandable, but please give me three days to let our whole family move away, and after three days you may dig. After waking, Fang Xiaoru's father felt he should not take it seriously, and simply ignored it; anyway the auspicious day was already chosen, and digging must begin tomorrow.

As a result the next day they went to dig, and beneath a large stone below they found many red snakes. Seeing so many red snakes, Fang Xiaoru's father thought it inauspicious, and actually said, 'Let us burn all these red snakes to death.' And so with fire they burned to death very many snakes. That night he dreamed again of the red-clothed old man (the snake king), very angrily saying, 'Yesterday I already sent you a dream, requesting you dig three days later, but why did you not heed my plea? Today you have actually burned all my eight hundred-plus descendants to death. Very well, now you have exterminated my clan, and I will also exterminate your clan in the future!'

Soon Fang Xiaoru was born; he grew up to be a learned and virtuous great Confucian, quickly valued by Zhu Yuanzhang and given heavy responsibility. In the thirty-first year of Hongwu, Zhu Yunwen (the Jianwen Emperor) ascended the throne and summoned Xiaoru to the capital, appointing him Hanlin Academician Expositor-in-Waiting, honoring him as a teacher; for all state affairs he often had Xiaoru answer in his presence. In the first year of Jianwen (1399), Prince Yan Zhu Di launched the Jingnan Campaign to seize the throne. The

Jianwen Emperor's court debated punishment, and the edicts and proclamations all came from Fang Xiaoru. After Zhu Di led troops from the north and broke into Nanjing, he killed the ruler and usurped the throne, arrested the original civil and military officials, and most, feeling there was no alternative since it was a power struggle between the Zhu brothers, submitted to Zhu Di. Zhu Di knew Fang Xiaoru was a great Confucian revered by the world, so he had Fang Xiaoru write the accession proclamation declaring the Prince of Yan emperor. Fang Xiaoru would rather die than comply; he took the brush and swiftly wrote the four characters 'Usurper Yan,' threw the brush to the ground, and weeping cursed: 'Death is death; I will never write the proclamation.' Zhu Di in great anger said, 'How dare you do this; do you not fear I will exterminate your nine clans?' Xiaoru answered, 'Even if you exterminate my ten clans, I will not submit!' His curses grew fiercer. Zhu Di, hating his stubborn mouth, had men cut the corners of Fang Xiaoru's mouth, tearing to the ear roots. Xiaoru, blood and tears streaming, still spat blood and cursed. Zhu Di said sternly, 'How can I let you die by yourself; I will exterminate your ten clans!' In the end, Zhu Di added one more clan atop the nine, arresting even Fang Xiaoru's students and friends and beheading them. This is the unprecedented 'extermination of ten clans,' a total of 873 killed, with thousands imprisoned, exiled, or banished, and Fang Xiaoru himself was cut in two at the waist.

Later people learned that Fang Xiaoru's previous life was the snake king, who transformed into the red-clothed old man and pleaded in a dream to Fang Xiaoru's father. To obtain a geomantically auspicious plot for an ancestral grave, Fang's father actually burned those eight hundred red snakes, exterminating the snakes' clan. As a result this red snake king swore a venomous oath to also exterminate the Fang family's ten clans, demanding repayment of the eight hundred-plus lives. The six-realm samsara is just like this: you kill me, I kill you, mutually repaying the debt of life, vengeance answering vengeance.

The historical Fang Xiaoru was a learned and virtuous person of high aspiration, much revered, but he did not know that this life of his came to take revenge, because he had forgotten his previous life. But this karma pulled him along, naturally leading him onto this path, exterminating the Fang family's ten clans. This inner cause and effect does not shift according to human subjective will; once karma is created, the retribution must be received.

So when we harm animals, we must know there will surely be retribution in the future. Especially spiritually aware lives like snakes and turtles, if you kill them and eat them, you offend greatly, with severe consequences. It is a pity that modern people do not believe in cause and effect, especially we southerners, who dare to eat snakes and turtles, everything that flies in the sky, swims in the sea, walks on land, the full set of air, sea, and land, creating very heavy killing karma, and the future retribution will truly be miserable. You see the Fang family, because of the killing karma, had ten clans exterminated; then how many clans will be exterminated for the killing karma we create? I am afraid all will be exterminated; that is what we call the end of the world.

You owed my life, I return your debt; by this cause and condition, through hundreds of thousands of kalpas, we are forever in birth and death. (Suramgama Sutra)

VII. The Law of Karmic Fruit (the Principle of Cause and Effect)

Earlier we spoke of the three-life view, of the six-realm samsara, of the suffering of samsara. These principles all boil down to one most fundamental law, which is the law of karmic fruit, once a karmic cause is planted, the fruit must result; when the retribution ripens, no force can block it. This section makes clear the basic face of this law.

(1) The Basic Principle of Cause and Effect: This being, therefore that arises

The core realized by the Buddha under the bodhi tree is the law of dependent origination. The Agama scriptures have this saying: 'This being, therefore that exists; this arising, therefore that arises; this not being, therefore that does not exist; this ceasing, therefore that ceases.' The main condition constituting a thing is called 'cause,' and the auxiliary condition is called 'condition.' Any thing must be complete with the main cause and various conditions to arise; they cannot exist independently. So all beings and even natural phenomena are interdependent and mutually conditional.

The law of cause-effect retribution has two fundamental axioms: one is what the Yogacarabhumi Sastra says, 'What is done is not lost, what is not done is not gained' (karma already created does not disappear, karma never created cannot appear from nowhere); the other is what the Maharatnakuta Sutra says, 'Even if through a hundred kalpas, the created karma does not perish; when cause and condition meet, the retribution is still borne by oneself' (even after a hundred kalpas, once karma meets its condition, the retribution is still received).

(2) The Classification of Cause and Effect: the Six Causes, Four Conditions, Five Fruits

Buddhism's analysis of cause and effect is very meticulous. The Abhidharmakosa lists the 'six causes': the capable-cause (the force that aids or does not obstruct the arising of retribution), the concomitant-cause (mutually dependent arising of fruit), the homogeneous-cause (able to produce homogeneous retribution), the corresponding-cause (arising simultaneously in correspondence), the pervasive-cause (ignorance, self-view, etc., able to pervasively generate all afflictions and karmic defilements), and the ripened-cause (unwholesome karma and defiled wholesome karma, able to produce in the next life fruit matured in the five realms). The 'six causes' of the Abhidharmakosa are not six completely independent 'causes,' but six angles from which to view: by what forces and what relations a result arises.

The Six Causes

1. The capable-cause: the broadest 'environmental cause'

As long as it does not obstruct a certain result from arising, and can even help a little, it counts as a capable-cause.

For instance, seed germination: soil, water, sunlight, air, space, even 'no stone pressing it down,' all count as capable-cause. Its scope is the broadest; what helps is the assisting condition, and what does not block the way also counts.

2. The concomitant-cause: the 'teammate cause' of mutual simultaneous reliance

Several things exist simultaneously, supporting each other; lacking any one will not do; they are mutually cause and effect.

For instance, three wooden sticks form a tripod, each relying on the other two for support; or fire and light appear simultaneously, mutually dependent. The emphasis is on 'simultaneous' and 'mutual.'

3. The homogeneous-cause: the 'habit cause' of similar continuity

The preceding same-kind thing gives rise to the following same-kind thing. Wholesome thoughts give rise to wholesome thoughts, unwholesome thoughts to unwholesome thoughts, habits give rise to habits.

For instance, if you study today, tomorrow it is easier to continue reading; if you lose your temper today, tomorrow it is easier to lose your temper. It mainly speaks of 'same-kind continuity,' not the kind of retribution of rebirth in the next life.

4. The corresponding-cause: the 'synchronous coordination cause' of mind and mental activities

This is a special kind within the concomitant-cause, specifically referring to the 'mind-king' and 'mental factors' corresponding simultaneously and cooperating.

In plain terms: when your consciousness cognizes an object, simultaneously there are feeling, ideation, attention, volition, greed, hatred, and other mental activities. They share the same object, the same time, work together, and are mutually cause.

For instance, when you see someone, consciousness knows 'this is so-and-so,' and simultaneously there arises like or dislike in the mind; these mental activities are synchronously coordinated.

5. The pervasive-cause: the 'general root' or 'source of infection' among afflictions

Some root afflictions, such as ignorance and self-view, are like a general disease root, able to pervasively give rise to many afflictions.

For instance, because of clinging to 'I,' there arise a great heap of afflictions such as 'I want,' 'I am superior,' 'I hate,' 'I am greedy.' It does not produce only one affliction, but can pervade and spread, becoming the cause of many defiled dharmas.

6. The ripened-cause: the 'karmic cause' of cross-life retribution

This speaks of creating karma and experiencing fruit, especially next-life retribution. Unwholesome karma and defiled wholesome karma can mature in the future as suffering or pleasure retribution, causing one to be reborn in the five realms: hell, hungry ghost, animal, human, deva.

The meaning of 'ripened' is: not ripening immediately, not ripening as the same kind, but ripening at a different time, as a different kind, and through transformation. For instance, defiled wholesome karma such as giving and upholding precepts will in the future bring a pleasant fruit; unwholesome karma such as killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, and false speech will in the future bring a painful fruit.

To summarize in one sentence:

- Capable-cause: the environment that does not block the way and can help.

- Concomitant-cause: simultaneous mutual support.

- Homogeneous-cause: same kind gives rise to same kind.

- Corresponding-cause: mind and mental activities synchronously coordinated.

- Pervasive-cause: root afflictions give rise to many afflictions.

- Ripened-cause: wholesome and unwholesome karma bring fruit across lives.

So the six causes are really saying: the appearance of a result may rely on environment, on simultaneous mutual dependence, on same-kind continuity, on mental-dharma coordination, on the spread of afflictions, and on the maturation of past karma. Seen thus, cause and effect is not a straight line, but a net.

The Four Conditions

The Mulamadhyamakakarika and others speak of the 'four conditions': the causal condition (direct cause, i.e., the seed of karmic consciousness in one's own mind, the fundamental condition for producing dharmas), the objective condition (the external object that consciousness grasps), the dominant condition (other conditions that play a key role), and the uninterrupted condition (no interval or obstruction between cause and effect in

their continuity). Only with the four conditions complete can the retribution arise; if any one condition is lacking, the fruit cannot arise. Just as a plant's seed does not necessarily fall and sprout at once; it must wait until temperature, humidity, soil, and light are all suitable before it flowers and bears fruit.

The 'four conditions' can be understood as: for an event to occur, four kinds of conditions must be assembled. Not four independent causes, but four angles: the main cause of producing fruit, the object the mind faces, the assisting conditions that help, and the continuous succession from before to after. Only when all four are complete does the fruit arise; lacking one, the fruit does not arise.

1. The causal condition (direct cause): the true 'seed'

This is the most fundamental inner cause, the main force that produces fruit. As said here, it is the seed of karmic consciousness in one's own mind, the habitual tendencies, the seed of karmic force.

For instance, why do you get angry? The person outside is only the fuse; the true cause is the seed of hatred already in the mind. Without this seed, however much the outside stimulates, such great hatred may not arise.

Like a plant: the seed is the causal condition. Without the seed, however good the sunlight, water, and soil, that plant cannot grow.

2. The objective condition: the 'object' that consciousness grasps

The mind cannot arise from nothing; it must have an object. You look at a flower, the flower is the objective condition of the eye-consciousness; you think of a person, that person or that image is the objective condition of the mental consciousness; you hear a sound, the sound is the objective condition of the ear-consciousness.

In plain terms: the objective condition is 'the thing the mind faces.' Without an object, consciousness has nothing to lodge in and cannot arise.

Like taking a photo: there must be a scene to be photographed, otherwise what to shoot?

3. The dominant condition: the 'other conditions' that play a key role

This is not the main cause, but it cannot be lacking, or it can greatly help. For instance, seed germination needs temperature, humidity, soil, sunlight, space; for you to see something, you need normal eyes, light, distance, and attention.

The dominant condition has the broadest scope: any condition that helps the fruit arise, or at least does not obstruct its arising, counts as a dominant condition.

Like a plant: the seed is there, but too dry, too cold, no soil, and it cannot sprout.

4. The uninterrupted condition: the 'unbroken' continuity from before to after

This speaks of the continuity of mental thoughts. The preceding thought ceases before the following thought can arise; between them there can be no break. The preceding thought yields its place, the following thought immediately takes it up, like water flowing, wave upon wave.

In plain terms: the uninterrupted condition is 'the relay baton must not drop.' If the middle breaks, the continuity of consciousness breaks, and the fruit cannot connect.

For instance, when you read a book, the previous thought attends to the text, the following thought continues to understand, thought after thought continuous, so you can keep reading. If the middle is completely broken, there is no continuity to speak of.

The four conditions complete before the fruit arises:

- Causal condition: the main seed, the inner cause.

- Objective condition: the object of consciousness.

- Dominant condition: various key assisting conditions.

- Uninterrupted condition: continuous from before to after without break.

Take the plant seed for example: the seed is the cause, temperature, humidity, soil, and light are dominant conditions, and the continuous passage of time is the uninterrupted condition. Only when conditions are all suitable does it sprout, flower, and bear fruit; if any one is lacking, the fruit cannot arise.

Strictly speaking, though, the objective condition and the uninterrupted condition are mainly spoken from the angle of the arising of consciousness; the plant analogy only helps us understand the principle of 'conditions complete.'

To summarize in one sentence:

The causal condition is the seed, the objective condition is the object, the dominant condition is the helper, and the uninterrupted condition is the unbroken relay. Only when the four conditions are complete does the fruit arise; lacking one, the fruit does not arise. Cause and effect is not a single cause, but the result of a whole set of conditions cooperating.

The Five Fruits

The retribution has the 'five fruits': the fruit of personal effort (the actual retribution enjoyed in this present life), the homogeneous fruit (same-kind cause and effect continuous, like a river flowing on), the ripened fruit (retribution maturing in future lives, causing one to flow in the six realms), the dominant fruit (the influence the created karma has on relatives, those around, even society, the folk saying 'when one attains the Way, even chickens and dogs ascend to heaven' belongs to this layer), and the fruit of release (the unconditioned fruit, i.e., the retribution of realizing liberation).

1. The fruit of personal effort: effort in this life, enjoyed in this life

'Personal effort' means the doing, striving, and functioning of a person. What you do, you can see the result now.

For instance, cooking brings satiety, studying brings exams, working brings wages, farming brings grain.

Work now, get the fruit now; visible and usable.

2. The homogeneous fruit: same-kind continuity, habit continuation

'Homogeneous' means similar continuity, flowing on like a river. The preceding same kind gives rise to the following same kind.

For instance, one who likes to lose his temper becomes easier to lose his temper; one who often cultivates loving-kindness has a softer mind; reading scripture today makes it easier to read again tomorrow.

Good leads good, evil leads evil, habits nurture habits, the same kind continues to flow.

3. The ripened fruit: cross-life retribution, maturing in the next life

This speaks of wholesome and unwholesome karma maturing in future lives, causing one to flow in the six realms.

'Ripened' means: ripening at a different time, as a different kind, through transformation, not immediate retribution, not same-kind retribution, but becoming another kind of fruit after conditions mature.

For instance, wholesome karma such as giving and upholding precepts will in the future bring a pleasant fruit; unwholesome karma such as killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, and false speech will in the future bring a painful fruit, even falling into evil destinies.

The karma created in this life is not necessarily repaid in this life; it may be repaid in future lives.

4. The dominant fruit: influencing the surroundings, the common karma of the environment

This is not only about one's own inner suffering or joy, but about the influence your karma has on relatives, others, society, and the environment.

For instance, one with virtue brings benefit to family, team, and society; one who creates evil may also implicate those around. The folk saying 'when one attains the Way, even chickens and dogs ascend to heaven' can be understood at this layer.

The karma you create acts not only on yourself, but also affects those around and the world.

5. The fruit of release: liberation and the unconditioned, the fruit of realization

'Release' means leaving bondage, no longer bound by afflictions, karma, and birth-death. It is not a fruit 'created,' but the realization of the unconditioned, nirvana, liberation.

Like a rope binding you; once untied you are free, freedom is not a newly created thing, but the restoration of the originally unbound state.

Cutting afflictions and realizing liberation, no longer bound by birth-death and afflictions, this is the fruit of release.

To summarize in one sentence:

- Fruit of personal effort: effort in this life, used in this life.

- Homogeneous fruit: same-kind continuity becomes habit.

- Ripened fruit: cross-life retribution, turning through the five realms.

- Dominant fruit: influencing others and the environment.

- Fruit of release: leaving bondage, realizing the unconditioned.

So the 'five fruits' are not five different fruits, but five angles: the present-life fruit, the continuity fruit, the next-life fruit, the influence fruit, and the liberation fruit.

(3) The Time of Fruit Maturation: Immediate, Next-Life, and Later Retribution (the Threefold Retribution Theory)

Although a karmic cause will surely produce a fruit, it must await the completion of all necessary conditions before it can mature. According to the time of maturation, it is divided into three kinds:

1. Immediate retribution (present-life retribution): the fruit is before one's eyes and matures in this life; this abounds in life. In study and work, results are seen at once; in believing and practicing the Dharma, one soon gains benefit in body and mind; in committing crime and breaking the law, one immediately suffers legal punishment and public scorn.

2. Next-life retribution: karma created in this life is received in the next life, while the cause of the retribution received in this life must naturally be traced to a past life. The scriptures say: 'If you wish to know the cause of past lives, look at what you receive in this life; if you wish to know the fruit of future lives, look at what you do in this life.' This kind mainly refers to the ripened fruit, the ripened fruit meaning the conditions fixed at birth, not subject to one's own choice, such as the era, region, family, inborn constitution, appearance, intelligence, and character one is born with.

3. Later retribution: some karma created in this life or in past lives, because conditions are not complete or are obstructed by a strong condition, must await many lives hence, even the extremely distant future, before all conditions are complete and the fruit matures. But no matter how long the time of retribution, even if it is after many kalpas, so long as the karmic cause seed has been planted, there is no principle by which fruit is not produced.

(4) Cause and Effect Is Not Fate: the Weight Lies in This Present Thought

Here is the most easily misunderstood point: since everything is determined by karma, is life then completely predestined by the past, with no room for change? On the contrary. The law of cause and effect speaks of 'seeds meeting conditions and becoming manifest' (the seed of karmic force is stored in the alayavijnana; only when the seed meets conditions does it become manifest). Manifestation requires conditions, and conditions can be changed; causes and conditions can be transformed.

Therefore when the Buddha spoke the dharma of causes and conditions, the emphasis was never on 'fate' but on 'can be transformed.' The Mulamadhyamakakarika says: 'Dharmas produced from causes and conditions, I declare them to be empty; they are also provisional names; this too is the middle way.' Understanding dependent origination and emptiness of nature, one can fundamentally transcend samsara, rather than passively resigning to fate. In sum, one sentence: cause and effect is not fate; cause and effect is an account, whatever you do, that fruit you will have; but the account is in your own hands, and at any time you can start a new entry.

(5) Why the Buddha Teaches Cause and Effect: Four Negative Implications

If one denies the existence of the principle of cause and effect, the Buddhist scriptures call it 'uprooting cause and effect.' The Dasacakra Ksitigarbha Sutra, volume seven, says: 'To uproot cause and effect is to cut off the roots of goodness.' The Madhyama Agama, volume fourteen, says: 'Not fearing the afterlife, one stops at no evil.' Thus believing in cause and effect is not a passive worry, but a self-warning.

On the question of cause and effect, Buddhism opposes four wrong attachments: the first is 'wrong cause, wrong fruit,' attributing the rise of all things to a super-personal force like Siva (Mahesvara); the second is 'no cause, yet fruit,' acknowledging present phenomena as fruit but denying their cause; the third is 'cause, yet no fruit,' acknowledging phenomena as cause but denying their result; the fourth is 'no cause, no fruit,' denying both cause and effect. Precisely because cause and effect truly exist, the good have hope and the evil have dread, which is exactly the ethical significance of the law of cause and effect.

(6) Who Creates Karma, Who Receives It: the Profound Meaning of Non-Self

This section supplements a very key question: since cause and effect truly exist, who is creating karma and who is receiving retribution?

The Buddha's answer may surprise: no one is creating karma, and no one receives retribution.

The Buddha's teaching is that 'only the afflictions and deluded mind of beings go to create; that alone is called karma; within it there is no I creating karma.' The Indian non-Buddhist teaching is that 'all doing is karma, and there is an I creating karma'; Buddhism goes further, pointing out that even that I itself is a provisional name formed by the coming-together of causes and conditions, a concept provisionally established merely for the continuation of the flow of afflictions.

Therefore the subject that creates karma is the 'formation aggregate' (samskara-skandha), one of the five aggregates. The formation aggregate contains many of our afflictions; these afflictions have no master, they arise with causes and conditions and do not arise without them. When karma is created, we can only say 'some afflictive causes and conditions are propelling,' and it is not some person creating karma.

The side that receives retribution is the same. We created much karma in the past; the power of karma cooperates with afflictions to keep creating new karma, that is to say, while receiving the retribution of karma we are also creating new karma. This is like a seed sprouting, growing into a tree, and the tree bearing new seeds.

Buddhism speaks of the five aggregates precisely to break our affliction of clinging to a self within the five aggregates. The so-called 'non-self' means all dharmas are the gathering and scattering of many conditions, unable to exist by themselves or be accomplished alone.

According to the Mahayana teaching, self-grasping is divided into two kinds: one called discriminative self-grasping (called self-view in the Hinayana), and one called innate self-grasping (called self-conceit in the Hinayana).

Self-view is a view, the view that there is a self within body and mind. After hearing the Dharma and realizing non-self, self-view is gradually let go; realizing the first fruit, one can let go of self-view.

Self-conceit is not a view, but a thought arising in the mind, such as 'I am noble,' 'I cannot disappear,' 'I am the most important in the world' — without needing to search in body and mind, one directly feels there is a self existing. Only upon realizing the arhat fruit can one completely let go of self-conceit.

From self-view further arise the annihilation view and the eternalist view, which are the extreme views. Clinging to an eternal self, even in the next life still this self, is called the eternalist view; regarding death as total annihilation, nothing remaining, is called the annihilation view. Ordinary people all have one of these two views, but not both at the same time.

This is precisely the deep basis for 'cause and effect is not fate': since there is no fixed I receiving retribution, changing thoughts and changing behavior is changing the causes and conditions. Once causes and conditions change, the fruit changes. The so-called 'destiny' is nothing but a still-flowing chain of cause and effect, and every choice you make adds a link to the chain.

(7) The Six Fields of Modern Samsara Research

In his The Scientific Proof of Cause-Effect and Reincarnation, Dr. Zhong Maosen summarizes Western samsara research into five fields. The following follows Dr. Zhong Maosen's original book.

1. Near-Death Experience Research (NDE)

Speaking of reincarnation, the first premise is to prove the existence of the soul. Western science has a mainstream discipline for this, called 'near-death experience research' (NDE, Near-Death Experience). Near-death experience is a very common phenomenon; according to Gallup statistics, a considerable proportion of people in the United States alone have had this experience.

American parapsychology researcher Karlis Osis began research in 1959; in 1978 the 'International Association for Near-Death Studies' was founded. American University of Washington pediatric professor Melvin Morse and others also did extensive research.

American University of Nevada professor Dr. Raymond A. Moody, between 1972 and 1974, systematically described the research reports of one hundred fifty near-death people: when a person is dying, he will see deceased relatives and friends, will see beautiful colors and solemn forms; then a deity lets him self-assess whether this life was good or evil, and based on good or evil choose the next life.

It is worth noting that near-death experience research originated in the East. More than three thousand years ago, ancient Indian Buddhism already had extremely detailed descriptions; Buddhism has good methods for handling the scene at the time of death, such as people reciting Amitabha at the time of death, chanting scriptures, and doing merit for the deceased.

2. Scientific Experiments on Out-of-Body Experience

The first in the world to use scientific experimental methods to prove that humans have a soul and that the soul can leave the body to observe was the British doctor Sam Parnia. American University of California professor Dr. Charles Tart also adopted scientific experimental methods, confirming that human consciousness can operate independently of the body.

There is a widely circulated story called 'The Soul Saves the Shipwreck': in 1860, a book Walking on the Edge of the Spirit World recorded that a sailor on the ship 'Ariel' died accidentally aboard; Captain Clark wrote his name on the blackboard with chalk, asking him to return and report the cause of death. Three days later, someone saw the 'Ariel' approaching through the fog outside the cabin, within reach. The captain later verified the handwriting and confirmed it was written by the deceased.

3. Hypnosis to Regress to Past Lives

American psychiatrist Ian Stevenson and Brian Weiss, among others, used hypnosis to help people recall past lives. Dr. Weiss of the Mount Sinai Medical Center in Miami, Florida, recorded that Catherine, under hypnosis, saw herself cycling through eighty-six lives on earth, spanning four to five thousand years.

There is also a particularly thought-provoking case: in one life Catherine was killed by her husband; in this life she came to him carrying the scene of her past-life husband killing her, yet in her present marriage is continuously deeply attracted to her husband. Dr. Weiss wrote: 'We are attracted to each other in this life often because unconsciously we recognize the other.'

4. Birthmarks and Destiny Related to Past Lives

Professor Stevenson discovered that human birthmarks are often closely related to past lives. If in a past life one was stabbed to death by a knife, or died by fire or scalding, a corresponding birthmark will remain on that part of the body in the next life. He recorded at least two hundred-plus cases matching past-life deceased with later-life birthmarks, and considers this a fairly stable regularity.

5. The Power of the Mind: Masaru Emoto's Water Experiment

The Japanese scientist Dr. Masaru Emoto spent ten years doing tens of thousands of experiments, putting the same water in two test tubes, one labeled with positive words such as 'praise' and 'gratitude,' the other labeled with negative words such as 'disgusting,' 'hate,' and 'I hate you,' and then observing the arrangement of water molecules with nuclear magnetic resonance. The two showed markedly different crystal structures.

From this Masaru Emoto proposed: seventy percent of our physical body is water; if we often hold good, loving, and kind intentions, the water tends toward neat crystallization; if we hold malice, the water becomes chaotic. He further inferred that seventy percent of the earth's surface is ocean; if all people in the world hold good intentions, the water will crystallize neatly and malicious events will decrease.

All dharmas are manifested by mind alone and transformed by consciousness alone. When the mind stirs, the arrangement of water changes; so it is with the world. This view in Buddhism is called 'manifestation by consciousness alone.'

6. Khenpo Tsultrim Lodro: Self-Grasping Is the Root of Samsara

In Recognizing the Root of Samsara, Khenpo Tsultrim Lodro points out: why are we ordinary beings today, why do we flow in samsara? It is not the arrangement of God, nor is it the external environment binding us. One thing always forces us to drift in samsara; it is 'self-grasping' (atma-graha), and this self-grasping is not a fixed, unchanging entity, but a concept provisionally established by consciousness for the continuation of the flow.

With self-grasping come greed, hatred, and delusion. With greed, hatred, and delusion, karma is created; with karma comes retribution; with retribution self-grasping arises again, and so the cycle continues and one can never get out. Therefore the root of samsara is not a god, not the external environment, but our own ever-grasping, ever-clinging 'I.'

To leap out of this layer, one must realize non-self. Seeing 'non-self' is the first step; when non-self is seen, the root of samsara is cut, and even if not yet completely cut off, self-grasping will no longer produce new seeds of samsara.

VIII. Faith and Verification

The story told earlier of King Virudhaka attacking the Sakya clan may seem merely a Buddhist account. To give us more confidence, you can learn more of the worldly accounts. In the past it was hard to find relevant materials, but now is the internet age and they are easy to find online. Now whether browsers or short-video platforms, one can search many interviews and reports about rebirth cases.

However, religion and science are not opposed or contradictory, just as the father of science Einstein said, 'All religion, art, and science are branches and leaves growing on the same tree. Humanity's pursuit of these three is all to lift life from the mere material world and attain freedom.' Thus religion and science and art are not opposed. Truth withstands scientific testing and fears not a thousand temperings. In recent decades, Western science has deeply explored reincarnation and karmic retribution; scientists and medical researchers, with abundant cases and abundant research results, prove that humans truly have samsara, and from beginning to end truly are governed by the law of cause and effect. We can learn from Western science's research results on reincarnation and karmic retribution to truly understand the truth of the universe and human life.

The research results of Western countries in the field of samsara research are very rich, and can be summarized into five aspects:

First, research on the existence of the soul;

Second, filed-case investigations of those able to remember past lives;

Third, research using hypnosis to help recall past lives;

Fourth, research on lives in different dimensional spaces;

Fifth, research on how psychic individuals advance the study of samsara.

Our main purpose is to let the general public truly understand the mystery of human life and the truth of the universe and human existence; numerous scientific cases confirm that there truly is the six-realm samsara, and throughout samsara runs the thread of karmic retribution. Therefore we should reflect: how did samsara come about? Can one transcend samsara? These are major questions facing humanity. It is hoped that through discussion we deepen understanding and reflection on the problem of birth and death, thus gaining fresh inspiration and guidance for our view of life and the universe.

Chapter Two: Planning Life

Having understood samsara, we must also know how to plan. This chapter explains the consequences of not planning life, and how life can be mastered by oneself.

I. Outline of the Ksitigarbha Sutra (the Consequence of Not Planning Life)

(Selected Scripture)

At that time Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva said to the Holy Mother: Such are the names of the sufferings and retributions of Jambudvipa to the south. If there are beings who are unfilial to parents, or even kill them, they shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas with no time to seek release. If there are beings who draw the Buddha's blood, slander the Three Jewels, and do not revere the honored scriptures, they too shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas with no time to seek release. If there are beings who encroach upon and damage the permanent endowment, defile monks and nuns, or within the monastery indulge in lust, or kill or harm, such people shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas with no time to seek release. If there are beings who falsely pose as sramanas, whose minds are not of a sramana, who misuse the permanent endowment, deceive lay followers, violate the precepts, and create all kinds of evil, such people shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas with no time to seek release. If there are beings who steal the permanent endowment's wealth, grain, food, clothing, or even take a single thing without giving, they shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas with no time to seek release. Ksitigarbha said: Holy Mother! If beings create such offenses, they shall fall into the five Avici hells, and not for a single thought can they seek even a moment's respite from suffering.

The mother Maya said again to Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva: What is called the Avici hell? Ksitigarbha said: Holy Mother! All the hells are within the great Iron Enclosure Mountain. There are eighteen great hells, then five hundred, each with a different name, then thousands, also with different names. As for the Avici hell, its city is eighty thousand li around, made entirely of iron, ten thousand li high, with fire piled atop, with few gaps. Within the hell-city, the various hells connect, each with a different name. There is one hell alone, called Avici. It is eighteen thousand li around, its walls a thousand li high, all made of iron. Fire from above penetrates below, fire from below penetrates above. Iron snakes and iron dogs, spewing fire, chase and run, east and west atop the hell walls. In the hell there are beds filling ten thousand li. One person receiving punishment sees his own body lying filling the whole bed. A thousand or ten thousand people receiving punishment each also sees his own body filling the bed. Such is the retribution summoned by collective karma. Moreover, the sinners fully undergo myriad sufferings. Hundreds of thousands of yama and evil ghosts, with teeth like swords and eyes like

lightning, with copper claws, drag the sinners.

Again there are yama who hold great iron halberds, striking the sinners' bodies, or striking mouth, nose, belly, or back, flinging them into the air and catching them, or placing them on beds. Again there are iron eagles that peck the sinners' eyes, and iron snakes that coil the sinners' necks. In hundreds of joints long nails are driven, the tongue is pulled and plowed, the intestines drawn and hacked, molten copper poured into the mouth, hot iron wound around the body. Ten thousand deaths and a thousand births, such is the summoning of karma. Passing through hundreds of millions of kalpas, with no time to seek release. When this world perishes, they are parasitic in another world; when that world in turn perishes, they transfer and are parasitic elsewhere; when that other place perishes, they successively transfer. After this world forms again, they return. Such is the Avici retribution. Moreover it is called Avici because of five karmic summonings. What are the five? First, day and night receiving punishment until the kalpa count, with no temporal interruption, hence called Avici. Second, whether one person or many, all are filled, hence called Avici. Third, the instruments of punishment, halberds and clubs, eagles, snakes, wolves, dogs, pestles, mills, saws, chisels, cauldrons and boiling soup, iron nets and iron ropes, iron donkeys and iron horses, raw hide binding the head, hot iron poured on the body, hunger swallowing iron pellets, thirst drinking iron fluid, from year to kalpa, countless nayuta, sufferings connected, with no interruption, hence called Avici.

Fourth, regardless of man or woman, Qiang, Hu, Yi, Di, old or young, noble or lowly, or dragon, or spirit, or deva, or ghost, all receive the same according to the karma of offense, hence called Avici. Fifth, if one falls into this hell, from the moment of entering until hundreds of thousands of kalpas, in a single day and night ten thousand deaths and ten thousand births, not for a single thought can one dwell even briefly; only when the karma is exhausted can one receive rebirth; because of this continuity it is called Avici. Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva said to the Holy Mother: Such is the rough account of the Avici hell. If one were to broadly describe the names of the hell's instruments of punishment and the various sufferings, in a single kalpa one could not finish telling. When Maya heard this, sorrowful and worried, she pressed her palms and withdrew with reverence.

At that time the four heavenly kings all rose from their seats, pressed palms reverently, and said to the Buddha: World-Honored One! Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva, over kalpas long past, made such great vows; how is it that to this day he still has not finished delivering beings, and again makes vast vows? We only wish the World-Honored One to explain for us. The Buddha told the four heavenly kings: Good indeed! Good indeed! Now for your benefit, and that of future and present devas and humans, for broad benefit, I speak of Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva's skillful means within the Saha world and Jambudvipa, in the path of birth and death, compassionately saving and delivering all beings of sin and suffering. The four heavenly kings said: Yes, World-Honored One! We wish gladly to hear. The Buddha told the four heavenly kings: Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva, from kalpas long past until now, has delivered beings and still not fulfilled his vow, compassionating the sinful and suffering beings of this world. Again observing the boundless kalpas of the future, where the causes spread unceasingly, for this reason he again made heavy vows. Thus the Bodhisattva, in the Saha world and Jambudvipa, uses hundreds of thousands of millions of skillful means to teach and transform. Four heavenly kings! When Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva meets a killer, he speaks of the retribution of past calamity and short life.

When meeting a thief, he speaks of the retribution of poverty and misery. When meeting one who commits sexual misconduct, he speaks of the retribution of sparrows, pigeons, and mandarin ducks (separation of mates). When meeting one of harsh speech, he speaks of the retribution of family strife. When meeting one who slanders, he speaks of the retribution of no tongue and ulcerated mouth. When meeting one of anger, he speaks of the retribution of ugliness and deformity. When meeting a miser, he speaks of the retribution of wishes

unfulfilled. When meeting one who eats and drinks without measure, he speaks of the retribution of hunger, thirst, and throat disease. When meeting one who hunts at will, he speaks of the retribution of terror, madness, and loss of life. When meeting one who rebels against parents, he speaks of the retribution of heavenly and earthly calamity and death. When meeting one who burns mountains and forests, he speaks of the retribution of delusion and seeking death. When meeting a later or former step-parent who is malicious, he speaks of the retribution of being flogged in a future life and receiving retribution now. When meeting one who nets and catches young birds, he speaks of the retribution of bone-and-flesh separation. When meeting one who slanders the Three Jewels, he speaks of the retribution of blindness, deafness, and muteness. When meeting one who disparages the Dharma and is arrogant toward teaching, he speaks of the retribution of dwelling forever in evil paths. When meeting one who misuses the permanent endowment, he speaks of the retribution of millions of kalpas cycling in hell. When meeting one who defiles the pure and falsely accuses monks, he speaks of the retribution of dwelling forever in the animal realm. When meeting one who harms life with boiling water, fire, or cutting, he speaks of the retribution of cycling repayment. When meeting one who breaks precepts and violates fasting, he speaks of the retribution of birds and beasts and hunger.

When meeting one who unreasonably destroys and uses, he speaks of the retribution of wishes lacking and cut off. When meeting one who is arrogant and self-exalting, he speaks of the retribution of being made lowly servant. When meeting one who sows discord with two tongues, he speaks of the retribution of no tongue and a hundred tongues. When meeting one of wrong views, he speaks of the retribution of rebirth in border lands. Thus for such Jambudvipa beings, the results of body, speech, and mind karma, the results of evil habits, hundreds and thousands of retributions, I have roughly spoken.

At that time the great bodhisattva Samantabhadra said to Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva: Virtuous one! I wish you would, for the devas, dragons, and four assemblies, and for all future and present beings, speak of the Saha world and Jambudvipa, the place of retribution received by sinful and suffering beings, the names of hells, and matters of evil retribution, so that beings of the future, in the final Dharma age, may know this retribution. Ksitigarbha answered: Virtuous one! Now relying on the Buddha's awe-inspiring spirit and the power of the great being, I briefly speak of the names of hells and the matters of karmic and evil retribution. Virtuous one! East of Jambudvipa there is a mountain called the Iron Enclosure, dark and deep, without sun or moon light. There is a great hell called the Utter Avici, and again a hell named the Great Avici. Again there is a hell called the Four Corners. Again a hell called the Flying Knife. Again a hell called the Fire Arrow. Again a hell called the Mountain Press. Again a hell called the Thrusting Spear. Again a hell called the Iron Cart. Again a hell called the Iron Bed. Again a hell called the Iron Ox. Again a hell called the Iron Garment. Again a hell called the Thousand Blades.

Again a hell called the Iron Donkey. Again a hell called the Molten Copper. Again a hell called the Embracing Pillar. Again a hell called the Flowing Fire. Again a hell called the Plowing Tongue. Again a hell called the Beheading. Again a hell called the Burning Feet. Again a hell called the Eye-Devouring. Again a hell called the Iron Pellet. Again a hell called the Conflict. Again a hell called the Iron Axe. Again a hell called the Much-Anger. Ksitigarbha said: Virtuous one! Within the Iron Enclosure there are such hells, innumerable in number. There are further the Howling hell, the Tongue-Extraction hell, the Excrement-Urine hell, the Copper-Lock hell, the Fire-Elephant hell, the Fire-Dog hell, the Fire-Horse hell, the Fire-Ox hell, the Fire-Mountain hell, the Fire-Stone hell, the Fire-Bed hell, the Fire-Beam hell, the Fire-Eagle hell, the Saw-Tooth hell, the Skin-Flaying hell, the Blood-Drinking hell, the Hand-Burning hell, the Foot-Burning hell, the Back-Thorn hell, the Fire-House hell, the Iron-House hell, the Fire-Wolf hell. Such hells, each further has various small hells, one or two, three or four, up to hundreds of thousands, their names each different.

Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva said to Samantabhadra Bodhisattva: Virtuous one! All these are the karmic summonings of evil-doing beings of southern Jambudvipa. The power of karma is very great; it can match Sumeru, it can fathom the great ocean, it can obstruct the holy path. Therefore beings must not lightly regard small evils, thinking them blameless; after death there is retribution, and the slightest is received. Father and son, close as they are, take separate roads; even if they meet, none will bear it for the other. Now relying on the Buddha's power, I briefly speak of the matters of hell's karmic retribution; I only wish the virtuous one to listen momentarily to these words. Samantabhadra answered: I have long known the retribution of the three evil paths; I hope the virtuous one will speak, so that all evil-doing beings of later ages and the final Dharma may hear the virtuous one's words and be led to take refuge in the Buddha. Ksitigarbha said: Virtuous one! The karmic retribution of hell is thus. In some hells the sinner's tongue is taken and plowed by an ox. In some hells the sinner's heart is taken and eaten by a yama. In some hells a boiling cauldron seethes, cooking the sinner's body. In some hells a red-hot copper pillar is set, making the sinner embrace it. In some hells fires are made to chase the sinner. In some hells it is always ice and cold.

In some hells, boundless excrement and urine. In some hells, pure flying spikes. In some hells, many piercing fire-spears. In some hells, only the chest and back are beaten. In some hells, only the hands and feet are burned. In some hells, iron snakes coil. In some hells, iron dogs drive. In some hells, all are iron mules. Virtuous one! Such retributions, in each hell, have hundreds of thousands of instruments of the karmic path, none other than copper, iron, stone, and fire, these four materials summoned by the karma of actions. If one broadly describes the matters of hell's karmic retribution, in each hell there are further hundreds of thousands of miseries, let alone many hells. Now relying on the Buddha's awe-inspiring spirit and the virtuous one's question, I have briefly spoken thus. If broadly explained, a kalpa would not exhaust it.

The following explains the above scripture section by section

(1) Ksitigarbha Sutra Scripture in Plain-Language Parallel: What Is the Avici Hell, What Is Retribution

The Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva Purva-pranidhana Sutra passages quoted above (the chapter on the karmic response of Jambudvipa beings, and the chapter on the names of hells) are written in archaic language; the following gives a plain-language section-by-section parallel for easier understanding.

1. Which Five Kinds of People Fall into the Avici Hell

Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva said to Maya: the following five kinds of people are all sentenced to the Avici hell, with 'no time to seek release':

First, being unfilial to parents, even killing them.

Second, drawing the Buddha's blood, slandering the Three Jewels, not revering the honored scriptures.

Third, encroaching on and damaging the permanent endowment, defiling monks and nuns, committing lust or killing within the monastery.

Fourth, falsely posing as a sramana (posing as a monk), whose mind is not that of a sramana, misusing the permanent endowment, deceiving the faithful, violating the precepts.

Fifth, stealing the permanent endowment's wealth, grain, food, clothing, or even taking a single thing without giving.

The weight of these five categories is pierced by one scripture line: 'They shall fall into the Avici hell, for countless hundreds of millions of kalpas, with no time to seek release,' not even a single thought's pause.

2. The Scale and Punishment of the Avici Hell

Location and number: all are within the great Iron Enclosure Mountain. Eighteen great hells, then five hundred, each with a different name; then thousands, also with different names. The single 'Avici' hell is eighty thousand li around, its walls ten thousand li high, made purely of iron.

Upper and lower fires penetrate each other: fire from above penetrates below, fire from below penetrates above; iron snakes and iron dogs spew fire and chase people; the hell's beds fill ten thousand li.

One person also fills, many people also fill: one person receiving punishment sees himself lying filling the whole bed; a thousand or ten thousand people receiving punishment each also sees himself filling the bed.

Punishment: yama and evil ghosts with teeth like swords and eyes like lightning; iron halberds pierce the sinner's mouth, nose, belly, and back, then fling into the air, catch, and throw back onto the bed; iron eagles peck eyes, iron snakes coil necks; hundreds of joints are nailed with long nails, the tongue is pulled and plowed, the intestines drawn and hacked, the mouth filled with molten copper, the body wound with hot iron.

The result is: ten thousand deaths and a thousand births, passing through hundreds of millions of kalpas, with no time to seek release.

3. Hell Also 'Moves House'

The scripture says: when this world perishes, be parasitic in another world; when that world in turn perishes, transfer and be parasitic elsewhere; when that other place perishes, successively transfer. After this world forms again, return.

The meaning is: the hell world constantly collapses and rebuilds, and the sinners endlessly transfer, with no end to suffering. This is not a single prison, but a self-circulating system.

4. Why It Is Called 'Avici': Five 'No-Intervals'

First: day and night receiving punishment until the kalpa count, with no temporal interruption.

Second: one person also fills, many people also fill (the bed is always full).

Third: the instruments of punishment never cease, iron forks, iron eagles, snakes, wolves, dogs, pestles, mills, saws, chisels, boiling cauldrons, iron nets, iron ropes, iron donkeys, iron horses...

Fourth: no distinction of status, man, woman, Qiang, Hu, Yi, Di, old or young, noble or lowly, or dragon, or spirit, or deva, or ghost, karma of offense the same, all receive the same.

Fifth: from entering to leaving the hell, in a single day and night ten thousand deaths and ten thousand births, not even a single thought can stop; only when the karma is exhausted can one receive rebirth.

The fifth point is the most crucial: the only condition for liberation is 'karma exhausted,' not ransom, not begging for mercy, but personally finishing the karma. This is also why the scripture immediately afterward gives the exit of reciting the Buddha's name.

5. Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva's 'Misconduct-Retribution' Parallel Table

This is the most practically valuable part of the whole passage. Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva is not frightening people, but prescribing according to the ailment: what you do, that fruit you will have.

Killing to short life (the retribution of past calamity and short life)

Theft to poverty and misery

Sexual misconduct to sparrows, pigeons, mandarin ducks (separation of mates)

Harsh speech and gossip to family strife, no tongue and a hundred tongues

Slander to no tongue and ulcerated mouth

Slandering the Three Jewels to blindness, deafness, and muteness

Disparaging the Dharma and being arrogant toward teaching to dwelling forever in evil paths

Anger to ugliness and deformity

Miserliness to wishes unfulfilled

Eating and drinking without measure to hunger, thirst, and throat disease

Hunting at will to terror, madness, and loss of life

Rebelling against parents to heavenly and earthly calamity and death

Burning mountains and forests to delusion and seeking death

Netting and catching young birds to bone-and-flesh separation

Malicious former or later step-parents to being flogged in a future life, receiving retribution now

Misusing the permanent endowment to millions of kalpas cycling in hell

Defiling the pure and falsely accusing monks to dwelling forever in the animal realm

Harming life with boiling water, fire, or cutting to cycling repayment

Breaking precepts and violating fasting to birds, beasts, and hunger

Arrogance and self-exalting to being made lowly servant

Wrong views to rebirth in border lands

The scripture finally summarizes: 'Body, speech, and mind karma, the results of evil habits, hundreds and thousands of retributions,' all retributions are created and received by oneself.

6. Three Sentences to Remember

Beings must not lightly regard small evils, thinking them blameless; after death there is retribution, and the slightest is received.

- Do not think small evils are harmless. The smallest mistake is also an account entry.

Father and son, close as they are, take separate roads; even if they meet, none will bear it for the other.

- Even if you meet your parents on the road, no one will bear it for you. This is the coldest line of the whole passage.

The power of karma is very great; it can match Sumeru, fathom the great ocean, and obstruct the holy path.

- The power of karma can support Mount Sumeru, fill the great ocean, and block the path to Buddhahood.

7. How Many Hells Are There

Within the Iron Enclosure Mountain (dark and deep, without sun or moon light), the great hells are: the Utter Avici, the Great Avici, the Four Corners, the Flying Knife, the Fire Arrow, the Mountain Press, the Thrusting

Spear, the Iron Cart, the Iron Bed, the Iron Ox, the Iron Garment, the Thousand Blades, the Iron Donkey, the Molten Copper, the Embracing Pillar, the Flowing Fire, the Plowing Tongue, the Beheading, the Burning Feet, the Eye-Devouring, the Iron Pellet, the Conflict, the Iron Axe, the Much-Anger...

The small hells are: the Howling, the Tongue-Extraction, the Excrement-Urine, the Copper-Lock, the Fire-Elephant, the Fire-Dog, the Fire-Horse, the Fire-Ox, the Fire-Mountain, the Fire-Stone, the Fire-Bed, the Fire-Beam, the Fire-Eagle, the Saw-Tooth, the Skin-Flaying, the Blood-Drinking, the Hand-Burning, the Foot-Burning, the Back-Thorn, the Fire-House, the Iron-House, the Fire-Wolf...

Each great hell also contains hundreds or thousands of small hells within it. And the material of all hells is only four kinds: copper, iron, stone, and fire. The scripture says: if one broadly describes the names of the hell's instruments and the various sufferings, in a single kalpa one could not finish.

8. What This Scripture Passage Really Wants to Say

On the surface it is all frightening, but fright is only the entrance; the exit is behind. The whole structure is: first make clear there is hell, then make clear what retribution, then give the exit.

The method Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva gives is extremely simple: reciting the Buddha's name. The ninth chapter of the Ksitigarbha Sutra, the chapter on Reciting the Buddha's Names, exactly speaks of this exit; the Amitayurdhyana Sutra also says it clearly: 'Because of reciting the Buddha's name, in each thought are eliminated eighty hundred million kalpas of birth-and-death sins.'

So the correct attitude in reading this passage is not fear, but two sentences: first believe 'there is' (the created karma will be received, only a matter of time), then believe 'there is an exit' (reciting the Buddha's name can eliminate it; one need not wait until it is fully eliminated).

(2) The Complete Structure of the Ksitigarbha Sutra and the Benefits of Study and Practice

The Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva Purva-pranidhana Sutra has thirteen chapters, accomplished by the vow-power of Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva. The value of this sutra lies not only in speaking of hell, but even more in its extremely concrete exposition of the method of 'how to save oneself and save one's family.'

1. The Chapter of the Divine Manifestation in the Trayastrimsa Heaven: Sakya Buddha ascends to the Trayastrimsa heaven to speak Dharma for his mother, gathering a great assembly.

2. The Chapter of the Assembly of Manifestation-Bodies: Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva manifests hundreds of millions of billions of bodies, responding and transforming to save in all places.

3. The Chapter of Contemplating Beings' Karmic Conditions: explains what heavy karma causes one to fall into the Avici hell.

4. The Chapter on the Karmic Response of Jambudvipa Beings: details the retributions summoned by beings' evil deeds.

5. The Chapter on the Names of Hells: details the names of hells and the sufferings received.

6. The Chapter of the Tathagata's Praise: the Buddha praises the supreme merit of reciting and offering to Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva.

7. The Chapter on Benefiting the Living and the Dead: reciting Ksitigarbha's name can avert calamity.

8. The Chapter of the Praise by the Assembly of Yama Kings: the ghost kings also praise Ksitigarbha's merit.

9. The Chapter on Reciting the Buddha's Names: reciting the names of various Buddhas can extinguish heavy sins.

10. The Chapter on the Conditions of Comparing the Merit of Giving: details the weighing of the heaviness and lightness of the merit of giving.

11. The Chapter on the Earth Spirit Protecting the Dharma: the earth spirit pledges to protect those who offer to Ksitigarbha images and read the sutra.

12. The Chapter on the Benefits of Seeing and Hearing: the twenty-eight benefits of seeing and hearing Ksitigarbha's form and reading this sutra.

13. The Chapter on Entrusting to Humans and Devas: the Buddha entrusts Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva to protect the beings of the final Dharma age.

Among these, the most relevant to daily benefit is the 'Chapter on the Earth Spirit Protecting the Dharma.' The steadfast earth spirit said to the Buddha: In future ages, if a good man or good woman, in their dwelling place, uses earth, stone, bamboo, or wood to make a shrine, and within can fashion a Ksitigarbha image, burning incense, offering, gazing with reverence, and praising, 'the place where this person dwells gains ten benefits':

First, the land becomes fertile. Second, the home is eternally peaceful. Third, departed ancestors are born to heaven. Fourth, the living gain longevity. Fifth, wishes are fulfilled. Sixth, freedom from water and fire calamities. Seventh, harmful wastage is dispelled. Eighth, evil dreams are cut off. Ninth, coming and going are divinely protected. Tenth, one often meets holy causes.

The earth spirit also said that if one can, regarding this sutra and the bodhisattva's image, 'read and turn the sutra and offer to the bodhisattva,' he will day and night with his own spirit-power guard this person, so that water, fire, thieves, great or small accidents, all evil matters, are completely extinguished. This is probably the most practical passage of the whole sutra.

In the 'Chapter on the Benefits of Seeing and Hearing,' the Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara asked the Buddha: What are the benefits of extolling Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva? The Buddha said: In all worlds of future and present, there are devas whose heavenly blessings are exhausted, who show the five decay signs, or who are about to fall into evil paths; if they encounter Ksitigarbha's name, they gain great benefit.

(3) The Brahman Woman Who Saved Her Loving Mother: the Prototype of Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva

The Sutra of the Bodhisattva Ksitigarbha's Fundamental Vows (Ksitigarbha Sutra) contains a story that is the archetype of Bodhisattva Ksitigarbha, and also the most moving passage in the entire scripture.

Innumerable asankhyeya kalpas ago, a Buddha appeared in the world named Tathagata King of Sovereign Mastery of the Flower of Enlightenment. During the period of the semblance Dharma there was a brahmana woman whose store of past merit was profound and who was respected by all. Her mother, however, believed in heterodox teachings and often slighted the Three Jewels. The holy maiden expounded various skillful means to persuade her mother to give rise to right views, but the mother did not fully believe; ere long she died, and her soul fell into the Avici hell.

The holy maiden knew that her mother, while alive, did not believe in cause and effect, and concluded that she must have fallen into the evil realms in accordance with her karma. So she sold her house, sought far and wide for incense, flowers, and offerings, and made grand offerings at the stupas and monasteries of the former

Buddha. As she gazed in reverence upon the image of Tathagata King of Sovereign Mastery of the Flower of Enlightenment, her devotion redoubled. She thought to herself: 'The Buddha is called the Greatly Enlightened One, possessed of all wisdom; had he been in the world, and had my mother asked the Buddha after her death, he would surely have known her whereabouts.' She wept for a long time, when suddenly a voice from the sky said: 'Weeping holy maiden, do not grieve excessively; I shall now show you the abode of your mother.'

Thereupon a ghost king named Free-from-Poison came to welcome her. The holy maiden asked him what place this was; Free-from-Poison answered: 'This is the Great Iron Enclosure Mountain, the first ocean to its west.' The holy maiden asked where the hells were; Free-from-Poison answered: 'Within the three oceans lie the great hells, hundreds and thousands of them, each different. The greatest comprise eighteen; next are five hundred, with immeasurable bitter suffering; next are thousands upon thousands, likewise with immeasurable suffering.'

Free-from-Poison further told the holy maiden: 'These are the evil-doing beings of Jambudvipa. Those newly dead, after forty-nine days, if no heir performs merit on their behalf to rescue them from suffering, and who in life planted no wholesome causes, will, in accord with the hell their own karma has summoned, naturally cross this ocean first. Ten thousand yojanas east of this ocean there is another ocean, whose suffering is double; east of that ocean there is yet another ocean, whose suffering is again doubled. Summoned by the evil causes of the three karmas, they are together called the Ocean of Karma—and this is that place.'

Free-from-Poison joined his palms and told the holy maiden: 'Your mother, called Joyful Empress, has been reborn in the heavens for three days now. Because her filial child made offerings and cultivated merit for her and gave alms to the stupas and monasteries of Tathagata King of Sovereign Mastery of the Flower of Enlightenment, not only did your mother escape the hells, but all the Avici offenders of that day likewise gained joy and were together reborn.'

The holy maiden then returned as if from a dream; having awakened to this, she stood before the stupa image of Tathagata King of Sovereign Mastery of the Flower of Enlightenment and made a great vow: 'May I, throughout all future kalpas, employ manifold skillful means to bring about the liberation of all beings who suffer under karmic retribution.' The Buddha told Manjusri: 'The ghost king Free-from-Poison of that time is now the Bodhisattva Wealth-Leader; the brahmana woman is none other than Bodhisattva Ksitigarbha.'

What does this story illustrate? The fundamental vow of Bodhisattva Ksitigarbha is not to attain liberation himself first, but rather 'until the hells are empty, I vow not to become a Buddha.' Even the matter of his own mother falling into hell he took as part of his work. This is a concrete demonstration of 'planning one's life'—inscribing the rescue of others into one's own vow-power.

II. An Overview of the Three Sutras and One Treatise on the Pure Land (Life Can Be in One's Own Hands)

(1) The origin of the Infinite Life Sutra (Sukhavativyuha) lies in how the bhiksu Dharmakara renounced kingship to become a monk, met Buddha King of Sovereign Mastery of the World, and thereupon brought forth a great vow. He first praised the World-Honored One with forty-eight verses, of which the most essential is the part that sets forth his vows:

May I become a Buddha, equal to the sage Dharma Kings. May I ferry beings across birth and death; none shall fail to be liberated. Through giving I calm the mind; through precepts, patience, and vigor; such samadhi, with wisdom supreme. I vow to attain Buddhahood and universally practice this vow. For all who are fearful, I shall bring great peace. Suppose there were Buddhas, hundreds of thousands of millions, and measureless great

saints, countless as the Ganges' sand. To make offerings to all such Buddhas is not as good as seeking the Way, firm and upright, never turning back.

May I, becoming Buddha, have a land peerless. Its assembly wondrous, its sacred sites transcendent. The land like nirvana, unmatched and unpaired. I shall take pity and ferry across all. From the ten directions beings come to be born, with joyful and pure minds; having reached my land, they are happy and secure. May the Buddha in faith make clear this, my true witness. I make my vow therein, striving for what I wish.

After these forty-eight verses, the bhiksu Dharmakara addressed the Buddha: 'Yes indeed, World-Honored One, I have brought forth the mind of supreme enlightenment. May the Buddha broadly expound the scriptures and Dharma for me, that I may cultivate them and gather in a pure, majestic, immeasurably wondrous Buddha-land. Allow me in this world swiftly to attain right enlightenment and uproot the root of the toilsome suffering of birth and death.' Buddha King of Sovereign Mastery of the World told him: 'It is like the great ocean—though one were to measure it with a ladle, through kalpas one could yet fathom its bottom and obtain its wondrous jewels; if a person with utmost sincerity and vigor seeks the Way without ceasing, he will surely attain the fruit—what vow could fail to be fulfilled?'

The Forty-Eight Great Vows of the Infinite Life Sutra

(1) If I attain Buddhahood and there are in my land hells, hungry ghosts, or animals, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(2) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land, after the end of their lives, fall again into the three evil realms, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(3) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land are not all of true golden hue, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(4) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land differ in form and complexion, with the beautiful and the ugly, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(5) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not know their past lives, down to not knowing events of hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of kalpas, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(6) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not obtain the heavenly eye, down to not seeing hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of Buddha-lands, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(7) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not obtain the heavenly ear, down to not hearing and fully retaining all that is spoken by hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of Buddhas, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(8) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not obtain the knowledge of others' minds, down to not knowing the thoughts of beings in hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of Buddha-lands, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(9) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not obtain the supernatural foot (rddhi), so that in a single thought-moment they cannot traverse beyond hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of Buddha-lands, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(10) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land give rise to thoughts of greed clinging to the self as body, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(11) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land are not settled in the definite certainty of reaching final nirvana, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(12) If I attain Buddhahood and my radiance can be limited, down to not illuminating hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of Buddha-lands, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(13) If I attain Buddhahood and my lifespan can be limited, down to [less than] hundreds of thousands of millions of nayutas of kalpas, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(14) If I attain Buddhahood and the sravakas in my land can be counted—down to the sravakas and pratyekabuddhas of a trichiliocosm, whom all together over hundreds of thousands of kalpas could calculate and know their number—may I not attain right enlightenment.

(15) If I attain Buddhahood, the humans and devas in my land shall have immeasurable lifespan, except that in accord with their original vows they are free to be long or short. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(16) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land hear even the name of what is unwholesome, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(17) If I attain Buddhahood and the measureless Buddhas of the ten-direction worlds do not all praise and proclaim my name, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(18) If I attain Buddhahood, and beings of the ten directions with sincere faith and joy wish to be born in my land, even with ten thoughts [of my name], yet are not born there, may I not attain right enlightenment. Excepted only are those guilty of the five grave offenses and those who slander the true Dharma.

(19) If I attain Buddhahood, and beings of the ten directions who have aroused the bodhicitta, cultivated various merits, and with sincere vow wish to be born in my land—should I at the end of their lives not appear before them surrounded by my assembly, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(20) If I attain Buddhahood, and beings of the ten directions who hear my name, keep their thoughts fixed on my land, plant roots of virtue, and with sincere dedication wish to be born in my land, are not fulfilled, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(21) If I attain Buddhahood and the humans and devas in my land do not all perfect the thirty-two marks of a great man, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(22) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies from other Buddha-lands who come to be born in my land shall surely reach the stage of one lifetime from Buddhahood. Except those who, by their own vows, freely choose to teach and transform; for the sake of beings they don the armor of the great vows, accumulate roots of virtue, and liberate all; they roam the Buddha-lands practicing the bodhisattva conduct, making offerings to all Tathagata Buddhas of the ten directions; they awaken measureless beings like the Ganges' sand and establish them in the unsurpassed true way, surpassing the ordinary course of the bodhisattva stages, and in their presence cultivate the virtues of Samantabhadra. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(23) If I attain Buddhahood, and the bodhisattvas in my land, relying on the Buddha's spiritual power, in the time of a single meal cannot reach countless immeasurable nayuta Buddha-lands to make offerings to the Buddhas, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(24) If I attain Buddhahood, and the bodhisattvas in my land, before the Buddhas, manifest their roots of virtue, yet their every wish for offerings and requisites is not fulfilled as desired, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(25) If I attain Buddhahood and the bodhisattvas in my land cannot expound all-knowledge, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(26) If I attain Buddhahood and the bodhisattvas in my land do not obtain the vajra-like Narayana body, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(27) If I attain Buddhahood, and the humans, devas, and all things in my land are not supremely pure, radiant, and beautiful, uniquely excellent in form and color, perfect to the subtlest and most wondrous, beyond all measure—and if any being, even one who has attained the heavenly eye, can clearly distinguish and name their numbers, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(28) If I attain Buddhahood and the bodhisattvas in my land, even those of little merit, cannot know and see the immeasurable light and color of the Bodhi-tree, four million li in height, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(29) If I attain Buddhahood and the bodhisattvas in my land, when receiving, reading, reciting, upholding, and expounding the scriptures, do not obtain eloquence and wisdom, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(30) If I attain Buddhahood and the wisdom and eloquence of the bodhisattvas in my land can be limited, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(31) If I attain Buddhahood, my land shall be pure, and all the measureless, countless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions shall be clearly reflected in it as in a bright mirror beholding their images. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(32) If I attain Buddhahood, from the ground up to the empty sky, the palaces, towers, ponds, streams, flowers, and trees—all things in my land—shall be composed of immeasurable varied gems and hundreds of thousands of kinds of fragrance. Adorned wondrously, surpassing humans and devas; their scent pervades the ten-direction worlds, and the bodhisattvas who smell it all cultivate the Buddha's conduct. If it is not thus, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(33) If I attain Buddhahood, among the classes of beings in the measureless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions, those whose bodies are touched by my light shall have bodies and minds soft and pliant, surpassing humans and devas. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(34) If I attain Buddhahood, among the classes of beings in the measureless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions, those who hear my name and do not attain the bodhisattva's patience of the non-arising and the profound dharanis, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(35) If I attain Buddhahood, in the measureless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions, any woman who hears my name with joyful faith and joy, arouses the bodhicitta, and loathes the female body—should she, after the end of her life, again take a female form, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(36) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in the measureless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions who hear my name shall, after the end of their lives, constantly cultivate the pure conduct until they attain the Buddha-way. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(37) If I attain Buddhahood, the devas and humans in the measureless, inconceivable Buddha-worlds of the ten directions who hear my name, prostrating with the five limbs to the ground in reverent bow, with joyful faith and joy cultivate the bodhisattva conduct, and none among devas and humans shall fail to pay homage. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(38) If I attain Buddhahood, when the humans and devas in my land wish for clothing, it shall come at the thought, like the wondrous Dharma-robes praised by the Buddha, naturally upon their bodies; if there be any who must cut, sew, dye, wash, or cleanse them, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(39) If I attain Buddhahood and the happiness enjoyed by the humans and devas in my land is less than that of a bhiksu whose outflows are exhausted, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(40) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattvas in my land who at will wish to see the measureless majestic pure Buddha-lands of the ten directions shall, in that very moment and as they wish, see them all reflected in the jewel trees, as in a bright mirror beholding their images. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(41) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name, up until they attain Buddhahood, shall not have deficient or incomplete sense faculties, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(42) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name shall all attain the samadhi of pure liberation. Abiding in this samadhi, in a single thought-moment they make offerings to the measureless, inconceivable World-Honored Buddhas without losing their concentrated mind. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(43) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name shall, after the end of their lives, be reborn in noble families. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(44) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name shall rejoice with leaps of joy, cultivate the bodhisattva conduct, and perfect their roots of virtue. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(45) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name shall all attain the samadhi of universal equality. Abiding in this samadhi, until they become Buddhas, they constantly behold the measureless, inconceivable all Buddhas. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(46) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattvas in my land shall, in accord with their vows and the Dharma they wish to hear, naturally hear it. If it is not so, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(47) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name, if they do not immediately reach the stage of non-retrogression, may I not attain right enlightenment.

(48) If I attain Buddhahood, the bodhisattva assemblies in other Buddha-lands who hear my name, if they do not immediately reach the first, second, and third patience with regard to the Dharma, and cannot immediately attain non-retrogression in the Buddhas' Dharma, may I not attain right enlightenment.

An Overview in Plain Language of the Forty-Eight Vows of the Infinite Life Sutra

Background: The bhiksu Dharmakara (later Amitabha), drawing upon the excellences of two hundred and ten billion Buddha-lands, spent five kalpas in contemplation and brought forth the forty-eight great vows; if these vows could not be fulfilled, he would not become a Buddha. He then spent immeasurable kalpas accumulating merit and virtue, ultimately accomplishing the Land of Ultimate Bliss. The forty-eight vows fall roughly into three great sections: the environment of the Pure Land of Ultimate Bliss, the enjoyments of the beings reborn there, and the reception of beings from the ten directions to the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

The most famous core: The Eighteenth Vow, the Vow of Rebirth with Ten Invocations, is the essential fundamental vow of the forty-eight.

Part One: The Splendor of the Land of Ultimate Bliss (Vows 1–5)

1. The Vow That the Land Has No Three Evil Realms: After I attain Buddhahood, in the Land of Ultimate Bliss there shall be no such realms of suffering as the hells, hungry ghosts, and animals.

2. The Vow of No More Falling into Evil Realms: Beings born in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, after the end of their lives, shall never again fall into the three evil realms to suffer.

3. The Vow That All Bodies Are Golden: All in the Land of Ultimate Bliss have bodies of the true purple-golden color, pure and majestic.

4. The Vow of No Difference in Form and Complexion: All have equally beautiful appearance, with no distinction of beauty or ugliness, high or low.

5. Regarding the heavenly ear, heavenly eye, knowledge of past lives, knowledge of others' minds, and the supernatural foot (Vows 6–9): Those reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss all possess these spiritual powers—knowing events of countless past kalpas; seeing countless Buddha-lands; hearing the Buddhas of the ten directions expound the Dharma; knowing what others think; and in a single thought-moment flying to countless Buddha-lands to pay homage to the Buddhas and make offerings.

6. The Vow of No View of Self (Vow 10): Beings in the Land of Ultimate Bliss do not cling to the body as 'self,' and do not give rise to thoughts of greed or calculating self-interest.

7. The Vow of Abiding in the Definite Group and Surely Reaching Nirvana (Vow 11): All who are born in the Land of Ultimate Bliss enter the irreversible stage of cultivation and will surely become Buddhas in the future, never again falling back into samsara.

8. The Vow of Immeasurable Light (Vow 12): After attaining Buddhahood, my radiance has no boundary, universally illuminating the countless Buddha-lands of the ten directions.

9. The Vow of Immeasurable Lifespan (Vow 13): The lifespan of myself and of the beings in the Land of Ultimate Bliss is immeasurably long.

10. The humans and devas in the land can all hear at will the Dharma they wish to hear, and all needed material things appear of themselves without lack (Vows 14–17).

Part Two: The Core Vows of Reception (Vows 18, 19, and 20—the three most important vows, dedicated to saving us ordinary beings of the ten-direction worlds)

The Eighteenth Vow [The Vow of Rebirth with Ten Invocations] (the core of the forty-eight vows)

In plain words: All beings in the ten-direction worlds, so long as they sincerely believe and wish to be reborn in my land, even if they only single-mindedly invoke my name ten times with true heart, shall all be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss; only two kinds of people are excepted: those who commit the five grave offenses and those who maliciously slander the Buddha-Dharma.

The Nineteenth Vow [The Vow of Reception at the End of Life]

In plain words: Beings of the ten directions who arouse the bodhicitta seeking Buddhahood, perform various good deeds, and with sincere heart wish to be reborn in my land—when the end of their lives approaches, I shall appear before them together with the holy assembly to welcome them.

The Twentieth Vow [The Vow of Rebirth Through Mindful Recitation]

In plain words: Beings of the ten directions who hear my name, keep their minds single-pointedly on the Land of Ultimate Bliss, accumulate roots of virtue, and dedicate their merit seeking rebirth there, shall all go to the

Land of Ultimate Bliss as they wish.

Part Three: The Guarantee of Practice After Rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss (Vows 21–31)

— The bodhisattvas reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss can all swiftly reach the stage of 'one lifetime from Buddhahood,' meaning they are but one step from becoming a Buddha (Vow 22); unless, by their own vow, they go to other worlds to save beings.

— All clothing, food, and articles for offering to the Buddhas are obtained merely by thought, at one's heart's desire; all attain unobstructed wisdom and eloquence.

— The environment of the Land of Ultimate Bliss—palaces, trees, flowing waters—is entirely made of jewels; the flowing waters and the wind through the trees emit the sound of Dharma, and all beings who hear it give rise to the mind of practice.

— The Land of Ultimate Bliss knows no suffering, only joy; hearing the name of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, body and mind become soft, pliant, and at ease.

Part Four: The Blessing of Bodhisattvas of the Ten Directions, and the Vast Spread of Merit (Vows 32–48)

1. Simply hearing the name of Amitabha, one obtains various samadhis, one's practice does not retrogress, and one swiftly realizes the fruit.

2. Even beings in border regions, who rarely hear the Buddha-Dharma, upon hearing the name also gain peace and joy, and their roots of virtue mature.

3. All who hear the Buddha's name obtain pure roots of virtue and are certain to become Buddhas in the future.

4. Amitabha's vow-power extends throughout the ten directions; all beings without exception receive the blessing of his light and find body and mind settled and secure.

The Core of the Forty-Eight Vows

The great vow of the bhiksu Dharmakara: to establish a Land of Ultimate Bliss free of suffering, with immeasurable lifespan, equality for all, and complete spiritual powers; ordinary beings of the ten directions, so long as they sincerely wish to be reborn there, even with ten invocations of the Buddha's name, shall all be received and brought over; once in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, they shall never again fall into samsara, and shall surely become Buddhas step by step.

(2) The Three Classes and Nine Grades of Rebirth in the Amitayurdhyana Sutra (with emphasis on the lowest of the lowest grade)

At that time the Buddha said to Ananda and Vaidehi: As to the highest grade of the highest class of rebirth: if there are beings who wish to be born in that land and bring forth three kinds of mind, they are immediately reborn there. What are the three? First, the mind of utmost sincerity; second, the profound mind; third, the mind of dedication and vow. Those who possess these three minds are certain to be born in that land. Furthermore, there are three kinds of beings who shall attain rebirth. What are the three? First, the compassionate mind that does not kill and the fulfillment of all precepts; second, the reading and reciting of the Mahayana Vaipulya scriptures; third, the cultivation of the six remembrances. Dedicate the merit and vow to be born in that land. With these merits, in one day up to seven days, they are immediately reborn. At the time of rebirth in that land, because this person is vigorous and courageous, Amitabha Tathagata, together with Avalokitesvara, Mahasthamaprapta, countless transformation Buddhas, hundreds of thousands of bhiksu sravakas, countless devas, and a palace of the seven jewels, comes. Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara holds the vajra platform and, with

Bodhisattva Mahasthamaprapta, arrives before the practitioner. Amitabha Buddha emits great light, illuminating the practitioner's body, and with the bodhisattvas extends his hand to receive and welcome him. Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta, with countless bodhisattvas, praise the practitioner and encourage his mind. Seeing this, the practitioner is filled with joy and leaps for gladness. He sees his own body mount the vajra platform and follow behind the Buddha; in a snap of the fingers he is reborn in that land. Once reborn in that land, he sees the Buddha's physical body complete with all marks and sees the bodhisattvas complete with all marks; the jeweled groves of light expound wondrous Dharma. Having heard it, he immediately awakens to the patience of the non-arising. In a short while he attends upon the Buddhas and pervades the ten-direction realms. Before the Buddhas, one by one, he receives predictions. Returning to his own land, he obtains innumerable hundreds of thousands of dharani gates. This is called the highest grade of the highest class of rebirth.

As to the middle grade of the highest class: one need not receive, uphold, or recite the Vaipulya scriptures. One well understands the meaning and intent, and one's mind is unshaken regarding the supreme truth. With deep faith in cause and effect, one does not slander the Mahayana. With this merit, dedicate and vow to seek rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. One who practices thus, at the approach of death, is met by Amitabha Buddha together with Avalokitesvara, Mahasthamaprapta, and an immeasurable great assembly of attendants, who hold a purple-gold platform and arrive before the practitioner, praising him: 'Dharma-child, you practice the Mahayana and understand the supreme truth; therefore I now come to welcome you.' Together with a thousand transformation Buddhas, they simultaneously extend their hands. The practitioner sees himself seated on the purple-gold platform, palms together, praising the Buddhas; in a single thought-moment he is reborn in the seven-jeweled pond of that land. This purple-gold platform is like a great jeweled flower; after one night it opens. The practitioner's body becomes the purple-golden color, and beneath his feet there are also seven-jeweled lotuses. The Buddha and bodhisattvas simultaneously emit light, illuminating the practitioner's body, and his eyes are at once opened bright. Because of former habits, he hears all sounds, all purely expounding the profound supreme truth. He then descends from the gold platform, bows to the Buddha with palms together, and praises the World-Honored One. In seven days he immediately reaches non-retrogression with respect to anuttara-samyak-sambodhi. At that moment he can fly and pervade the ten directions, attending upon the Buddhas. At the Buddhas' places he cultivates the various samadhis. After one small kalpa he attains the patience of the non-arising and receives a prediction before him. This is called the middle grade of the highest class of rebirth.

As to the lower grade of the highest class: one also believes in cause and effect, does not slander the Mahayana, but merely arouses the mind of the supreme way. With this merit, dedicate and vow to seek rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. At the approach of death, Amitabha Buddha, together with Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta and their retinue, holds golden lotus flowers and transforms into five hundred transformation Buddhas to come welcome this person. The five hundred transformation Buddhas simultaneously extend their hands, praising him: 'Dharma-child, you are now pure and have aroused the mind of the supreme way; I have come to welcome you.' Seeing this, the person sees his own body seated on the golden lotus. Seated, the flower closes, and following the World-Honored One he is immediately reborn in the seven-jeweled pond. After one day and one night the lotus opens. Within seven days he is able to see the Buddha. Though he sees the Buddha's body, his mind is not yet clear about the various marks; only after three times seven days does he see them distinctly. Hearing all sounds, they all expound wondrous Dharma. He roams the ten directions making offerings to the Buddhas. Before the Buddhas he hears the profound Dharma. After three small kalpas he attains the hundred dharma gate of illumination and abides in the stage of joy (Pramudita). This is called the lower grade of the highest class of rebirth. This is called the contemplation of the

highest class of rebirth, the Fourteenth Contemplation.

At that time the Buddha said to Ananda and Vaidehi: As to the highest grade of the middle class: if there are beings who receive and uphold the five precepts, receive and uphold the eight-precept fasting, and cultivate the various precepts; who do not commit the five grave offenses and are free of all faults—with this root of goodness, dedicate and vow to seek rebirth in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss. At the end of life, Amitabha Buddha together with bhiksus and a surrounding retinue emits golden light and comes to that person's place, expounding suffering, emptiness, impermanence, and non-self, and praising renunciation as attaining liberation from the many sufferings. Seeing this, the practitioner is filled with great joy. He sees his own body seated on a lotus platform, kneeling long and with palms together making obeisance to the Buddha. Before he raises his head, he is immediately reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. The lotus opens at once; when it unfolds, he hears the sounds praising the Four Noble Truths and immediately attains the arhat path, with the three insights and six supernatural powers, complete with the eight liberations. This is called the highest grade of the middle class of rebirth.

As to the middle grade of the middle class: if there are beings who for one day and one night receive and uphold the eight-precept fasting, or for one day and one night receive and uphold the sramanera precepts, or for one day and one night receive and uphold the complete precepts, with flawless deportment—with this merit, dedicate and vow to seek rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, their precept-fragrance permeating their cultivation. Such a practitioner, at the approach of death, sees Amitabha Buddha together with his retinue emit golden light and hold a seven-jeweled lotus to arrive before the practitioner. The practitioner himself hears a voice in the sky praising him: 'Good man, because you, a good person, follow the teachings of the Buddhas of the three periods, I have come to welcome you.' The practitioner sees himself seated on the lotus; the lotus immediately closes, and he is born in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss. In the jeweled pond, after seven days the lotus opens. Once it has opened, he opens his eyes and joins his palms, praising the World-Honored One. Hearing the Dharma with joy, he attains the stream-enterer (srota-apanna). After half a kalpa he becomes an arhat. This is called the middle grade of the middle class of rebirth.

As to the lower grade of the middle class: if there are good men or good women who are filial to parents and practice worldly benevolence—at the approach of death such a person meets a good spiritual friend who broadly explains to him the joys of Amitabha's land and also speaks of the forty-eight vows of the bhiksu Dharmakara. Having heard this, he immediately dies; like a strong man bending and stretching his arm, he is at once born in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss. After seven days he meets Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta. Hearing the Dharma with joy, after one small kalpa he becomes an arhat. This is called the lower grade of the middle class of rebirth. This is called the contemplation of the middle class of rebirth, the Fifteenth Contemplation.

At that time the Buddha said to Ananda and Vaidehi: As to the highest grade of the lowest class: there may be beings who commit many evil deeds. Although they do not slander the Vaipulya scriptures, such foolish ones commit many evils without shame. At the approach of death they meet a good spiritual friend who praises for them the titles of the twelve divisions of the Mahayana scriptures. By hearing these scripture names, a thousand kalpas of extremely heavy evil karma are removed. The wise one further teaches them to join palms and invoke Namo Amitabha Buddha. By invoking the Buddha's name, fifty billion kalpas of the karma of birth and death are removed. At that time that Buddha immediately dispatches transformation Buddhas, a transformation Avalokitesvara, and a transformation Mahasthamaprapta to arrive before the practitioner, praising him: 'Good man, because you have invoked the Buddha's name, your offenses are extinguished; I have come to welcome you.' Having spoken thus, the practitioner sees the transformation Buddha's light filling his room; seeing it, he

is joyful and immediately dies. Mounting a jeweled lotus, he follows behind the transformation Buddha and is born in the jeweled pond. After seven times seven days the lotus opens. When the lotus opens, the great compassion Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta emit great light, stand before the person, and expound for him the profound twelve divisions of the scriptures. Having heard them, he believes and understands, and arouses the mind of the supreme way. After ten small kalpas he perfects the hundred dharma gate of illumination and enters the first stage (bhumi). This is called the highest grade of the lowest class of rebirth. Having heard the names of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha—having heard the names of the Three Jewels—one is immediately reborn.

At that time the Buddha said to Ananda and Vaidehi: As to the middle grade of the lowest class: there may be beings who violate the five precepts, the eight precepts, and the complete precepts. Such foolish ones steal from the Sangha's store, steal the property of the present Sangha, expound the Dharma impurely, and are without shame, adorning themselves with various evil deeds. Because of such evil karma, such offenders should fall into hell. At the approach of death, the fires of hell arrive all at once. They meet a good spiritual friend who, with great compassion, speaks to them of Amitabha Buddha's ten powers and majestic virtue, broadly explaining that Buddha's light and spiritual power, and also praising precepts, concentration, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge and vision of liberation. Having heard this, the person removes eighty billion kalpas of the karma of birth and death. The fierce hell-fire is transformed into a cool breeze bearing heavenly flowers. Upon the flowers are all transformation Buddhas and bodhisattvas welcoming this person; in a single thought-moment he is immediately reborn. Within the lotus in the seven-jeweled pond, after six kalpas the lotus opens. When the lotus opens, Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta, with Brahma-voiced sound, comfort that person and expound for him the profound Mahayana scriptures. Having heard this Dharma, at that moment he arouses the mind of the supreme way. This is called the middle grade of the lowest class of rebirth.

At that time the Buddha said to Ananda and Vaidehi: As to the lowest grade of the lowest class: there may be beings who commit unwholesome deeds—the five grave offenses and the ten evils, fully possessed of all that is unwholesome. Such foolish ones, because of evil karma, should fall into the evil realms and undergo endless suffering through many kalpas. Such foolish ones, at the end of life, meet a good spiritual friend who with various comforts speaks the wondrous Dharma and teaches them to recite the Buddha's name. Afflicted by suffering, they have no leisure to recite. The good friend tells them: 'If you cannot recite, you should invoke Amitabha of Immeasurable Life.' With such sincere mind, let the sound be unceasing; with full ten invocations, invoke Namo Amitabha Buddha. By invoking the Buddha's name, in each thought-moment eighty billion kalpas of the karma of birth and death are removed. At the end of life, they see a golden lotus like the disc of the sun standing before them. In a single thought-moment they are immediately reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. Within the lotus, after a full twelve great kalpas, the lotus opens. Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta, with voices of great compassion, broadly expound for them the true characteristic of all dharmas and the method of removing offenses. Having heard it with joy, at that moment they arouse the mind of bodhi. This is called the lowest grade of the lowest class of rebirth. This is called the contemplation of the lowest class of rebirth, the Sixteenth Contemplation.

A Key Summary of the Nine Grades of Rebirth in the Amitayurdhyana Sutra

General premise: All nine grades are reborn in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss, and the core requirement for all is the three minds—the mind of utmost sincerity, the profound mind, and the mind of dedication and vow. The differences lie in the depth of wholesome roots while alive, the gravity of karma created, and the shallowness or depth of faith and understanding, which result in differences in the reception at the end of life, the speed of the lotus opening, and the time to awakening after reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

They are divided into three great classes, and each class is further divided into upper, middle, and lower grades, making nine grades in all.

The first great class: the three grades of the highest class (Mahayana faculties, who arouse the bodhicitta and cultivate Mahayana wholesome Dharma)

Highest Grade of the Highest Class

Conditions: Arouse the sincere mind seeking Buddhahood; compassion and not killing; upholding the precepts; reading and reciting Mahayana scriptures; deep faith in the Mahayana teachings; and dedicating merit seeking rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

At the end of life: Amitabha Buddha, Avalokitesvara, and Mahasthamaprapta, together with countless transformation Buddhas and holy beings, personally come to welcome the person, bearing the vajra platform.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: as soon as one arrives, the lotus opens at once; one immediately sees the Buddha and hears the Dharma, on the spot realizing the patience of the non-arising, and swiftly becomes a Buddha.

Middle Grade of the Highest Class

Conditions: Not necessarily reading scriptures, but able to understand the meaning and principle of the Mahayana Dharma, with deep faith in cause and effect, not slandering the Mahayana, and arousing the bodhicitta vowing to be reborn in the Pure Land.

At the end of life: The Three Saints of the West, with the great assembly, come to receive and guide, bearing the purple-gold platform.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: after one night the lotus opens; hearing the Dharma one awakens to the Way; after one small kalpa one realizes the patience of the non-arising.

Lower Grade of the Highest Class

Conditions: Belief in cause and effect, no slandering of the Mahayana, and arousing the bodhicitta that seeks the Buddha-way above and saves beings below.

At the end of life: The Three Saints, bearing golden lotus flowers, with five hundred transformation Buddhas, come to welcome.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: the lotus opens after seven days; after three small kalpas, one enters the stage of the first ground (bhumi) bodhisattva.

Common points of the three highest grades: they belong to Mahayana practitioners; at the end of life the true Buddha personally appears to receive them; after rebirth they directly become bodhisattvas.

The second great class: the three grades of the middle class (upholding precepts and practicing goodness, centered on worldly good and Hinayana precepts)

Highest Grade of the Middle Class

Conditions: Upholding the five precepts and the eight-precept fasting all one's life, strictly keeping the precepts, not committing the five grave offenses, doing good and not evil, and dedicating merit seeking rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

At the end of life: Amitabha Buddha, together with bhiksu holy beings, comes to welcome; one is reborn riding the lotus.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: the lotus opens at once; hearing the Hinayana teachings, one swiftly attains arhatship.

Middle Grade of the Middle Class

Conditions: Even if only for one day and one night one earnestly upholds the eight-precept fasting and maintains flawless deportment, dedicating this merit seeking rebirth.

At the end of life: Amitabha Buddha's transformation body comes to welcome.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: after seven days the lotus opens; after another half small kalpa one attains arhatship.

Lower Grade of the Middle Class

Conditions: One has not specifically received the Buddha's precepts, but is a worldly good person: filial to parents, loyal and righteous toward others, doing worldly good all one's life; at the end of life one hears the Buddha-Dharma and arouses the vow to be reborn.

At the end of life: one meets Amitabha Buddha's transformation Buddha who comes to receive and guide.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: after seven days, Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta Bodhisattvas come to expound the Dharma for him.

Common points of the three middle grades: centered on upholding precepts and worldly good deeds; without deep understanding of Mahayana principles, after rebirth one first attains arhatship, then later cultivates Mahayana practice.

The third great class: the three grades of the lowest class (those who created evil in life, who rely on end-of-life repentance and Buddha-recitation for rebirth—this is the most striking part of the Contemplation Sutra)

Key point: The three lowest grades of people all created very heavy evil karma in life and were originally destined to fall into the evil realms; relying on end-of-life repentance and Buddha-recitation, they are saved by the Buddha's power.

Highest Grade of the Lowest Class

Conditions: One creates much evil in life (the ten evils), but has not committed the five grave offenses. At the end of life one meets a good spiritual friend who teaches Buddha-recitation, repentance of offenses, and the vow to be reborn.

At the end of life: the transformation Buddha comes to receive and guide.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: the lotus stays closed for forty-nine days before opening; after it opens, Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta Bodhisattvas expound the Dharma for him.

Middle Grade of the Lowest Class

Conditions: In life one violated the precepts and created much evil karma. At the end of life one meets a good spiritual friend who reveals Amitabha's name, and one repents, recites the Buddha, and arouses the vow.

At the end of life: one sees the transformation Buddha come to welcome.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: the lotus remains closed for six kalpas; when it opens, a bodhisattva comes to teach and transform.

Lowest Grade of the Lowest Class (the most important)

Conditions: One commits the five grave offenses (killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, breaking the harmony of the Sangha, shedding the Buddha's blood); the offense is very heavy and one was originally bound for hell. At the end of life, in unbearable suffering, one meets a good spiritual friend who teaches Buddha-recitation; with sincere mind one invokes Amitabha Buddha ten times, repents, and arouses the vow.

At the end of life: at the very moment of reciting the Buddha, the transformation Buddha comes to receive and guide, freeing one from the suffering of hell.

Upon reaching the Land of Ultimate Bliss: confined within the lotus for twelve great kalpas; after the lotus opens, Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta Bodhisattvas expound the Dharma for him, and he gradually awakens.

An Overall Summary of the Core

1. Whether one's grade is high or low depends on the depth of one's cultivation in reciting the Buddha's name, not on how much one recites; yet even one who has committed the five grave offenses, so long as at the end of life he sincerely repents, recites the Buddha ten times, and resolves to be reborn, can still be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss—it is only that the time spent waiting in the lotus for awakening is very long.

2. The upper grades are those of Mahayana bodhisattva nature, who see the true Buddha, whose lotus opens quickly, and who swiftly become Buddhas; the middle grades are precept-keeping good people; the lower grades are evil-doers, saved entirely by the vow-power of Amitabha Buddha.

3. All nine grades are irreversible: once born in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, one forever no longer falls into the evil realms such as hell or the animal realm; only the speed of the lotus opening, seeing the Buddha, and awakening differs.

4. The key point: the lowest of the lowest grade corresponds to the Eighteenth Vow of the Infinite Life Sutra—rebirth with ten invocations—which is the very core of the Pure Land teaching; ordinary beings with heavy offenses are saved by the Buddha's power through faith and vow.

(3) The Pure Land or Questions (Jingtu Huowen) by the Yuan-dynasty Dharma Master Tianru Weize:

Question: 'There are many kinds of shared abodes of purity; why now single out the Land of Ultimate Bliss, and why further exclusively praise its superior environment and superior conditions?' Answer: 'The sutra says: "The beings of that land have no numerous sufferings, but enjoy all pleasures; therefore it is called Ultimate Bliss." Now comparing it with Saha: Here we have flesh-and-blood bodies, and all born must suffer; there they are born by transformation from the lotus, with no suffering of birth. Here the seasons revolve and old age daily encroaches; there cold and heat do not change, with no suffering of old age. Here the four great elements are hard to balance and illness often arises; there the transformed body is fragrant and pure, with no suffering of sickness. Here those who reach seventy are few and impermanence is swift; there lifespan is immeasurable, with no suffering of death. Here there is affection and attachment to kin, and where there is love there must be separation; there are no parents, wife, or children, with no suffering of separation from those one loves. Here there are enemies and foes, and where there is enmity there must be meeting; there the supremely good gather together, with no suffering of meeting those one hates. Here there is hardship, hunger, and cold, and greedy seeking that is never satisfied; there all have clothing, food, and jewels, ready at hand for use. Here there may be ugly and foul bodies, with faculties often deficient and flawed; there they have dignified and majestic appearance, with bodies that emit light.

Here one revolves in birth and death; there one eternally realizes the non-arising. Here there is the suffering of the four destinies; there the very name of the three evils does not exist. Here there are hills and pits, thorny thickets for forests, earthen and stony mountains, filled with filth and evil; there gold is the ground, jeweled trees reach the sky, towers rise of the seven treasures, and flowers display the four colors. Here the Twin Trees have passed away and the Dragon-Flower is yet to come; there the Honored One of Immeasurable Life is now expounding the Dharma. Here Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta are but names looked up to in vain; there one is personally a noble friend to those two worthy ones. Here hordes of maras and outside paths disturb right cultivation; there the Buddha's transformation reigns unified and maras and outsiders leave no trace. Here seductive forms and wantonness delude the practitioner; there the personal retribution is pure, with truly no women. Here evil beasts and mountain sprites alternately fan the sounds of heresy; there water, birds, and trees all proclaim the wondrous Dharma. Comparing the two lands, environment and conditions are utterly different, and the excellences of the Land of Bliss are without number, more than can be fully enumerated here. Its superior environment can capture beings' inclination toward purity; its superior conditions can assist the practitioner's power of cultivation. Although there are many kinds of shared pure abodes, only the Land of Ultimate Bliss has complete conditions for cultivation; therefore it is singled out.

'Further questioned: "All Tathagatas of the ten directions can be approached; why now exclusively exalt Amitabha?" Answer: "There are three reasons for exclusively exalting Amitabha: first, the profundity and weight of his vows; second, his affinity with Saha; third, the relatedness of his teaching mission. As to the weight of vows: the sutras say that in the causal stage of the past, Amitabha once brought forth various vast and great vows, the gist of which is: 'If, since my attainment of Buddhahood, there be beings who wish to be born in my land, or who hear my name, cultivate wholesome roots, and call my name, even ten times, and are not reborn, I vow not to attain right enlightenment. Once born in my land, if any should retrogress or not definitely become a Buddha, I vow not to attain right enlightenment.' Therefore the Huayan Commentary says: 'Amitabha's vows are weighty; he especially receives the beings of Saha.' As to affinity: when our Buddha Sakyamuni was in the world, beings who heard the Buddha's teaching and turned toward Amitabha were already many. Observe that after the Buddha's extinction, among beings of the degenerate age, regardless of monk or lay, male or female, noble or base, rich or poor, those who have slightly heard of Buddhism all believe and turn toward him; even those who have not heard of Buddhism will also call his name. Even obstinate, foolish, violent, evil, and faithless persons, when meeting perilous danger, or uttering sounds of praise or lament, involuntarily and without thinking call out 'Amitabha Buddha.'

'As for children and women at play, piling sand and molding clay, painting walls and plastering, they make images of Amitabha Buddha. Even those who have not yet learned to walk steadily or to speak clearly naturally can sing 'Amitabha Buddha.' All this arises without being urged and is accomplished without being taught—if not affinity, what else could it be? Again, as the Infinite Life Sutra says: 'I speak this sutra so that now you may see Amitabha Buddha and his land; whatever should be done may all be sought. Do not, after my extinction, give rise to doubt again. In the age to come, when the sutras and the Way have perished, out of compassion I shall specially leave this sutra to remain another hundred years. Beings who encounter this sutra may, according to their wishes, all be saved.' Further, the sutra says: 'After this sutra perishes and the Buddha-Dharma is wholly gone, only the four-character name "Amitabha Buddha" shall remain to save beings. Those who disbelieve and slander it shall fall into hell and fully undergo all sufferings.' Therefore Tiantai said: 'Know that that Buddha has special affinity with this evil age.' As to relatedness: earlier awakened ones said that the sages of the two lands manifest dwelling in purity and defilement, using the two gates of subduing and receiving to tame beings.

'Here, by defilement, by suffering, by brevity, and by many mara-afflictions, he subdues them, making them know what to loathe; there, by purity, by joy, by longevity, and by non-retrogression, he receives them, making them know what to rejoice in. Once they both loathe and rejoice, the teaching mission proceeds. Moreover, apart from Sakyamuni's teaching of the three vehicles, those not yet fully liberated are to be liberated by Amitabha; hence in the various Mahayana sutras he repeatedly and earnestly praises and urges rebirth—this is the relatedness of the teaching mission. For these three reasons, Amitabha alone is exalted.'

To summarize the content of this Pure Land or Questions, it mainly answers two questions:

1. Why single out the Land of Ultimate Bliss?

Because the Land of Ultimate Bliss is far better than our world, and its conditions for cultivation are also the best.

Our world: has birth, old age, sickness, death; separation from loved ones; meeting those one hates; not getting what one seeks; samsara; the three evil realms; a foul and disordered environment; disturbance by maras and outsiders; many temptations; and the Buddha has already passed into extinction.

The Land of Ultimate Bliss: born by lotus transformation, with no birth, old age, sickness, or death; no separation from loved ones or meeting those one hates; clothing, food, and jewels appear of themselves ready at hand; dignified appearance and bodies that emit light; eternally free of birth and death; no three evil realms; gold for ground, jeweled trees and towers; Amitabha Buddha now expounding the Dharma; Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta are close friends; no maras to disturb; no women to tempt; water, birds, and trees all expounding the Dharma.

Therefore the Land of Ultimate Bliss:

• Has a fine environment that makes one willing to be reborn there;

• Has fine conditions for cultivation that help one practice without retrogression.

Although there are many 'shared pure abodes,' the Land of Ultimate Bliss has the most complete conditions for cultivation; therefore it is especially singled out.

2. Why exclusively exalt Amitabha Buddha?

There are three reasons:

1. His vow-power is especially weighty.

Amitabha Buddha made a great vow: if beings wish to be reborn and call his name, even ten times, and are not reborn, he will not become a Buddha; once reborn, if any retrogress or cannot definitely become a Buddha, he also will not become a Buddha. Therefore his vow-power especially inclines to receive the beings of Saha.

2. His affinity with the Saha world is especially deep.

When Sakyamuni Buddha was in the world, many already turned toward Amitabha Buddha. After the Buddha's extinction, regardless of monk or lay, male or female, noble or base, rich or poor, those who have slightly heard of Buddhism mostly believe and turn toward him; even those who have not heard will also recite 'Amitabha Buddha.' Even when meeting danger or suffering, unconsciously they cry out 'Amitabha Buddha.' Children at play also draw Amitabha's image and sing his name. This shows the beings of Saha have special affinity with Amitabha Buddha. The sutra also says that after the Dharma-ending age, when the sutras and the Way have perished, the four-character name 'Amitabha Buddha' shall remain to save beings.

3. It is related to Sakyamuni Buddha's teaching mission.

Sakyamuni Buddha, in the defiled land, uses suffering, defilement, brevity, and mara-afflictions to subdue us and make us weary of it; Amitabha Buddha, in the pure land, uses purity, joy, longevity, and non-retrogression to receive us and make us aspire to it. The beings Sakyamuni Buddha could not fully liberate are entrusted to Amitabha Buddha for liberation. Therefore the Mahayana sutras repeatedly urge people to be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

Summary

The Land of Ultimate Bliss has the best conditions for cultivation; Amitabha Buddha has the greatest vow-power, the deepest affinity with Saha, and the closest relation to Sakyamuni's teaching mission; therefore the Land of Ultimate Bliss is singled out and Amitabha Buddha is exclusively exalted.

(1) The Scriptural Basis of the Pure Land Teaching

The scriptures on which the Pure Land teaching relies are called the 'Three Sutras and One Treatise on the Pure Land':

1. The Buddha Speaks of the Sutra of Immeasurable Life (Sukhavativyuha Sutra), translated by Kang Sengkai. Its core is the forty-eight vows of Bodhisattva Dharmakara, among which the Eighteenth Vow states: 'If I attain Buddhahood, beings of the ten directions who with sincere faith and joy wish to be born in my land, even with ten invocations, and are not reborn, may I not attain right enlightenment. Excepted only are the five grave offenses and slander of the true Dharma.' This vow is called the 'fundamental vow' and is also the most important promise among the three sutras. The key point here is that the object of Amitabha Buddha's promise is all six-realm beings throughout the entire universe.

2. The Buddha Speaks of the Sutra of Contemplation of the Buddha of Immeasurable Life (Amitayurdhyana Sutra), translated by Kalayasas. Regarding the nine grades of rebirth in the Amitayurdhyana Sutra, the most important point is not memorizing the details of each grade, but grasping the fundamental principle and the interpretive logic behind it. It can be condensed into the following four layers of core:

(1) Fundamental principle: The nine grades of rebirth rely entirely on 'riding the Buddha's vow-power.'

The common basis of the nine grades of rebirth is not earned by the 'absolute level' of the ordinary person's own cultivation, but is attained by being received by Amitabha Buddha at the end of life and riding the Buddha's vow-power to rebirth. The verdict of Great Master Ouyi (Zhi Xu) is most succinct:

'Whether one is reborn depends entirely on the presence or absence of faith and vow; the high or low grade depends entirely on the depth of one's holding of the name.'

That is to say, the very matter of 'rebirth' has faith and vow as its threshold; the difference among the nine grades is only the grade difference formed by the differing depth of Buddha-recitation practice, under the premise that faith and vow are already present.

(2) The essence of the nine-grade difference: not a 'difference between ordinary and sage,' but a 'difference in the conditions encountered.'

Many commentators of the Sui and Tang periods judged the highest grade of the highest class to be a ground-entering bodhisattva and the middle class to be an arhat, which would leave no share for ordinary beings. Great Master Shandao, with the spirit of 'rectifying the ancients and moderns,' overturned this view, pointing out:

'The nine grades of rebirth are all ordinary beings, having nothing to do with sages... it is the difference in the conditions encountered that leads to the difference in the nine grades of rebirth.'

Specifically: the upper three grades are ordinary beings who encountered Mahayana Dharma; the middle three grades are ordinary beings who encountered Hinayana Dharma; the lower three grades are ordinary beings who encountered evil Dharma and evil conditions. The significance of this interpretation is extremely far-reaching: it pulls the nine grades back from a 'sage qualification contest' to the real predicament of ordinary beings, giving every ordinary being a true share in the highest grade of the highest class.

3. The two most crucial lines of difference among the nine grades: the reception at the end of life and the speed of the lotus opening.

The differences among the nine grades in their resultant state are most concentratedly embodied in two places:

(1) The specification of the reception at the end of life differs. The highest grade of the highest class is received in person by Amitabha Buddha with countless bodhisattva holy beings, riding the vajra platform; the middle grade of the highest rides the purple-gold platform, the lower grade of the highest rides the golden lotus; the middle class sees the Buddha with the bhiksu assembly; the lower class is mostly welcomed by transformation Buddhas and transformation bodhisattvas. The 'specification' of the reception itself is a natural reflection of the depth of one's cultivation resources.

(2) The speed of the lotus opening to see the Buddha varies greatly. The highest grade of the highest class opens at birth, and upon hearing the Dharma immediately awakens to the patience of the non-arising; the middle grade of the highest opens after one night, attaining the patience of the non-arising in one small kalpa; the lower grade of the highest opens after one day and one night, abiding in the stage of joy (Pramudita) after three small kalpas; the highest grade of the middle opens at once, immediately attaining arhatship; the middle grade of the middle opens after seven days; the lower grade of the middle meets Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta and hears the Dharma after seven days; the highest grade of the lowest opens after seven times seven days; the middle grade of the lowest opens after six kalpas; the lowest grade of the lowest must wait twelve great kalpas for the lotus to open. The speed of the lotus opening is the most intuitive 'measure of the resultant mark' among the nine grades.

4. The grade most needing to be appreciated: the lowest of the lowest—the bottom line of the teaching's thorough salvation.

The lowest of the lowest is the most extreme case among the nine grades: one who commits the five grave offenses and the ten evils and should fall into hell, at the end of life the hellish signs appear; meeting a good spiritual friend who teaches Buddha-recitation, even ten invocations, calling 'Namo Amitabha Buddha,' in each thought-moment removes eighty billion kalpas of heavy karma of birth and death, and at once sees the golden lotus come to receive and guide to rebirth.

The profound meaning of this grade is not to encourage evil-doing, but to reveal that Amitabha Buddha's salvation does not take the practitioner's 'degree of cleanliness' as prerequisite, but takes 'faith, vow, and calling the name' as the passage. Even the most gravely offense-laden ordinary being, with no cultivation to speak of, so long as at the end of life he accepts in faith and calls the name, the Buddha's vow-power still receives and never abandons him. This is the ultimate proof of why the Pure Land teaching is called 'salvation by other power,' and is also the stroke among the nine-grade interpretations that most embodies the great compassion of the Buddha's mind.

In summary: the key point of the nine grades of rebirth is not a leaderboard to compare against and see 'which grade one can attain,' but a framework of salvation that declares 'ordinary beings ride the Buddha's vow-power, differ in the conditions encountered, and thus differ in resultant rank.' Understanding this framework, the nine grades are not pressure, but the confidence that every path from the lowest of the lowest to the highest of the highest is truly walkable. Finally, in the transmission section, Sakyamuni Buddha urges the recitation of Namo Amitabha Buddha: 'The Buddha told Ananda, you should well uphold these words. To uphold these words is to uphold the name of Amitabha Buddha.' The Contemplation Sutra says: one who recites the Buddha is 'a white lotus among humans'; Great Master Shandao said, 'One who recites the Buddha is a good person among humans, a wonderfully good person among humans, a supreme person among humans, a rare person among humans, the most excellent person among humans.' For this reason the method of Buddha-recitation is called the 'easy path' and the 'hard-to-believe Dharma.'

The Contemplation Sutra begins with the easiest contemplation, the contemplation of the sun, gradually delving deeper layer by layer, and finally returns to the proper cultivation. Its sixteen contemplations, in the order of the sutra, are: the contemplation of the sun, of water, of the land, of the jeweled trees, of the jeweled pools, of the jeweled towers, of the lotus seats, of the jeweled images, of the true body, of Avalokitesvara, of Mahasthamaprapta, the universal contemplation, the mixed contemplation, the contemplation of the highest class of rebirth, the contemplation of the middle class of rebirth, and the contemplation of the lowest class of rebirth.

The Buddha proclaimed an extremely important principle:

All Tathagata Buddhas are the Dharma-realm body, entering into the thoughts of all beings. Therefore, when you think of the Buddha, that mind itself is the thirty-two marks and the eighty secondary characteristics. This mind makes the Buddha; this mind is the Buddha. The ocean of the Buddhas' right and universal knowledge arises from the mind's thoughts. Therefore you should single-mindedly fix your thought and contemplatively behold that Buddha, Tathagata (Duota Agadu), Arhat (Aluohe), Samyaksambuddha (Sanmiao Sanputi).

'This mind makes the Buddha; this mind is the Buddha'—reciting the Buddha is not to manufacture a Buddha, but to manifest the Buddha-nature within your mind that is obscured by afflictions. This saying can be regarded as the theoretical foundation of the entire Pure Land teaching.

The verdict at the end of the Contemplation Sutra makes the intent of the whole sutra perfectly clear:

This sutra is named the Contemplation of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, Amitabha Buddha, Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara, and Bodhisattva Mahasthamaprapta; it is also named the Purification of Karmic Obstacles and Being Born Before All Buddhas. You should receive and uphold it, and not let it be forgotten. One who practices this samadhi sees Amitabha Buddha and the two great bodhisattvas in the present body. If a good man or good woman merely hears the name of the Buddha and the two bodhisattvas, immeasurable kalpas of the karma of birth and death are removed—how much more by recollection. If one recites the Buddha, know that this person is a white lotus among humans. Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara and Bodhisattva Mahasthamaprapta are his noble friends. He shall sit in the bodhimanda and be born into the family of all Buddhas.

The Contemplation Sutra also specially records the account of Queen Vaidehi and her five hundred attendant women hearing the Dharma and realizing the fruit:

As these words were spoken, Vaidehi and her five hundred attendant women, hearing what the Buddha taught, at that very moment saw the vast and extended signs of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, beheld the Buddha's body and the two bodhisattvas, gave rise to joy in their minds, marveled at the unprecedented, were vastly and greatly

awakened, and attained the patience of the non-arising. The five hundred attendant women aroused the mind of anuttara-samyak-sambodhi, vowed to be born in that land, and the World-Honored One predicted for them all that they would be reborn.

3. The Buddha Speaks of the Amitabha Sutra (Amitabha Sutra), translated by Kumarajiva: 'Sariputra, if there be a good man or good woman who, having heard of Amitabha Buddha, holds fast to his name for one day, two days, three days, four days, five days, six days, or seven days with unwavering one-pointed mind—at the end of that person's life, Amitabha Buddha and the holy assembly will appear before them. At the end of life, with mind unconfused, that person is immediately reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss of Amitabha Buddha.' 'One cannot be reborn in that land by meager roots of virtue, merit, and favorable conditions'—here Great Master Ouyi, in his Essential Commentary on Amitabha, explains that reciting Namo Amitabha Buddha is precisely abundant roots of virtue, merit, and favorable conditions. The Amitabha Sutra concludes by stating that this teaching is the 'sutra protected and remembered by all Buddhas.'

4. The Commentary on the Rebirth Aspiration Verses (Upadesa) of the Infinite Life Sutra (translated by Bodhiruci, commented by Great Master Tanluan), together with the Collection of Peace and Joy (An Le Ji, by Daochuo), the Four Commentaries on the Contemplation Sutra (by Shandao), and the Ten Essentials of the Pure Land (compiled by Great Master Ouyi), are exegetical and propagative works explaining and spreading the above scriptures.

(2) The Three Conditions for Rebirth: Faith, Vow, and Practice

The three provisions (sustenance) of the Pure Land teaching are precisely these three: faith, vow, and practice.

To use an analogy: it is like going to a faraway but especially good place to settle down.

1. Faith—truly believing.

Believe that Amitabha Buddha truly exists and the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss truly exists; believe that Amitabha Buddha's vow-power is real and unfalse, and that by reciting the Buddha the Buddha will come to receive one at the end of life; also believe that so long as one truly believes and earnestly vows and recites the Buddha, one can be reborn. This is not superstition, but faith in the Buddha, faith in the Dharma, and faith that one's own recitation of the Buddha can resonate and connect. Believe in the inconceivable power of the Buddha, the inconceivable power of the Dharma (Amitabha's forty-eight vows and his name), and the inconceivable power of our own mind.

2. Vow—truly wishing to go (wearying of Saha, rejoicing in the Land of Ultimate Bliss).

In one's heart truly willing to be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, willing to renounce this world's afflictions, impermanence, and samsara. Not merely saying 'I want to go' with the mouth while the heart still clings to here. One must arouse the vow: in this life, at the end, to be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. The more sincere the vow, the firmer the direction.

3. Practice—truly reciting the Buddha.

Actually doing it, mainly by reciting 'Namo Amitabha Buddha.' Whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, busy or idle, one can recite; at the end of life one also relies on this Buddha-name. One may also read sutras, bow to the Buddha, and dedicate merit, but the core of the Pure Land teaching is reciting the name.

The relationship among the three can be understood thus:

• Faith: believing there is a vehicle, a driver, and a destination.

• Vow: truly willing to get on the vehicle and go.

• Practice: actually buying the ticket, getting on, and setting off.

Faith without vow is like knowing a place is good yet not wanting to go;

Vow without practice is like wanting to go yet not moving;

Practice without faith and vow is like walking blindly, easily losing heart.

So in one phrase: truly believe in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, truly vow to go there, truly recite Amitabha Buddha.

Such are the three provisions of faith, vow, and practice of the Pure Land teaching. Faith and vow determine whether one can be reborn; the depth of one's Buddha-recitation practice affects the grade of rebirth.

Great Master Ouyi taught: without faith one cannot arouse the vow; without the vow one cannot guide the practice; without the wondrous practice of holding the name one cannot fulfill the vow and realize the faith.

(3) The Appearance of the Land of Ultimate Bliss

The Amitabha Sutra describes:

The Amitabha Sutra begins with the concrete appearance of the Land of Ultimate Bliss and is the most accessible introductory scripture of the Pure Land teaching. The Buddha said to Sariputra:

To the west of here, beyond ten trillion Buddha-lands, there is a world called Ultimate Bliss. In that land there is a Buddha named Amitabha, who is now expounding the Dharma.

Sariputra, why is that land called Ultimate Bliss? The beings of that land have no numerous sufferings but enjoy all pleasures; therefore it is called Ultimate Bliss.

Again, Sariputra, the Land of Ultimate Bliss has sevenfold railings, sevenfold nets, and sevenfold rows of trees, all surrounded by the four jewels; therefore that land is called Ultimate Bliss. Again, Sariputra, the Land of Ultimate Bliss has pools of the seven jewels filled with the water of eight virtues. The pool bottoms are purely strewn with golden sand. The surrounding stairs and paths are composed of gold, silver, lapis lazuli, and crystal. Above are pavilions, also adorned with gold, silver, lapis lazuli, crystal, conch, red pearls, and agate. The lotuses in the pools are as large as carriage wheels, blue with blue light, yellow with yellow light, red with red light, white with white light—subtle, wondrous, fragrant, and pure.

Again, Sariputra, in that Buddha-land heavenly music is constantly played, and gold is the ground. Throughout the six periods of day and night, mandarava flowers rain down. The beings of that land, often at dawn, each with their robes gather many wondrous flowers to make offerings to the Buddhas of ten trillion other lands.

Regarding those birds, the Buddha specially reminds not to misunderstand:

Sariputra, do not say that these birds are truly born of karmic retribution. Why? In that Buddha-land there are no three evil realms. Sariputra, in that Buddha-land there is not even the name of the three evil realms, much less their reality. These birds are all transformation-made by Amitabha Buddha so that the sound of Dharma may flow forth.

Then the two great characteristics of the Land of Ultimate Bliss are pointed out:

Sariputra, that Buddha's light is immeasurable, illuminating the lands of the ten directions without obstruction; therefore he is called Amitabha. Again, Sariputra, that Buddha's lifespan, and that of his people, is

immeasurable and boundless asankhyeya kalpas; therefore he is called Amitabha.

Sariputra, that Buddha-land has accomplished such merit and adornment.

Finally, it comes down to the general principle of rebirth:

Sariputra, one cannot be reborn in that land by meager roots of virtue, merit, and favorable conditions. Sariputra, if there be a good man or good woman who, having heard of Amitabha Buddha, holds fast to his name for one day, two days, three days, four days, five days, six days, or seven days with unwavering one-pointed mind—at the end of that person's life, Amitabha Buddha and the holy assembly will appear before them. At the end of life, with mind unconfused, that person is immediately reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss of Amitabha Buddha.

In the Infinite Life Sutra, the majestic descriptions of the Land of Ultimate Bliss's 'environmental retribution' (the surroundings) and 'personal retribution' (the bodily form of beings) are mainly concentrated in the following sections; excerpts of the original scripture text are as follows:

Adornment of the Environment: The Beauty of the Land of Ultimate Bliss

1. The Foundation of the Land: Vast, Level, and Even, with Gold for Ground

The ground of the Land of Ultimate Bliss is flat and vast, without rugged mountains or rivers, and its substance is incomparably precious.

The Buddha said to Ananda: That world of Ultimate Bliss possesses measureless merit and is fully adorned. Forever there is no name for the many sufferings, the various calamities, the evil realms, or mara-afflictions. Nor are there the distinctions of the four seasons, cold and heat, or rain and gloom. Again there are no great or small rivers and seas, hills and pits, thorns and gravel, Iron Enclosure, Mount Sumeru, earthen or stony mountains. Only by nature the seven jewels, with gold as the ground, vast, level, and even, beyond all limit, subtle, wondrous, and beautiful, pure and majestic, surpassing all worlds of the ten directions.

2. Adornment of the Jeweled Trees: Composed of the Seven Jewels, Radiant with Flowing Light

Throughout the land are trees naturally formed of various precious jewels, extremely splendid.

Moreover, in that land the seven-jewel trees fill the whole world. Gold trees, silver trees, lapis lazuli trees... some are formed of two jewels, three jewels, up to the seven jewels turning and combining. The roots, stems, branches, and trunks are formed of one jewel; the flowers, leaves, and fruits are transformed from another jewel. Or there are jeweled trees with gold for roots, silver for trunk, lapis lazuli for branches, crystal for tips, amber for leaves, fine jade for flowers, and agate for fruits. The remaining trees likewise have their jewels turning into one another. Row upon row face each other, branch to branch correspond, leaf to leaf match.

3. Palaces and Pavilions: Transformed from the Seven Jewels, of Whatever Size One Wishes

The places of dwelling are also formed of many jewels and can manifest according to the minds of beings.

The dwellings, palaces, and pavilions, according to their form and color, in height, lowness, bigness, and smallness—whether of one jewel, two jewels, up to measureless many jewels—appear at the thought in accord with whatever one wishes. Again, wondrous robes of many jewels are spread over the ground, and all devas and humans tread upon them as they walk.

4. Adornment of the Empty Sky: Jeweled Nets Spread Over, Jeweled Bells Ringing in Harmony

The empty sky is covered with nets strung of precious jewels, hung all around with bells, extremely majestic and beautiful.

Measureless jeweled nets spread over the Buddha-land, all made of golden thread, true pearls, and hundreds of thousands of varied jewels, wondrous, rare, and strange, adorned and decorated. On all four sides hang jeweled bells, their light and color dazzling, supremely majestic and beautiful.

Adornment of the Personal Retribution: The Wondrous Bodily Form of Beings in the Land of Ultimate Bliss

1. The Body Is Supremely Excellent: Subtle and Wondrous Countenance, Neither Deva nor Human

The appearance of those reborn is majestic, surpassing the world, and the qualities of their bodily form are extraordinary.

Those sravakas, bodhisattvas, devas, and humans... all are of one class, with no differing forms.... Their faces are upright and proper, surpassing the world and rare. Their countenance is subtle and wondrous, neither deva nor human; all receive the natural 'empty-and-nonbeing body' and the 'boundless substance.'

Note: 'The empty-and-nonbeing body and the boundless substance' refers to the body born by lotus transformation, pure and ethereal, needing no food or drink, and with immeasurable and boundless lifespan.

2. The Body Is Uniform: All of One Class, No Different from the Buddha

All those reborn have bodily forms identical to Amitabha Buddha, with no distinction of beauty or ugliness.

In that Land of Ultimate Bliss, all beings have subtle and wondrous countenance, surpassing the world and rare. All are of one class, without marks of difference.... All are born by lotus transformation, with bodies of true golden color and the thirty-two marks... This is the fulfillment of the 'all bodies golden vow,' the 'thirty-two marks vow,' and the 'no-difference-in-body vow.'

The sutra uses a layered progression of similes—a beggar, an emperor, a wheel-turning sage king, up to the Heavenly King of the Sixth Heaven—to show supremely that the light, countenance, and appearance of beings in the Land of Ultimate Bliss surpass [them] beyond measure, unattainable even by trillions of times.

3. Complete Enjoyment and Use: Appearing at the Thought, Nothing Lacking

Not only is the bodily form majestic, but all the enjoyments of daily life are as one wishes, perfect and complete.

All beings... have upright and dignified form, measureless merit and virtue, clear wisdom, and unobstructed spiritual powers. They enjoy all manner of things, fully supplied. Palaces, robes, incense flowers, banners, and adornment articles—whatever they need, all come as in thought.

When one wishes to eat, seven-jewel bowls naturally appear before one, filled with the food of a hundred flavors... one merely sees the color and smells the fragrance, taking it as food with the mind; the body's strength increases without excrement or filth, the body and mind are soft and pliant, and one clings to no taste.

Summary

The sutra many times praises the environmental and personal retribution of the Land of Ultimate Bliss overall as 'surpassing the world and rare.' In the environment, it is a pure land with gold for ground, jeweled trees, and jeweled nets spread over it; in the personal retribution, it is the ethereal body of one uniform class, with true golden body and the thirty-two marks, and with enjoyments complete and appearing at the thought, lacking

nothing in body or mind.

(4) The Rebirth Aspiration Verses (Upadesa) and Its Commentary: The Aspiration Text for Seeking Rebirth in the Pure Land

The Rebirth Aspiration Verses of the Infinite Life Sutra (Upadesa) was composed by Bodhisattva Vasubandhu and translated by Bodhiruci of the Yuan-Wei dynasty. In verse form it summarizes the aspiration to seek rebirth in the Pure Land, and is a propagation work of the Infinite Life Sutra. Its opening four lines point out taking refuge and arousing the vow:

World-Honored One, with one mind I / take refuge in the Ten Directions all, / the Tathagata of Unobstructed Light, / and vow to be reborn in the Land of Peace and Joy. / Relying on the sutras, / the true mark of merit and virtue, / I speak aspiration verses as a summary, / in accord with the Buddha's teaching.

The verses depict the majesty of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, of which the most central lines are:

Contemplate the marks of that world: / it surpasses the path of the three realms. / Ultimately like empty space, / vast and without boundary. / The right path of great compassion, / born of the supramundane roots of goodness.

Forever free of bodily and mental affliction, / enjoying bliss constantly without interval. / The realm of Mahayana roots of goodness, / equal, with no name for blame or fault— / women, and those with deficient faculties, / and the two-vehicle seeds are not born there. / Whatever beings wish and rejoice in, / all can be fulfilled.

The final two lines gather the aspiration of the whole work:

In whatever world there is none, / the jewel of Buddha-Dharma merit— / I vow to be reborn in all of them, / showing the Buddha-Dharma like the Buddha. / I compose this treatise of verses, / vowing to see Buddha Amitabha, / together universally with all beings, / be reborn in the Land of Peace and Joy.

The commentary on these verses (Bodhiruci's Commentary on the Rebirth Aspiration Verses of the Infinite Life Sutra) thereupon opens the 'Five Gates of Recollection,' which is the most practical operational framework of the Pure Land teaching—Buddha-recitation is not a single action, but five complete practices:

First, the Gate of Prostration: with the body's action, prostrate to Amitabha Tathagata, the Perfectly Enlightened One of Right and Universal Knowledge, with the intent of being reborn in that land.

Second, the Gate of Praise: with the mouth's action, praise and call the name of that Tathagata, in accord with that Tathagata's mark of radiant wisdom, and in accord with that name's meaning, so as to correspond with true practice.

Third, the Gate of Vow-Making: the mind constantly makes the vow, single-mindedly and exclusively mindful, finally to be reborn in the Land of Peace and Joy, so as to correspond with true practice of samatha (calm-abiding).

Fourth, the Gate of Contemplation: with wisdom contemplate, with right mindfulness observe that [land], so as to correspond with true practice of vipasyana (insight). There are three kinds of contemplation: one, contemplating the merit of adornment of that Buddha-land; two, contemplating the merit of adornment of Amitabha Buddha; three, contemplating the merit of adornment of those bodhisattvas.

Fifth, the Gate of Dedication: not abandoning all beings in affliction and suffering, the mind constantly makes the vow, with dedication as foremost, so as to accomplish the great compassionate mind.

The sequence of the Five Gates of Recollection is a complete cultivation path: prostration (body) → praise (speech) → vow-making (mind) → contemplation (wisdom) → dedication (compassion). The first three gates establish confidence and vow-power; the fourth gate develops wisdom; the fifth gate directs all merit toward benefiting others. Great Master Shandao said that if one accomplishes the practice of these Five Gates of Recollection, 'one will finally be reborn in the Land of Peace and Joy and see that Amitabha Buddha.'

The Commentary on the Aspiration Verses lists seventeen kinds of merit-achievements regarding the adornment of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, each corresponding to a line of the verse; among them the 'merit-achievement of fulfilling all that is sought' is the most crucial:

Whatever beings wish and rejoice in, all can be fulfilled. Therefore I vow to be reborn there, in the land of Amitabha Buddha.

The Treatise on Rebirth (full title: The Rebirth Aspiration Verses of the Infinite Life Sutra) gives an extremely rigorous and orderly description of the environmental and personal adornment of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, summarizing the Pure Land's adornment into three categories and twenty-nine kinds. Unlike the Infinite Life Sutra's style of broadly listing particulars, Bodhisattva Vasubandhu uses the wisdom of the 'gate of contemplation' to gather the immeasurable adornments into cultivable and realizable items, finally returning to the 'one Dharma-phrase,' namely the unconditioned Dharmakaya of pure wisdom.

Adornment of the Environment: Purity of the Material World, Seventeen Kinds in All

This is the contemplation of the environment of the Land of Ultimate Bliss, unfolding layer by layer from overall purity to specific enjoyments:

• 1. Merit-achievement of Adornment and Purity: the general mark—'Contemplate the marks of that world: it surpasses the path of the three realms.' The Land of Ultimate Bliss as a whole transcends the leaky three-realm samsara.

• 2. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Magnitude: 'Ultimately like empty space, vast and without boundary.' The land is vast and boundless, able to contain measureless beings without a sense of cramping.

• 3. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Nature: 'The right path of great compassion, born of the supramundane roots of goodness.' Its essence arises from great compassion and supramundane roots of goodness.

• 4. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Form and Mark: 'Filled with pure light, like the mirror, sun, and moon discs.' The land's form and marks are made of pure light, perfect like bright mirrors, the sun, and the moon.

• 5. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Various Things: 'Endowed with the nature of all jewels, complete with wondrous adornment.' All things are compounded of many precious jewels, as one wishes, complete with wondrous majesty.

• 6. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Wondrous Color: 'The flawless light-flame blazes, bright and pure, illuminating the world.' The color and light are blazing, able to reflect inside and outside, brightening and purifying the world.

• 7. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Touch: 'The grass of jewel-nature merit, soft, turning left and right; whoever touches it gives rise to supreme joy, surpassing the kacchinda (softest) grass.' The things touched are soft, able to make the toucher give rise to supreme Dharma-joy.

• 8. Merit-achievement of Adornment of the Three Kinds: divided into water, earth, and empty sky. Water: 'Jeweled flowers of thousands of kinds, covering the pools, streams, and springs...'; earth: 'Palaces and pavilions, contemplating the ten directions without obstruction...'; empty sky: 'Measureless jewels interwoven,

nets filling the empty sky, various bells emitting sound, proclaiming and uttering the wondrous Dharma-sound.'

• 9. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Rain: 'Raining flowers and robes as adornment, measureless fragrance pervading.' The sky naturally rains down wondrous flowers and heavenly robes, fragrance pervading everywhere.

• 10. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Light: 'The Buddha's wisdom, the bright pure sun, removes the world's foolish darkness.' The Buddha's wisdom-light can dispel beings' foolish darkness.

• 11. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Wondrous Sound: 'The Brahma-sound awakens the profound and distant, subtle and wondrous heard in the ten directions.' With pure Brahma-voice it proclaims the wondrous Dharma, enabling hearers to awaken to profound principle.

• 12. Merit-achievement of Adornment of the Lord: 'The rightly awakened Amitabha, the Dharma King who well upholds.' Amitabha Buddha is the Dharma King, who skillfully upholds the land and receives beings.

• 13. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Retinue: 'The Tathagata's pure lotus assembly, born from the lotus of right awakening.' All beings are born by transformation from the lotus of Amitabha Buddha's right awakening, as the Buddha's retinue.

• 14. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Enjoyment: 'Loving the flavor of the Buddha-Dharma, taking the samadhi of meditative bliss as food.' One does not eat material food, but takes the samadhi of Dharma-joy as food.

• 15. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Freedom from All Calamities: 'Forever free of bodily and mental affliction, enjoying bliss constantly without interval.' Forever free of all bodily and mental sorrow, the bliss enjoyed is without interruption.

• 16. Merit-achievement of Adornment of the Great Meaning Gate: 'The realm of Mahayana roots of goodness, equal, with no name for blame or fault—women, and those with deficient faculties, and the two-vehicle seeds are not born there.' In the land there is equality and one mark; not even the blameworthy names 'women,' 'faculty-deficient,' or 'two-vehicle' are heard.

• 17. Merit-achievement of Adornment of Fulfilling All That Is Sought: 'Whatever beings wish and rejoice in, all can be fulfilled.' Whatever beings wish in accord with Dharma, all can be obtained and fulfilled.

Adornment of the Personal Retribution: Purity of the World of Beings, Twelve Kinds in All

The personal retribution is divided into two categories—Amitabha Buddha and the bodhisattvas of the Land of Ultimate Bliss—twelve kinds in all.

The Eight Adornments of Amitabha Buddha

• Merit of the Seat: contemplate the majesty of the lotus jewel-seat upon which Amitabha Buddha sits.

• Merit of the Body's Action: the Buddha's bodily action is pure, with marks, excellences, and light.

• Merit of the Speech's Action: the Buddha's verbal action is pure, with Brahma-voice profound and far-reaching.

• Merit of the Mind's Action: the Buddha's mental action is pure, with wisdom and compassion.

• Merit of the Great Assembly: the Buddha is surrounded by the pure great ocean assembly.

• Merit of the Leaders: Avalokitesvara, Mahasthamaprapta, and other great bodhisattvas as leaders.

• Merit of the Lord: Amitabha Buddha is the Dharma King, freely upholding.

• Merit of Upholding Without False Action: the Buddha's vow-power is real and unfalse, able to make those who see, hear, recollect, or touch him swiftly fulfill merit.

The Four Adornments of the Bodhisattvas of the Land of Ultimate Bliss

These four can also be summarized as the bodhisattvas' 'true practice,' carrying out the Buddha's work in the worlds of the ten directions:

• The Virtue of Unmoving Responsive Transformation: unmoving like the great earth, yet able to respond and transform in the ten directions.

• The Virtue of Simultaneously Pervading: able at the same time to pervade all Buddha-lands of the ten directions, making offerings to the Buddhas.

• The Virtue of Unomitted Offering and Praise: offering and praising the Buddhas of the ten directions without omission.

• The Virtue of Universally Revealing the Three Jewels: in places where the Buddha-Dharma is absent, manifesting and upholding the Three Jewels, and expounding the Buddha-Dharma.

The unique value of the Treatise on Rebirth lies in that it finally points these adornments toward the 'real wisdom and unconditioned Dharmakaya,' transforming Pure Land contemplation into inner wisdom cultivation—which complements the style of the Infinite Life Sutra that emphasizes faith, joy, and vow to be reborn.

(5) The Essence of the Four Commentaries on the Contemplation Sutra: How Great Master Shandao Judges and Arranges the Pure Land Teaching

The Four Commentaries on the Contemplation Sutra (full title: The Commentary on the Sutra of Contemplation of the Buddha of Immeasurable Life Spoken by the Buddha), compiled by Great Master Shandao of the Tang dynasty, is divided into four sections—the Profound Meaning, the Meaning of the Preface, the Proper Meaning, and the Meaning of Transmission—and is the authoritative reader for the Pure Land school's explanation of the Contemplation Sutra. The most crucial of its judgments and arrangements have always been required reading for Pure Land students.

The master's opening passage explains why he composed this commentary: 'The true suchness is vast; the five vehicles cannot fathom its edge; the Dharma-nature is deep and high; the ten sages cannot exhaust its limit.' Buddhist principle is too deep; the gradual cultivation of ordinary beings is hard to accord with, so one must rely on the Buddha's skillful guidance—this is why the Contemplation Sutra uses the sixteen contemplations, gradually gathering [beings]. The Pure Land teaching does not teach people to become bodhisattvas, but teaches beings of the Dharma-ending age first to seek rebirth in the Pure Land and cultivate there.

1. Proper Practice and Mixed Practice: What Is the True Method of Cultivation

Great Master Shandao clearly divides cultivation into two categories; this distinction is the core criterion of the Pure Land teaching:

Now there are two kinds of practice: one is proper practice, the other is mixed practice. What is proper practice? It is exclusively relying on the sutras of rebirth to practice—what is it? Single-mindedly and exclusively reading and reciting this Contemplation Sutra, the Amitabha Sutra, the Infinite Life Sutra, and so on; single-mindedly focusing the thought on contemplating, observing, recollecting the twofold adornment of that land. If

prostrating, then single-mindedly and exclusively prostrate to that Buddha; if calling with the mouth, then single-mindedly and exclusively call that Buddha's name; if praising and making offerings, then single-mindedly and exclusively praise and make offerings—this is called proper.

Within proper practice there is again a further division into two levels; this is the most crucial step:

Within this proper practice there are again two kinds. First, single-mindedly and exclusively reciting the name of Amitabha Buddha, whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, regardless of time long or short, never parting with the thought—this is called the karma of definite confirmation, because it accords with that Buddha's vow. If one relies on prostration, recitation, etc., this is called the auxiliary karma. Apart from these two kinds of proper and auxiliary practice, all other good deeds are collectively called mixed practice.

The karma of definite confirmation: single-mindedly and exclusively reciting the name of Amitabha Buddha, without interruption whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, regardless of time long or short. This is the proper within the proper.

Auxiliary karma: prostrating to the Buddha, reciting sutras, making offerings, praising—these are good deeds in themselves, but can only serve as assisting conditions, not as the main force.

Mixed practice: all good deeds outside proper practice. Done, they too can be dedicated toward rebirth, but the merit is thin and easily interrupted by miscellaneous matters.

The master then explains the temporal difference between the two:

If one cultivates the former proper and auxiliary two practices, the mind constantly abides near, recollecting without ceasing—this is called uninterrupted. If one practices the latter mixed practice, the mind is constantly interrupted; although one may dedicate [it] and be reborn, it is collectively called the distant-and-mixed practice.

The weight of this passage is extreme. 'Single-mindedly and exclusively reciting the name, whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, regardless of time long or short, never parting with the thought'—the karma of definite confirmation has no fixed schedule and no fixed form; one recites while working, walking, and eating. Those who do mixed practice have minds constantly interrupted, and good deeds are hard to sustain. This does not mean mixed practice cannot lead to rebirth—the master clearly says 'although one may dedicate [it] and be reborn'—but that the strength differs. This is the true meaning of the two words 'exclusive cultivation' in the Pure Land teaching.

2. Exclusive Cultivation and Mixed Cultivation: Why the Pure Land Emphasizes 'Exclusivity'

Great Master Shandao does not shy from stating that the Pure Land teaching has a distinction between 'exclusive cultivation' and 'mixed cultivation.' One who exclusively cultivates, among the three classes of upper, middle, and lower, relies on the above conduct—this is called exclusive cultivation; one who mixedly cultivates, concurrently practices the six perfections, dedication, and other karmas—this is called mixed cultivation. He specifically established for exclusive cultivators the framework of the 'five gates of upper conduct and upper rebirth':

All who wish to enter that land have three classes. The upper class: renouncing home and desire to become a monk, arousing the bodhicitta, always exclusively reciting Amitabha Buddha, cultivating various merits, and vowing to be reborn in that land. The middle class: although unable to become a monk or greatly cultivate merit, should arouse the mind of supreme bodhi, always exclusively reciting Amitabha Buddha, and cultivate some good. The lower class: even if unable to cultivate various merits, should arouse the mind of supreme

bodhi, always exclusively reciting Amitabha Buddha, not cultivating precepts, not studying scriptures.

Note this line about the lower class—'not cultivating precepts, not studying scriptures.' This is what Great Master Shandao, based on the lowest of the lowest grade of the Contemplation Sutra, taught: even one who commits the five grave offenses and the ten evils, fully possessed of all that is unwholesome, so long as at the end of life can 'with full ten invocations call Namo Amitabha Buddha,' is still reborn.

The reason Great Master Shandao repeatedly discriminates 'exclusive cultivation' is not to elevate Buddha-recitation, but to solve a practical problem: those who mixedly cultivate, though their good deeds are many, are greedy for the world, for fame, profit, and family, and cannot 'settle the one mind with determination.' The Pure Land teaching is called the 'hard-to-believe Dharma'; the difficulty lies precisely in that you must truly settle your mind. Exclusive cultivation does not disdain that you do much, but fears that you do it mixedly and your mind is not exclusive.

3. Self-Power and Other-Power: The Fundamental Principle of the Pure Land Teaching

This is the most critical point in all of Great Master Shandao's judgments and arrangements. He said that all good and evil ordinary beings who attain rebirth without exception all ride the great vow and karma-power of Amitabha Buddha as the supreme condition:

Like a person who, fearing the three bad paths, receives and upholds the precepts; because of receiving and upholding the precepts, can cultivate dhyana concentration; because of dhyana concentration, cultivates spiritual powers; because of spiritual powers, can roam the four continents. This and the like is called self-power. Again, like an inferior man who cannot even mount a donkey; riding with the wheel-turning king, he then travels through the empty sky and roams the four continents without obstruction. This and the like is called other-power. How foolish—later students, hearing that other-power can be ridden, should give rise to faith and not confine themselves to their own portion.

This analogy could not be clearer: self-power is walking by oneself (upholding precepts to gain concentration, concentration to gain spiritual powers, climbing up step by step by oneself); other-power is catching the tailwind of one who has accomplished (an inferior man cannot mount a donkey, but following the wheel-turning king, he can roam the four continents through the empty sky). The Pure Land teaching wants the latter—not relying on one's own cultivation to stand up, but boarding the great ship of Amitabha Buddha. The master's final line, 'How foolish—later students, hearing that other-power can be ridden, should give rise to faith and not confine themselves to their own portion,' is extremely weighty in tone: do not think little of yourself.

4. The Two Rivers and the White Path: An Analogy Everyone Can Understand

To protect practitioners' faith, Great Master Shandao devised an extremely apt analogy—one anyone can understand:

It is like a person wishing to travel west a hundred thousand li, who suddenly in the middle of the road sees two rivers: one is a river of fire to the south, the other a river of water to the north; each river is a hundred paces wide and bottomlessly deep. North and south are boundless; right between the water and fire there is a white path, about four or five inches wide. This path runs from the east bank to the west bank, also a hundred paces long. The water's waves cross over and wet the path, and the flames also come to burn the path; water and fire intersect, never ceasing.

This person, having reached a desolate open place with no people, and many bands of thieves and fierce beasts seeing him alone, competingly come to kill him. Frightened of death, he runs straight west, when suddenly he

sees this great river, and thinks to himself: 'These rivers, south and north, have no visible edge; in the middle I see a white path extremely narrow; though the two banks are near, how can one pass? Today I am surely doomed.' Just as he is about to turn back, the bands of thieves and fierce beasts gradually close in; just as he is about to flee north or south, the fierce beasts and poisonous insects competingly come at him; just as he is about to seek the path and go west, he again fears falling into these two rivers of water and fire.

Right at this point of being unable to advance or retreat, from both banks voices call out at once:

From the east bank he suddenly hears a voice urging: 'Virtuous one, just resolutely follow this path; there is certainly no deadly peril. If you stay, you die.' And from the west bank a voice calls: 'You, with one mind and right recollection, come straight; I can protect you, so do not fear falling into the peril of water and fire.'

This person, having heard this sending-off and that calling, then rightly settles body and mind, resolutely follows the path straight forward, and gives rise to no doubt, fear, or retreating mind. Having gone one or two tenths, the thieves and others on the east bank call: 'Virtuous one, come back; this path is perilous and evil, you certainly cannot pass, surely you will die; we have no evil intent toward you.' Although this person hears the calling, he does not look back, but with one mind goes straight forward, mindful of the path as he walks; in a moment he reaches the west bank, forever free of all perils. Meeting good friends, he rejoices without end.

After reading this passage, one only needs to match the analogy:

East bank = the Saha burning house; west bank = the treasure land of Ultimate Bliss.

The two rivers of water and fire = beings' greed and attachment like water, and hatred and aversion like fire, the two warring ceaselessly.

The white path in the middle (four or five inches wide) = the pure vow to be reborn that can arise amid greed and hatred afflictions.

The water waves constantly wet the path = the mind of attachment constantly arises, soaking and rotting the white path; the flames burn the path = the fire of hatred scorches.

The bands of thieves and fierce beasts = the six sense faculties, six consciousnesses, and six sense objects, the five aggregates and four great elements; commonly seen are 'false-friend' evil companions who constantly follow people.

The calling voices from both banks = the Buddha and good spiritual friends. The key point is: this practitioner 'though hearing the calling, does not look back'—not swayed by the thieves' false show of affection.

The most wondrous part of this analogy is that the white path is only four or five inches wide. It is not a broad road, but a thread of life; at any moment soaked by water or burned by fire, at any moment it may break. Therefore one can only 'resolve,' 'with one mind,' and 'go straight forward'—one cannot be of two minds, cannot look left and right, cannot stop and wait. The practice of Buddha-recitation is precisely walking this narrow path.

5. Dharma Master Tanluan's 'Tethering Grass to Lead the Ox': Why One Must Settle on One Place

Great Master Shandao, in the Four Commentaries, specially sets up a question, recounting the story of Dharma Master Tanluan of the Northern Wei. Tanluan practiced the Pure Land daily, and someone challenged him: 'All Buddha-lands in the ten directions are pure lands; why does the master fix his mind solely on the West? Is this not the arising of a one-sided view?' Dharma Master Tanluan's answer was plain yet hit the vital point:

'I am an ordinary being, with shallow and brief wisdom, not yet entered into the stages; my mindful power must be even. It is like tethering grass to lead the ox—one must always tie the mind to the trough. How can one let it roam free, with nothing to return to?'

When leading an ox along, the rope must be tied to the trough; it is fine for the ox to graze on grass, but the ox must always have a place to return to. Mindful power is the same: one need not watch it tightly at every moment, but one absolutely cannot be without any support.

The master then wrote: Although the objectors were many and varied, the Dharma Master alone was resolute. Therefore, regardless of whether monk or lay, whoever met the Dharma Master, if not yet born of right faith, he urged them to give rise to faith; if already born of right faith, he urged them all to return to the Pure Land. When the Dharma Master was at the end of life, the monks and laypeople to the left and right of the monastery all saw banners and flowers reflected in the courtyard, smelled the wondrous fragrance, and heard music welcoming him, and thus he was reborn [in the Pure Land].

This passage is a rare 'documentary testimony' in the Four Commentaries. It shows that the Pure Land teaching has not only rational proof (the fifteen kinds of skillful means, the three classes and nine grades) but also factual proof—when Dharma Master Tanluan, relying on this method, was reborn, the whole monastery personally saw banners and flowers reflected in the courtyard and smelled the wondrous fragrance and heard music. Rational proof persuades people; factual proof steadies them.

6. Explaining the Sutra's Name: The Six-Character Sanskrit-Chinese Translation of 'Namo Amitabha Buddha'

Great Master Shandao explains the sutra title character by character, speaking very finely on the six characters of 'Namo Amitabha Buddha':

'As for the words Namo Amitabha Buddha, they are also the correct sound of the Western lands. Further, nan means taking refuge, mo means life, a means without, mi means measure, tuo means lifespan, fo means awakening. Therefore it is said: take refuge in the life of immeasurable lifespan and awakening. This is the Sanskrit-Chinese correspondence, and the meaning is thus. Now, "immeasurable lifespan" is the Dharma, and "awakening" is the person. Person and Dharma both manifest, therefore it is named Amitabha Buddha.'

Therefore the literal translation of the six characters 'Namo Amitabha Buddha' is 'take refuge in the life of immeasurable lifespan and awakening'—taking refuge is not enthroning oneself; the awakening of immeasurable lifespan is not one's own accomplishment. The entire import rests on these two phrases.

(6) The Essence of the Ten Essentials of the Pure Land: The Patriarchs Through the Ages on the Ten Essentials of the Pure Land

The Ten Essentials of the Pure Land was an anthology of Pure Land scriptures compiled by Great Master Ouyi of the Ming dynasty, collecting ten treatises from the Sui to the Ming dynasties; each of the ten has its own emphasis, and together they form a complete outline of the Pure Land teaching. Below are selected those most relevant to the theme of this section.

1. Yin Guang's 'Preface to the Publication': Why the Pure Land Teaching Can Pervasively Embrace Beings of the Dharma-ending Age

Great Master Yin Guang, in his preface to the Ten Essentials of the Pure Land, from the very beginning makes clear the position of the Pure Land within the whole of Buddhist teaching:

'All the Dharma gates spoken by the Tathagata in his one lifetime of teaching, although differing as great or small, sudden or gradual, provisional or real, partial or complete, are none other than causing all beings to return home by the road and restore their original mind-nature.'

This line sets the tone: the eighty-four thousand Dharma gates are all the same road—returning to the original mind-nature. The Pure Land is not another road, but the most labor-saving segment of that same road. But he then turns the point, explaining the fundamental difference between the Pure Land and the self-power Dharma gates:

Note: In the passage below in this preface, Yin Guang points out that all other methods 'must rely on self-power cultivation, cutting off delusion to realize the true'; only the Pure Land teaching 'relies solely on the Buddha's vow,' and thus can enable beings of the Dharma-ending age to 'transverse-cross by relying on the Buddha's power' without waiting until their own practice is accomplished. This is the basis for the Pure Land being called 'the easy path among the hard-to-practice paths.'

This passage can be seen as the general outline of the whole book: there is only one road in the Buddha-Dharma (returning home by the road), but the way of walking it has hard and easy. The self-power Dharma gates require one to cut off delusion and realize the true by oneself; the Pure Land teaching can transverse-cross by borrowing the Buddha's vow-power. Therefore it is not an opportunism, but a shortcut opened by the Buddha.

2. Ouyi's 'Essential Commentary on the Amitabha Sutra': The Five Essentials for Reading the Sutra

At the end of the Ming, Great Master Ouyi composed the Essential Commentary on the Amitabha Sutra, establishing the 'Five Essentials' method for reading sutras, which is the sequential order for reading Pure Land scriptures:

First, explaining the name. This sutra is named after the speaker and the spoken-of person. The Buddha is the teaching lord who speaks in this land, namely Sakyamuni. Riding the great compassionate vow-power, he was born in the five turbid evil world. He who, by his own prior awakening, awakens those who come after—there is nothing he does not know, nothing he does not see.

Second, discerning the substance. All Mahayana sutras take the true suchness as their proper substance. Our present mind-nature of a single thought is not within, not without, not in the middle. It is not past, not present, not future.

Third, clarifying the tenet. The tenet is the essential path of cultivation, the pivot that unites with the substance, and the program of all practices. Raise the outline and the many eyes open; grasp the collar and the lapels and sleeves follow. Therefore after the substance one must discern the tenet. This sutra takes faith, vow, and holding the name as the essential tenet of cultivation.

Fourth, clarifying the function and use. This sutra takes rebirth and non-retrogression as its function and use. There are four lands of rebirth, each discussed in nine grades.

Fifth, the teaching's character. This is included in the Mahayana Bodhisattva store. It is also spoken without being asked, blessed by thorough great compassion, able to let beings of the Dharma-ending age with many obstacles, relying on this, directly ascend to non-retrogression. Therefore when in the future the sutras and the Dharma perish, this sutra is specially left to remain in the world for a hundred years, broadly saving beings.

Among the Five Essentials, the third, 'clarifying the tenet,' is most crucial: Great Master Ouyi defines the essential path of the whole sutra as the three words 'faith, vow, and holding the name.' Faith is believing; vow is

arousing the vow to be reborn; holding the name is grasping the Buddha's name. These three words mutually confirm the 'Five Gates of Recollection' of the Commentary on the Aspiration Verses above—the Five Gates of Recollection are the unfolding sequence, while faith, vow, and holding the name are the condensed program.

'Only faith can enter' is the threshold of the Pure Land gate. Great Master Ouyi speaks plainly: the Pure Land teaching is not sitting in meditation, investigating Chan, or attaining awakening; it is faith, vow, and holding the name. Having believed, vowed, and held the name, one is on this ship; there is no need to first realize some awakening.

3. The Treatise on Ten Doubts and the Pure Land or Questions: Is It All Right to Recite Only at the End of Life?

This is the most frequently asked question in the Pure Land gate, and also the easiest to go wrong on. The Pure Land or Questions (by the Yuan-dynasty Tianru Weize) contains a question aimed precisely at this:

Question: 'One who creates evil all life, recites the Buddha at the end of life, and is reborn with karma, with no retrogression. This Buddha Amitabha's vow-power is truly inconceivable. Then may I, during my life, just do worldly endeavors, and only recite the Buddha at the end of life—is that acceptable?'

Behind this question is a very common thought: I should enjoy what this life offers and do what needs doing, and only recite the Buddha at the end of life; that is not too late, right? Master Tianru's answer is stern word by word:

Answer: 'How bitter, how bitter. What an ignorant and absurd statement. Arsenic and poisoned wine are the deadliest of poisons. Your words now are more poisonous than arsenic and poisoned wine.'

He then says that the consequence of speaking thus is not only to mislead oneself:

'Not only do you cheat yourself, but you also cheat all good men and good women, monk or lay, under heaven.'

The reason Master Tianru sharply rebukes is that everyone who says 'recite only at the end of life' thinks the last five minutes are enough, so no one truly cultivates. The Pure Land teaching precisely opposes this kind of luck-seeking.

Then the question arises: if that one thought at the end of life is so crucial, why does the Contemplation Sutra's lowest of the lowest grade say 'afflicted and with no leisure to recite,' yet can still be reborn? The Ten Doubts on the Pure Land (by Zhiyi of the Sui) answers this question:

'Again it is said: a single thought of Buddha-recitation extinguishes eighty billion kalpas of the karma of birth and death. Because at the time of reciting the Buddha the mind is fierce and sharp, it suppresses and extinguishes evil karma and definitely attains rebirth—there is no need to doubt.'

The key lies in the three characters 'the mind is fierce and sharp.'

'Again, you take the evil karma from beginningless time as heavy, and the ten thoughts at the end of life as light. Now, by principle, there are three ways to weigh the light and heavy, which are not fixed by length of time or amount. What are the three? First is in the mind, second is in the condition, third is in determination.'

That is to say: the weight of a single thought does not lie in the length of time, but in whether that thought has a fierce and sharp mind, meets the condition, and makes the determination. Therefore:

Reciting regularly, the thought at the end of life comes prepared, naturally with fierce and sharp mind, complete condition, and sincere determination—this is the most stable.

Not reciting regularly, at the end of life one is confused and scattered by the affliction of illness; whether that one thought can be 'determined'—this is precisely the worry.

Therefore the conclusion is not 'cannot recite at the end of life,' but 'must recite regularly, and the end of life is only the cashing of the final thought.'

(7) The Commentary and Notes on the Amitabha Sutra: Holding the Name Is the Path Within the Path

'The path within the path for cultivating practice' has two meanings:

First, other gates for learning the Way are a myriad li distant; Buddha-recitation for rebirth, the ancients called the shortcut path. Yet the method of Buddha-recitation itself has many gates; now this holding of the name is the shortest within the shortcut path. Like a crane ascending or a peng soaring, a fine steed galloping or a dragon flying—without hastening yet arriving, it is the path within the path.

The second meaning: one is comparing among the various pure-land practices, the other is distinguishing within this root sutra the Larger Sutra; hence it is called the path of the path. The shortcut path means a small and swift road. 'Small' metaphorically means the ease of the power of Buddha-recitation; 'swift' metaphorically means the rapidity of Buddha-recitation's success—as Great Master Shandao's verse says, 'There is only the shortcut path for cultivation; just recite Amitabha Buddha'—this is it.

Therefore it is said: other gates for learning the Way are called 'vertically exiting the three realms'; Buddha-recitation for rebirth is called 'horizontally exiting the three realms.' Like a worm in bamboo, vertically it must pass each node with difficulty; horizontally it breaks through at once. Compared with other gates, Buddha-recitation is faster!

That Buddha-recitation has many gates: as the four kinds of Buddha-recitation by true suchness opened later in the text, up to dedicating all practices, etc.

Although the Buddha of true suchness is said to be originally possessed, beings have heavy obstructions, and few understand and awaken.

Below these several gates: contemplating the image—then the image leaves and becomes nothing, causing interruption; contemplating the thought—the mind is coarse and the object subtle, the wondrous contemplation hard to accomplish; all practices—the doing is many and varied, with a tendency to topple at the heavy points; only this one method of holding the name is simple, concise, direct, and immediate—just able to continue reciting and one gains rebirth.

The ancients said: 'Once you have seen Amitabha, why worry about not awakening?' Thus without aiming for true suchness, one accords with true suchness.

Therefore Buddha-recitation is the shortcut path of cultivation, and holding the name is the shortcut within Buddha-recitation.

The crane's ascent already surpasses common birds, yet how can it match the peng's soaring; the fine steed's gallop surpasses the herd of horses, yet does not reach the dragon's flight. All the upper [images] metaphorically refer to Buddha-recitation, the lower to holding the name in Buddha-recitation.

'Without hastening, without moving': the Appended Remarks of the Book of Changes says, 'Change has no thought, no action; quiescent and unmoving, yet upon being stirred it penetrates the causes of all under heaven; unless one is of the utmost spirituality, who can attain to this?' Only the spiritual, without hastening yet swift,

without moving yet arriving—meaning that which hastens then is swift, and moves then arrives, is the common way of things.

The substance of the milfoil and hexagram is quiescent, with no thought or action, yet upon being stirred it penetrates—this is without hastening yet swift, without moving yet arriving, wondrously moving all things and called spiritual.

This is cited to make clear that the various gates of Buddha-recitation, though all called rebirth, require somewhat harder effort and somewhat longer time—they need movement and need hastening, and only then arrive swift. Now this [holding the name] requires no counting of months and years, borrows no complex doing; with seven days of one-pointed mind, one is immediately reborn in that land—how spiritually wondrous it is to this degree.

Therefore the Commentary Notes on the Chapter of Universal Worthy's Vows says: Among the several hundred volumes of the great canon, whether sutras or treatises, all speak of cultivating its cause, yet all require diligent accumulation to attain rebirth. Now merely calling the name, one ascends to non-retrogression—is this not the shortcut upon the shortcut?

The summary of this passage:

Among all methods of cultivation, Buddha-recitation for rebirth is already a shortcut; and among the various methods of Buddha-recitation, holding the name (simply reciting 'Amitabha Buddha') is the simplest and most direct, hence called 'the path within the path.'

The specific meaning:

1. Other Dharma gates are hard and slow to cultivate, called 'vertically exiting the three realms,' like a worm in a bamboo tube biting upward node by node, hard to pass through; Buddha-recitation for rebirth is 'horizontally exiting the three realms,' like drilling out the side of the bamboo tube and escaping at once—therefore Buddha-recitation is the shortcut.

2. Buddha-recitation itself has many kinds: Buddha-recitation by true suchness, by contemplating the image, by contemplating the thought, by dedicating all practices, etc. But for ordinary people, some have heavy obstructions and are hard to awaken, some are easily interrupted, some have objects too subtle to accomplish the contemplation, some do too much and too mixed. Only holding the name is the simplest and most direct—just able to continue reciting and one gains rebirth.

3. Therefore the ancient worthies said: 'Once you have seen Amitabha, why worry about not awakening?' Although holding the name does not specially cultivate true suchness, it naturally accords with and enters true suchness.

4. 'The crane's ascent and the peng's soaring, the fine steed's gallop and the dragon's flight' is an analogy: just as the crane flies high yet cannot match the great peng, and the thousand-li horse runs fast yet cannot match the dragon's flight, other Buddha-recitation methods already surpass ordinary Dharma gates, but holding the name surpasses them even more.

5. Other Buddha-recitation methods, though they too can attain rebirth, require somewhat harder effort and somewhat longer time; holding the name requires no long years, relies on no complex contrivance—with seven days of one-pointed mind, one is reborn, extremely spiritually wondrous.

6. The Commentary Notes on the Chapter of Universal Worthy's Vows also says: many sutras and treatises in the great canon speak of rebirth and all require diligent accumulation of merit and virtue; now merely calling

the name, one ascends to non-retrogression—is this not the 'shortcut upon the shortcut'?

Therefore, the core of this passage is: holding the name is the shortcut upon the shortcut—the simplest, most secure, and fastest to accomplish.

(8) The Benefits of Reciting 'Namo Amitabha Buddha'

Premise: truly believe, and be willing to be reborn in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss, and hold the Buddha's name.

Benefits in the Present Life, Here and Now

1. Eliminating karma: The Amitayurdhyana Sutra says that calling Amitabha Buddha's name can extinguish eighty billion kalpas of heavy karma of birth and death, purify the mind, and reduce affliction, anxiety, and hatred.

2. The Buddha's light illumines and protects: Amitabha Buddha's light constantly shines on those who recite the Buddha, receiving and never abandoning them, protecting them day and night, so that evil ghosts and evil spirits cannot harass them at will.

3. Inner peace, reduced fear, and calmness in facing events; peaceful sleep with more auspicious dreams.

4. Protected by all Buddhas of the ten directions: The Amitabha Sutra teaches that those who exclusively cultivate this Dharma gate are protected and remembered by all Buddhas, and on the path of cultivation it is not easy to lose the resolve for the Way.

5. Roots of goodness and merit gradually grow; it is easy to give rise to compassion and be gentle toward others.

The Greatest Benefit at the End of Life (the Core of the Pure Land)

At the end of life, Amitabha Buddha, together with Avalokitesvara, Mahasthamaprapta, and other holy beings, comes to receive and guide; the mind is not confused or panicked, and one is reborn in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss.

After arriving in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, one forever leaves the six-realm samsara, free of the sufferings of birth, old age, sickness, and death, and continues cultivation in the pure land until becoming a Buddha.

Supplement: Reciting the Buddha is not asking that worldly affairs go smoothly, with no disaster or difficulty, but that the mind has a refuge, karma-obstacles are gradually transformed, and the ultimate goal is liberation from birth and death.

(9) The Twenty-Five Bodhisattvas Who Protect Those Who Recite the Buddha (from the Sutra Spoken by the Buddha on the Ten Rebirths in the Land of Amitabha Buddha)

The Two Core Bodhisattvas:

Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara and Bodhisattva Mahasthamaprapta (the two great attendant bodhisattvas at the side of Amitabha Buddha in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, the most important)

The Other Twenty-Three:

Bodhisattva Medicine King, Bodhisattva Medicine Superior, Bodhisattva Samantabhadra, Bodhisattva Manjusri, Bodhisattva Lion's Roar, Bodhisattva Dharani, Bodhisattva Akasagarbha, Bodhisattva Virtue Store,

Bodhisattva Treasure Store, Bodhisattva Gold Store, Bodhisattva Vajra, Bodhisattva Mountain-Sea Wisdom, Bodhisattva Light King, Bodhisattva Flower Adornment King, Bodhisattva Many Treasures King, Bodhisattva Moonlight King, Bodhisattva Sunlight King, Bodhisattva Samadhi King, Bodhisattva Freedom King, Bodhisattva Great Freedom King, Bodhisattva White Elephant King, Bodhisattva Great Majestic Virtue King, Bodhisattva Boundless Body.

Original text: 'If there are such people as these, from now on I shall constantly cause the twenty-five bodhisattvas to protect and uphold this person. Constantly let this person be free of illness and affliction. Whether human or non-human, none can take advantage. Whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, day or night, always at peace.' 'If beings deeply believe this sutra, recite Amitabha Buddha, and vow to be reborn, that Amitabha Buddha of the Land of Ultimate Bliss will thereupon dispatch Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara, Bodhisattva Mahasthamaprapta, Bodhisattva Medicine King, Bodhisattva Medicine Superior, Bodhisattva Samantabhadra, Bodhisattva Manjusri, Bodhisattva Lion's Roar, Bodhisattva Dharani, Bodhisattva Akasagarbha, Bodhisattva Virtue Store, Bodhisattva Treasure Store, Bodhisattva Gold Store, Bodhisattva Vajra, Bodhisattva Mountain-Sea Wisdom, Bodhisattva Light King, Bodhisattva Flower Adornment King, Bodhisattva Many Treasures King, Bodhisattva Moonlight King, Bodhisattva Sunlight King, Bodhisattva Samadhi King, Bodhisattva Freedom King, Bodhisattva Great Freedom King, Bodhisattva White Elephant King, Bodhisattva Great Majestic Virtue King, and Bodhisattva Boundless Body—these twenty-five bodhisattvas protect the practitioner. Whether walking or dwelling, sitting or lying, by day or by night, at all times and in all places, they do not let evil ghosts or evil spirits take advantage.' (Sutra Spoken by the Buddha on the Ten Rebirths in the Land of Amitabha Buddha)

The general meaning of the sutra:

So long as one deeply believes and recites Amitabha Buddha, wishing to seek rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss, these twenty-five bodhisattvas follow and protect day and night, whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, protecting at every moment, freeing the practitioner from illness and affliction, and not allowing humans or non-humans (such as ghosts and spirits) to harm [them].

Apart from these twenty-five bodhisattvas, the various devas and protective Dharma spirits also protect together.

Core: Amitabha Buddha is the principal honored one; Avalokitesvara and Mahasthamaprapta are the most important protecting bodhisattvas, with the twenty-five great bodhisattvas constantly following and protecting.

Reciting the Buddha in the present life can quiet the mind, dispel afflictions, and be embraced by the protection of the Buddhas and bodhisattvas; the ultimate merit is reception and rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss at the end of life, leaving samsara.

III. An Overview of the Five Vehicles of Dharma (Human, Heavenly, Sravaka, Pratyekabuddha, Bodhisattva)

The Buddha spoke the Dharma for forty-nine years in over three thousand assemblies, its content touching many issues of society and human life. All the Dharma spoken by the Buddha can be divided by content into the 'Five Vehicles of Dharma,' also called the 'three scopes of beings.' 'Vehicle' means a conveyance, referring to the vehicle that can carry beings from the shore of birth and death to the other shore.

'Dharma has no high or low; what suits the capacity is wondrous.' The Buddha was skilled at observing capacities and teaching accordingly, prescribing medicine for the illness, establishing the eighty-four thousand

Dharma gates; yet 'skillful means have many doors, but the return to the source has no two roads'—all Buddha-Dharma is the good medicine that cures the physical and mental illnesses of beings. Precisely because beings' faculties are sharp or dull, the Buddha had no choice but to open provisional and real teachings, with differences of earlier and later sequence.

First, the Human Vehicle: taking refuge in the Three Jewels of Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha and upholding the five precepts as the vehicle, one can leave the four realms of hell, hungry ghost, animal, and asura and be born in the human realm; hence it is named the human vehicle. The three refuges mean taking refuge in the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha, relying on the blessing, power, and protection of the Three Jewels' merit to be far from fear; the five precepts are no killing, no stealing, no sexual misconduct, no false speech, and no intoxicants.

Second, the Heavenly Vehicle: taking the superior ten wholesome deeds and the four dhyanas and eight samadhis as the vehicle, carrying beings across the four continents to the heavenly realm. The ten wholesome deeds are: in body, no killing, no stealing, no sexual misconduct; in speech, no false speech, no divisive speech, no frivolous speech, no harsh speech; in mind, no greed, no hatred, no wrong views—collectively called the ten wholesome deeds path. Simultaneously cultivating dhyana concentration, namely the concentration of the desire realm as well as the four dhyanas of the form realm and the four formless samadhis of the formless realm, collectively called the four dhyanas and eight samadhis.

Third, the Sravaka Vehicle: taking the Dharma gate of the Four Noble Truths as the vehicle, carrying beings across the three realms to reach the remainder nirvana and become arhats. The four noble truths are suffering, accumulation, extinction, and the path; 'truth' means reality. The four truths are the four real and unfailing suchnesses of the universe and human life, which only the noble ones can deeply realize with certainty and no doubt.

Fourth, the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle: taking the Dharma gate of the twelve links of dependent origination as the vehicle, carrying beings across the three realms to reach the nirvana without remainder and become pratyekabuddhas. The definition of dependent origination is 'this being, that is; this arising, that arises; this not being, that is not; this ceasing, that ceases,' explaining that the existence of all dharmas is mutually dependent and conditioned, arising from causes and conditions. The birth-and-death revolving of sentient beings does not escape this dependent-origination Dharma. The pratyekabuddha is sharper in faculty than the sravaka, needing not hear the Dharma, but by merely observing the twelve links of dependent origination can awaken by self-power.

Fifth, the Bodhisattva Vehicle: taking the Dharma gate of compassion-wisdom and the six perfections as the vehicle, carrying beings to transcend the three realms and the three-vehicle sphere altogether, to the other shore of the unexcelled bodhi and great nirvana. The six perfections are giving, precept-keeping, patience, vigor, dhyana, and prajna. The bodhisattva not only seeks his own liberation, but further arouses the great bodhicitta to save all beings, actively cultivates the six perfections, and vows to be a horse or ox for beings, vowing to pull out beings' suffering and give them happiness.

The Five Vehicles of Dharma form a staircase structure; the lower vehicle is the inevitable step to mount the higher, like elementary, middle, high school, master's, and doctoral students, ascending in sequence. Together they are the 'three scopes of beings': those who do not seek liberation from the suffering of worldly samsara but only seek present or future benefit and joy are the 'lower scope,' namely the human and heavenly vehicles; those who strongly pursue personal liberation, seeking to leave the suffering of worldly revolving samsara, are the 'middle scope,' namely the sravaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles; those who not only seek their own liberation but also vow to universally save beings are the 'upper scope,' namely the bodhisattva vehicle.

The human and heavenly vehicles are attached to the world; the sravaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles are world-renouncing; the bodhisattva vehicle is engaged in the world without attachment to it, and world-renouncing without being solely concerned with self. The Five Vehicles of Dharma take the human and heavenly vehicles as the foundation, advancing step by step into the Mahayana and directly reaching the Buddha vehicle; therefore the human and heavenly vehicles are the first step of the Buddha vehicle, and the Buddha's true intent in appearing in the world is mainly to transform beings from the human vehicle directly into the Buddha vehicle. If the practitioner cultivates progressively according to the Five Vehicles of Dharma, he will certainly realize the same true-suchness Dharmakaya as the Buddha.

The Buddha-Dharma of the human and heavenly vehicles emphasizes the aspiration to accumulate worldly merit and virtue, satisfied with present and future joy—this is Buddhism's teaching shared with the world; the Buddha-Dharma of the sravaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles emphasizes the renunciant mind of world-transcending liberation, with the joy of nirvana liberation as the final goal; the Buddha-Dharma of the bodhisattva vehicle emphasizes the bodhicitta of benefiting others and saving the world, with the ultimate compassion-wisdom joy as the pinnacle of cultivation, and the six perfections and myriad practices as the concrete practice for benefiting others and saving the world.

Each of us holds a winning lottery ticket; this ticket is the benefit Amitabha Buddha gives us. If you do not redeem it, it will expire; if you try to redeem it, you may gain an unexpected reward. This ticket requires no money to buy—you only need to redeem it, needing no capital at all.